

Hist 310 The Rise and Fall of the Soviet Union

Numbered Transcript

HIST 310 • Michael Malice

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Lecture 1: Revolution and Disillusion

At a glance — Malice traces revolution and disillusion in the run-up to and aftermath of 1917.

- 1.1 The year was 1875, and in the air in America, there was this call to revolution. It would be the end of the trilogy that began with the Revolutionary War, which overthrew the forces of aristocracy, the Civil War, which put an end to slavery forever, and now the forces of labor were going to overthrow capitalism and install a society more equitable, based on the workers and their needs. There was a group in Chicago, specifically, that called themselves the Educational and Defense Society. They had the guns, they had the will, and they practiced their militia in order to overthrow the government and to install this prophesied revolution.
- 1.2 The Illinois legislature passed a law in 1879 banning private militias. This went all the way up to the Supreme Court. And in the 1886 *Presser v. Illinois* decision, it was determined that states do have the rights to organize and license militias, and that the Second Amendment only applied to Congress, not to state legislatures. Some of the very earliest restrictions on gun rights were used by the right against the left. But if they could not have militias, they could have other mechanisms.
- 1.3 There was a scientist named Christian Schönbein, and he had discovered that by mixing nitric acid and sulfuric acid, he could come upon a new compound, something called nitroglycerin. It was highly explosive. It took the work of Alfred Nobel to create a fulminating blasting cap and mixing that nitroglycerin with diatomaceous earth to create a new substance, dynamite. Nobel's vision was that dynamite would help miners. Instead of having to spend hours doing back-breaking work in the mines, they could explode the rocks and extract the minerals so much more easily. But other people had other ideas. If dynamite could be so effective against rocks deep in the Earth, imagine what it could do to human beings.
- 1.4 It was the German-born anarchist Johann Most, who published a pamphlet called *The Science of Revolutionary Warfare*. In what was an enormously questionable first speech concern, this pamphlet taught people how to make explosives from the safety of their own home. Mass violence had now become democratized. This dynamite held a clarion call to young radicals who now felt empowered to impose or implement their vision of a more just and equitable world.
- 1.5 As one anarchist writer later put it, "When free speech is suppressed, when men are jailed for asking for food, clubbed for assembling to discuss their grievances, and stoned for expressing their opinions, there is but one recourse, violence. The ruling class has guns, bullets, bayonets, police, jails, militias, armies, and navies. To oppose all this, the worker has only dynamite." Incidentally, the author of this piece later became a biology professor at NYU, although it is highly questionable what the faculty knew of his youthful, let's just say, indiscretions.

- 1.6 As Johann Most put it, "Once we are in error when things are really happening, it would be stupid to consider amateur dynamite production. Dynamite factories and explosive warehouses can be seized just like anything else." The momentum was in the air. Laws were passed, mandating eight-hour days, but they were overthrown or poorly implemented. The Industrial Revolution plowed on, and many people got very, very rich, while many others stayed very, very poor, unable to feed their own families. It seemed to be a gross injustice that so few should have so much while so many should have so little.
- 1.7 On May 1st, 1886, the first May Day, a national strike was organized and around 350,000 workers demanded shorter hours. On May 4th, three days after that, a rally was held in Chicago's Haymarket Square. Estimates for how many people attended varied from several hundred to several thousand. What is in dispute is that the rally was a peaceful one. No one from the stage called for violence or started babbling about dynamite. They were advocating for workers' rights, for organizing, for working together as unions, to try to get better conditions for themselves and their families. The mayor personally came. He saw the situation, so everything was fine, and then he left.
- 1.8 At around 10:30 PM, in complete violation of the First Amendment, the police inspector ordered the crowd to disperse in the name of the law. That is when somebody threw a bomb. To this day, we don't know who threw that bomb or why, but what we do know is that many people were killed, including several police officers. That meant that somebody had to pay. These comments in the air about dynamite and violence had now gone from being theoretical to being practical and resulting in mass death. Eight men were arrested as a result of these events, several of whom had not even been in attendance. They were being put on trial simply because they had espoused anarchist views, some of whom had never espoused violence, but all would be judged as a group.
- 1.9 They were all found guilty, one of whom was given a 15-year sentence, while the others were sentenced to hang. It was a decision largely without precedent, certainly in American soil. They appealed to the Supreme Court, they appealed to the governor, but no one was interested in letting them off. The one who would have the greatest impact historically was the young man by the name of Louis Lingg. It's crazy to look at this picture and realize this is someone from the 1800s because he looks like he stepped out of an Abercrombie ad. In fact, the police chief who arrested him talked about how visitors came to the jail just to look upon. Let me see the exact words.
- 1.10 "Many callers came to sympathize with Linng, as well as to admire his handsome physique." This is from the police captain who arrested him. And Lingg was brought before the judge, as were the others. Like a caged animal, he snarled before the judge and told the court, explicitly, "I tell you frankly and openly, I am for force. I am the enemy of the order of today, and as long as breath remains in me, I shall combat it. I declare again, frankly and openly, that I'm in favor of using force. Perhaps you think,

you'll throw no more bombs, but let me assure you, I die happy on the gallows. So confident am I that the hundreds and thousands to whom I've spoken will remember my words, and when you shall have hanged us, then, mark my words, they shall do the bomb-throwing. In this hope, do I say to you, I despise you, I despise your order, your laws, your force-propped authority. Hang me for it."

- 1.11 But they would never have the opportunity to hang Louis Linng. Somehow or other, historically it remains unclear, someone had managed to smuggle a blasting cap into the prison, and from his jail cell, he managed to blow off half his face. His jaw, what was left of it was left hanging, his tongue sticking out, his teeth were gone. In his death throes, he managed to write on the wall of his cell with his own blood, "Hoch die Anarchie!" Hooray for anarchy. The other men, two of them, asked for clemency. They were granted it, but four of the others refused to bend the knee, and they were brought to the gallows.
- 1.12 Adolph Fischer, George Engel, August Spies, and Albert Parsons. "This is the happiest moment of my life," Adolph Fischer said, right before the hangman pulled the lever and sent him to his grave. There are several versions of August Spies' last words, but the one that is enshrined on the monument that was built to these men several years after their death in Chicago reads, "The day will come when our silence will be more powerful than the voices you are throttling today." They were posthumously pardoned, but of course, that did them little good. You can still see that monument, by the way, today in the cemetery in which they're buried.
- 1.13 Two of the people that were inspired by these men, one of them was a young woman by the name of Emma Goldman, who was born in the Russian Empire. She emigrated to the United States. As she put in her own words, "I devoured every line in anarchism I could get. Every word about the men, their lives, their work. I read about the heroic stand while on trial, their marvelous defense. I saw a new world opening before me." In a way, Louis Linng was what Che Guevara is meant to be and supposed to be, this young revolutionary who inspired so many in the call of revolutionary violence.
- 1.14 The first day she was in New York, she met a young man named Alexander Berkman, and the two of them became partners in crime for the rest of their lives, both literally and figuratively. It seemed that this worker's revolution, which had been so prophesied by Marx and others, was just moments away from starting. What would be the spark that would set it off? Well, the young Berkman and Goldman decided that they would be the ones to do it, and history gave them an engraved invitation.
- 1.15 In 1892, there was a strike at the Homestead Steelworks, which were eight miles to the east of Pittsburgh, run by Andrew Carnegie, and his right-hand man, Henry Clay Frick. The workers were on strike, negotiating not even for a raise, not even for the same pay, but they were fighting a pay cut, even as Carnegie was making bundles upon bundles of profits. Henry Clay Frick, who was the chairman of Carnegie Steel, had a new and innovative idea. He simply fired them all and shut down the factory. They were no

longer workers, so they were not in a position to negotiate at all. He said he would be happy to negotiate with them on an individual basis.

- 1.16** He brought in replacement workers. You couldn't even call them scabs because, technically, the union was no longer working at the works. He began to fortify the works, making it into even more of a warlike atmosphere. Then he hired a bunch of private security, including the notorious Pinkertons. A barge full of Frick's men came up the river to attend to the workers who were camped outside. And history doesn't record who shot first. But if you read history books, it'll always say something like, "inevitably, shots were fired." Well, perhaps it is inevitable, but it's really important to know who shot first, and that is something we don't know. What we do know is that many people were killed, one young boy was injured, and things were escalating at a rapid rate, and no one knew what to do about it.
- 1.17** The militia was called on July 18th. The town was put under martial law. Politicians reached out to Frick, trying to get him to compromise, but he dug in his heels. With the loss of men's lives, Carnegie, who was hardly some sort of crazy anti-union capitalist, dug in his heels as well. He telegraphed Frick with his decision, and as he put it, "Never employ one of these riders. Let grass grow over the works. I'd rather lose this factory than deal with any of these men."
- 1.18** This enormously inspired Goldman and Berkman. This was their opportunity. This was the clearest example of capitalist oppression of the workers. If they took out Frick, they would be the heroes that would set off the revolution. Everyone would clap, and they would be, in a sense, these messiahs who would bring in this new wave and set off this new class warfare. They tried to build a bomb, but even with Johann Most's book, it's a lot harder to build a bomb at home than you might think. I do not encourage anyone listening to this to do so. They're like, "All right, we could do it old school." Berkman got a gun, he got a knife, and he made his way down to Frick's office.
- 1.19** Berkman broke into the office. He shot Frick. The first bullet hit Frick in the ear. He fired again, hitting Frick in the neck. Frick and the vice-chairman of Carnegie Steel, who was both in the office, began to wrestle Berkman. It was a loud office. People charged in. They tried to wrestle him down. Berkman pulled out his knife and began to stab Frick, and then he was tackled and subdued. Frick never lost consciousness. He refused anesthesia, and he would not bend the knee. Before he even left for the hospital, Frick left basically a press release. "This incident will not change the attitude of the Carnegie Steel Company towards the Amalgamated Association," meaning the workers. "I do not think I shall die. But whether I do or not, the company will pursue the same policy and it will win."
- 1.20** And he was absolutely correct. The assassination completely failed. Frick regained his health entirely. If anything happened as a result of this, people only had sympathy for Frick. Instead of killing Frick, Berkman humanized him and made a martyr out of him without him even having to die. Even the members of the union shook their heads,

knowing that this made them look bad because their whole argument was, "We're just trying to get more food for our families. We're not violent thugs like the capitalists are." Even Johann Most condemned Alexander Berkman, perhaps out of jealousy. As he put it, "Berkman is my enemy. He is no good. I hate him as much as I hate Frick, and Frick is the Tsar of America."

- 1.21 Berkman was 21 years old and was sentenced to 21 years in jail. His life effectively was already almost over, and he had nothing to show for it. The Homestead strike was a complete disaster for the workers. They voted to return to work on Frick's terms. The union went from 24,000 members in four years, down to 8,000 members, a drop of two-thirds. Frick went on to live a long and happy life. To this day, you can visit the museum of his art collection in New York City, where it is known as the Frick.
- 1.22 Goldman was left alone, trying to agitate the workers. She would give speeches. She would have jobs under assumed names, often as a nurse. When she would tell the workers, "Go to the capitalists and ask for work. If they don't give you work, ask for bread. If they don't give you bread, take bread. You do not have a responsibility to starve when so many people have so much and you're just trying to feed your family." Of all the people who heard Emma Goldman speak, there was one who goes down history for perhaps not so positive reasons, a young man with the unpronounceable name of Leon Czolgosz. In 1901, he went up to Buffalo, New York, at the Pan-American Exhibition, where President William McKinley was shaking hands with patriotic Americans. He pulled out his rifle and shot the President at point-blank range.
- 1.23 When he was arrested, Czolgosz said, "What started the craze to kill was a lecture I heard some little time ago by Emma Goldman. Her doctrine that all rulers should be exterminated was what set me to thinking, so that my head nearly split with the pain. Miss Goldman's words went right through me, and when I left the lecture, I had made up my mind that I would have to do something heroic for the cause I loved." It took McKinley a week to die, and Emma Goldman was on the lam. In fact, she had met Czolgosz before, but he was such a weirdo that most of the anarchists who met him wondered if he was a fed because he was acting crazy, crazy by anarchist standards, mind you. So she was right to be suspicious, but now, think about this.
- 1.24 The President's on his deathbed. The assassin, or would-be assassin, blames you. You're Emma Goldman. You're on the run. What do you do? Eventually, she was arrested by someone named Captain Hermann Schlueter, the very same man who had earlier arrested Louis Linng. When asked her thoughts, she said that, of Czolgosz, "I felt the man is one of those unfortunates who have been driven by despair and misery to commit the deed. I feel deeply with him as an individual, as I would feel with anybody who suffers."
- 1.25 Here are some of her other quotes. "I'm not in a position to say who ought to be killed." She said, "What I don't see is why they would make more fuss about a president than anybody else. All men are born equal." She said, if she had the means, she would

help Czolgosz as much as she could. She would see that he had counsel, that justice was done him. And of McKinley, she said, "Other presidents have had heart or something, but this poor fellow, God forgive him, since he knows nothing, is a tool in the hands of the wealthy." As for the police, she said, "They're making more anarchists than the most prominent people connected with the anarchist cause could make in 10 years. If they would only continue, I should be very grateful. They'll save me lots of work."

- 1.26** Imagine this. You've just been arrested because the president's would-be assassin said it was your idea. And Emma Goldman's response is, "I'd help the assassin. McKinley is a fool. P.S. Fuck the police." To say that she was the most hated woman in America is something that is a bit of an understatement. But there was nothing the police could do. They felt that there was this idea that, if someone is in a position to kill the President, because McKinley did succumb to his wounds, there surely had to be some kind of big organization behind it, but there wasn't.
- 1.27** As a result of this, McKinley's successor, Teddy Roosevelt, launched a full-scale assault on anarchism in as much as he could, as President of the United States, saying that "the anarchist is more dangerous than any other criminal because he represents the same depravity in a greater degree." And he prophesied that, "if anarchy is triumphant, its triumph will last for one but red moment, to be succeeded for ages by the gloomy night of despotism." And he said that anarchism is worse than piracy and the slave trade. "It is a far blacker infamy than either."
- 1.28** In 1903, President Roosevelt signed the Anarchist Exclusion Act, banning people from immigrating to the United States if they were beggars, epileptics, or anarchists. "They and those like them should be kept out of this country, and if found here, they should be promptly deported to the country whence they came." This makes me a little nervous, but come and find me.
- 1.29** Let's go back to Alexander Berkman. By 1906, 14 years after prison, he was released and now a free man. Goldman had been publishing a journal called Mother Earth, promoting anarchism and associated causes. And by 1916, Woodrow Wilson was running for re-election. His slogan as the Great War was tormenting Europe was, "He kept us out of war." And he barely beat his opponent, Charles Evans Hughes, New York governor, and became the first sitting Democrat to be re-elected President since the Civil War. In March 1917, Woodrow Wilson was sworn in. On April 2nd, 1917, he asked for and received a Declaration of War from Congress and officially entered the US into World War I. He kept us out of war for one month into his second term.
- 1.30** Now, during the Great War, Germany had two fronts. She had to deal with her Western front, from Western Europe, and the Eastern front from the Tsar and the forces of Russia. General Ludendorff of Germany was a very smart and very crafty man, and he knew that warfare could be managed by several different means. And that gave him an idea. There was someone by the name of Vladimir Lenin. At the time, Lenin was regarded as a complete lunatic and a kook. His vision of this Bolshevik Communist

dictatorship was something regarded as both utopian and ridiculous and impossible. But he would have made a great troublemaker.

- 1.31** In 1905, Lenin had taken part in an attempt to overthrow the Tsar, and as a result, had been exiled from Russia. Ludendorff had the idea, let's take Lenin out of exile, send him back where he came from, to Russia, and have him cause trouble there. The more trouble the Tsar has to deal with, the less of a problem the Tsar is going to be on German's Eastern front. Very famously, Lénin was put in a sealed train car with his associates from Zurich, Switzerland, and he made his way all the way around, taking a ferry to Sweden, then to Finland, and then back to the Russian Empire after eight days.
- 1.32** Two months later, on June 15th, 1917, Woodrow Wilson signed the Espionage Act of 1917, which made it a felony to interfere with the draft. In 1916, keeping us out of war was a winning slogan. In 1917, working to keep us out of war was a felony. The very same day that the Espionage Act was put into law, Goldman and Berkman were arrested, their office seized, and the authorities found a list with the contact info of every anarchist and anarchist sympathizer. Bail was set for each at \$25,000, an insane amount of money back in 1917.
- 1.33** Further, the government retroactively repealed the citizenship of Goldman's teenage husband, which had granted her citizenship. And since he was no longer a citizen, therefore she was no longer a citizen as well. And the pair were sentenced to two years in jail. They were not alone. Very famously, Eugene V. Debs, who had been the socialist presidential candidate, was also in jail for opposing the Great War.
- 1.34** And then the impossible happened. Lenin and his right-hand Man, Trotsky, had done great work convincing many in the military to buy into his ideology. They persuade enough the population that they controlled a majority of the Petrograd Soviet, which was one of the workers' councils that was trying to transition Russia into a working democracy. And on October 24th, 1917, things came to a head. Lenin and Trotsky's forces seized control of Petrograd, and they declared themselves the new government.
- 1.35** As journalist John Reid called it, "It was 10 days that shook the world." As Berkman wrote, "Without exaggeration, I may say that the happiest day of my existence was passed in a prison cell, the day when the first news of the October Revolution and the victory of the Bolshevik reached me in the Atlanta federal penitentiary." The Russian Civil War had begun. What's important to understand is this Bolshevik vision, this Communist vision, was supposed to be scientific socialism. This was a new society based on the idea that the experts would plan everything centrally, that what had happened before was accidents of history. Now that we had science and we had technology, we could run a society based on scientific principles, as opposed to these vague principles of the market and having some greengrocer make decisions for the rest of us.

- 1.36 In fact, everything was on the table. By 1918, the Bolshevik's code on marriage, the family, and guardianship envisioned a withering away of the family itself, because preferring your own children to other children was inequality. Since it was unfair that some parents would be better than others—this is something that few people dispute—why not have professional educators educate all the children collectively so no one unfairly has a better head start than anyone else? In fact, anything that was old-school or bourgeois, which was their slur of the moment, was regarded with suspicion. Marriage, very bourgeois idea.
- 1.37 In fact, it got down to the point when the communists began to question biology itself, when they spoke of creating a new Soviet man, they meant so literally. In fact, one writer mused that, "We don't know whether during communism, emotions will disappear, whether a human being will change to such an extent that he will become a luminous globe consisting of a head and brain only, or whether new and transformed emotions will come into being." They would change everything, including having a new calendar, because again, everything was on the table in this new era of science. As one writer later put it, "I had been to the future, and it worked."
- 1.38 Just weeks after seizing power on December 19th, 1917, Lenin issued a decree to form what he called an extraordinary commission for combating counterrevolution and sabotage, popularly known as the Cheka, the secret police. Their job was to persecute and to break up all acts of counterrevolution and sabotage all over Russia. And since the revolution was regarded as the Bolshevik government itself, opposition to it could therefore claim to be in itself sabotage. As the head of the Cheka publicly stated, "We stand for organized terror. This should be frankly admitted. The Cheka is obligated to defend the revolution and conquer the enemy, even if its sword does by chance sometimes fall upon the heads of the innocent." This was an organization external to and superior to the law.
- 1.39 Now, in order to consolidate his power and to make sure that the revolution wasn't going anywhere, Lenin wanted to get out of the Great War as quickly as possible, something that General Ludendorff never hoped for, perhaps, in his wildest dreams. It wasn't just the Bolsheviks who were in power, there were the Mensheviks. Now, in Russia, "bolshe" means greater or more, "menshiy" means lesser. The Mensheviks wanted things to be implemented slowly. The Bolsheviks wanted quick revolution as fast as possible. There were other groups like the Social Revolutionists, the left SRs, who are an agrarian party. They're more democratic socialists. Then there were the anarchists, who believed in these local workers' councils, the Soviets. When people speak of the Soviet Union, they're referring to the workers' councils which supposedly ran everything, but in practice, ran nothing.
- 1.40 In December 1917, Lenin sent his right-hand man, Trotsky, to meet with the Germans. Lenin told him, "String out the talks until there's a revolution in Germany, or as long as possible." Because the idea was, and has been prophesied, once the revolution takes

place in one country, the workers throughout the world are going to overthrow their chains, and this is going to be a worldwide phenomenon. If you just wait it out, things are going to resolve themselves. This was the German counter-offer. You can get out of the war, but we keep whatever we're currently in occupation of, meaning Poland, Lithuania, and most of western Ukraine. Lenin didn't know what to do. He's barely in office. If he goes back to his people and says, "Listen, we can cut a deal where we're losing an enormous amount of territory," it's going to look very badly for us.

- 1.41** Then General Hoffmann offered an ultimatum. The Russians had one day to sign this treaty or else Germany would invade. This was Trotsky's response. He said, "Russia is going to leave the war, but we're not signing a treaty." Bye. The Germans didn't know what to do. This is not how things are done. The Russians just tried to run out the clock. The Germans threatened again. Russians dawdled. In late February, they invaded and captured more territory in three days than they had in the previous three years combined. Soon, capturing Petrograd itself was on the table. If that happened, it really would be the end of the Russian Revolution, if not Russia herself.
- 1.42** Finally, Lenin convinced his comrades that they needed to sign the treaty, and they also had to give up the Baltic states, Finland, nearly all of Ukraine, several ports. In short, about a third of their best agricultural land, half their industry, and 89% of their coal mines, in addition to an indemnity of 120 million gold rubles. It was a huge humiliation. And one of his comrades said to him, "If we had 500 courageous men in Petrograd, we should put you in prison." He said that to Lenin. Lenin said, "Some people may indeed go to prison after this, but if you calculate the probabilities, you'll see it is much more likely that I'll send you than that you will send me." And indeed, this did firmly establish Lenin as the head of Russia.
- 1.43** On August 30th, 1918, Lenin was the victim of an assassination attempt. A young woman managed to shoot him three times, giving him injuries from which he would never recover. And this gave him the cover to unleash what was known as the Red Terror. As one newspaper at the time put it, "We will turn our hearts into steel, which we will temper in the fire of suffering and the blood of fighters for freedom. We will make our hearts cruel, hard, immovable, so that no mercy will enter them, so that they will not quiver at the sight of a sea of enemy blood. Without mercy, without sparing, we will kill our enemies in scores of hundreds. Let them be thousands. Let them drown themselves in their own blood."
- 1.44** Terror and class warfare became official state policy. The Weekly Cheka, the newspaper, opined, "Enough of this long, sterile, and vain talk about Red Terror. It is time, while it is not late yet, to carry out, by deed and not in word, a ruthless and strictly organized mass terror." In fact, concepts like individualism were old-school. This was the new scientific society so that, in case guilty people are not turned over to the authorities, one person out of 10 will be shot irrespective of whether he's guilty or not.

- 1.45 Meanwhile, the United States, as the US further entered the Great War, the Socialist Party in Philadelphia printed and mailed out flyers to young people under the heading of "Long live the Constitution of the United States." They pointed out that the 13th Amendment made involuntary servitude illegal in the United States, and that when you conscript and compel a man to go abroad, to fight against his will, you violate the most secret right of personal liberty, meaning the draft was a form of slavery and grossly unconstitutional.
- 1.46 This was a mild example of free speech, of political speech, and of course, it resulted in arrests. The case went all the way up to the Supreme Court, and unanimously, the Court, Republicans and Democrats alike, upheld the Espionage Act, and Judge Oliver Wendell Holmes said words that resonate to this day. "The most stringent protection of free speech would not protect a man in falsely shouting fire in a theater and causing a panic."
- 1.47 It's the type of legal gymnastics that only a brilliant jurist could come up with with a straight face. To begin with, you can't yell anything in a theater at any time. It is private property. Number two, if you're releasing a flyer that says, "Don't go to war, this is against the Constitution," this is advocating against violence, not for it. We're all told to this day that the First Amendment protects anything. It protects the right of free political speech. Yet that was exactly what was made a felony at this time. If you hear ever people talk about you can't yell fire in a crowded movie theater, this is where they're getting it from. An idea that you can't argue against the draft during in a time of war, without even telling people to defy the draft. Just telling people that the draft in and of itself is unconstitutional.
- 1.48 Radicals began to be deported from the United States in line with the laws that Teddy Roosevelt had passed. Then, as earlier prophesied, the workers had dynamite. In April 1919, 30 letter bombs were mailed out to various powerful people in the United States. The others were intercepted, and one detonated, blowing up the hands of a sender's housekeeper and his wife's teeth. On June 2nd, nine bombs were detonated across eight cities. Most concernedly was the one meant for the attorney general, Mitchell Palmer. It detonated prematurely in front of his townhouse in Washington, DC. The explosive took out the young anarchist carrier. Then across the street, the Assistant Secretary of the Navy, FDR, and his wife, Eleanor Roosevelt, witnessed the aftermath, including a piece of the bomber's body landing on their doorstep. This would not be the only time in his life that FDR would know what it's like to look at a useless leg.
- 1.49 The attorney general took this matter very seriously, understandably so, and he put a young Justice Department lawyer named J. Edgar Hoover in charge of a series of Palmer Raids to investigate these radicals that infiltrated the United States. Berkman and Goldman were arrested, along with many others, and then they were deported. On what was called the Red Ark, on December 21st, 1919, 250 radicals were deported to Russia. Get your commie ass back where it came from. Now, the two of them were very

optimistic. Berkman said that landing in Russia was "the most sublime day of my life. Thus, my pious old forefathers must have felt first entering the Holy of Holies." He felt a strong desire to kneel down and kiss the ground.

- 1.50** They would try to make the best of what they had. This was their opportunity to take part in the workers' revolution and bring it forth to its conclusion. A nation of equity, peace, free speech, and food for everyone. Berkman met with Lenin, and Lenin told him that "Liberty is a luxury not to be permitted at the present stage of development." When the revolution is out of danger, external and domestic, then free speech might be indulged in. He admitted that the government is often compelled to resort to unpleasant means, but that is the imperative of the situation from which there can be no shrinking. He told Goldman that free speech is a bourgeois notion. There can be no free speech in a revolutionary period, and that after the revolution is won, then you could have all the free speech you want. But not now.
- 1.51** Goldman saw firsthand the depravity of the Cheka. She told the story of a young man who was arrested. His rich relatives were told that he had been arrested and that he could be liberated by paying a very large fine. They got the money, handed over the fine, and then they were arrested for attempted bribery, and the prisoner and the relatives were shot. As she herself witnessed, early in the morning, mounted Chekas with DShKs shooting in the air, which was a warning that closed all the windows. Then came motor trucks loaded with the doomed, faces down, hands tied behind them. Soldiers were over them with rifles, and that blood dripped from the wagons, leaving a crimson streak on the pavement all the way up to the Cheka headquarters.
- 1.52** Karl Radek, who had been in the sealed train car with Lenin, came to Berkman with a proposition. He wanted Berkman to translate one of Lenin's essays into English. The essay was called The Infantile Thickness of Leftism, and it was a clear attack on anarchism directly. At that very moment, there were a group of political prisoners, anarchists, who were being held in prison. They were undergoing a hunger strike to demand better conditions. They were who Berkman thought of in this moment. He said, "I saw their burning eyes peering accusingly at me through the iron bars. 'Have you forsaken us?' he could hear them whisper." He wanted to write a preface to the essay, saying that he couldn't in good conscience translate an attack on his views without allowing some defense. Of course, this is something Lenin would not allow. After that, Berkman was persona non grata.
- 1.53** For 18 months, the two of them had held out hope that the Russian Revolution could be redeemed, and day by day, their hopes were dashed. As he put it, "I saw the ideals of yesterday betrayed, the meaning of the revolution perverted, its essence caricatured into reaction. I saw the workers subdued, the whole country silenced by the party dictatorship and its organized brutality. I saw entire villages laid waste by Bolshevik artillery." And then came Kronstadt.

- 1.54** Kronstadt is a naval base just outside St. Petersburg. During 1919, a detachment of sailors there were crucial to defending the city against the White Forces, the counterrevolutionaries. By 1920, the impossible became reality. The White Forces were defeated, and war communism would finally be on its way out. The Bolsheviks had won against the only forces internally who offered them a threat. Now the soldiers of Kronstadt asked that Lenin and the Bolsheviks deliver what had been promised, specifically, new elections by secret ballot, freedom of speech and of the press, freedom of assembly for labor unions, to liberate political prisoners, to review cases of those held in prisons, and to equalize the rations of those who work, and to permit free individual production on a small scale.
- 1.55** Lenin and Trotsky were not exactly amenable to these demands. Trotsky personally approved the plan to gas them if they continued their uppity behavior. To put it mildly, Lenin and Berkman were beside themselves. These men who had been crucial in winning the revolution were now being threatened simply for asking for what the revolution had promised from the very beginning. They wrote to the Petrograd Soviet of labor and defense. They offered their services as intermediaries, saying, "We want no bloodshed." And then Berkman himself heard the decision of the Bolsheviks. He heard the sounds of the cannons and the weapons as Kronstadt was laid under attack.
- 1.56** It was a complete bloodbath, and the Kronstadt men fell and were defeated utterly by the forces of the Bolsheviks. Two thousand were taken prisoner, many executed on the spot. The rest were sent to prisons, others to labor camps. As Lenin put it, "The time has come to put an end to opposition, to put a lid on it. We've had enough opposition." Nine days after Kronstadt fell, Lenin declared war on anyone whose views were different from his own. The Mensheviks, who had been his allies throughout this whole thing, now Lenin said, "An open proof of one's Menshevism should be sufficient ground for our revolutionary courts to confer the highest punishment." That is, shooting. Over 1,000 Mensheviks were arrested in Ukraine alone.
- 1.57** As historian Paul Abrich puts it, "By the end of the year, the active remnants of political opposition had been silenced or driven underground, and the consolidation of one party rule was all but complete." Emma Goldman left the Soviet Union in 1921 with complete and utter loathing. She published a memoir in what became two books, given titles of *My Disillusionment in Russia* and *My Further Disillusionment in Russia*. His was called *The Bolshevik Myth*. His came out in 1925 during the Coolidge administration. So as early as 1923, 24, and 25, people could learn for themselves, if they were interested, the reality of what was going on behind what would become the Soviet Union, from the pens of people who were hardly on the right.
- 1.58** As Goldman put it, "Those familiar with the real situation in Russia, and who are not in the mesmeric influence of the Bolshevik superstition, will bear me out that I have given a true picture. The rest of the world will learn in time." This was 100 years ago. But the rest of the world didn't want to learn it. They didn't want to hear it. Books began to be

burned. Descartes, Plato, Schopenhauer, virtually every philosopher. Bakunin, who was Marx's rival, was an early anarchist. And Kropotkin, forbidden. Tolstoy's novels escaped censures, but his non-fiction works, as he was an anarchist, were banned. Kant could be found in academic libraries, but could only be given out under the strictest responsibility of the chief librarians.

- 1.59** This was a new society, and anything from before could be regarded as obsolete and outdated, and therefore counterrevolutionary. In 1924, Goldman gave a dinner talk in London. Red Emma, the revolutionary. This is the woman who prophesied what would happen, who fought for the workers all her life. Wild applause, standing ovation. By the time she was done, you could hear a pin drop because she told these lefties in London that this is not what they were fighting for. This is not what they had hoped for. This was something more barbaric than the Tsar could ever have imagined in his wildest dreams.
- 1.60** As she put it, "To call the present Soviet government a workers' experiment is the most preposterous lie ever told. The time has come when silence on the Russian situation makes you a party of the crimes which are being committed there." They called her a Tory, Emma Goldman. Until the day she died, she never stopped advocating for the workers of Russia and for the workers all around the world. In 1933, she wrote, "The fact is that the communists are the forebears of fascism. Neither Mussolini nor Hitler have made a single original step. All they had to do was to follow and copy faithfully the steps taken by Lenin and Stalin." At the time, this was regarded as complete absurdity. Lenin and Stalin are on the left, Hitler is on the right. What could the two possibly have in common?
- 1.61** Even though Lenin was indisputably an ideologue and a fanatic, he was more pragmatic than many people in the popular consciousness realize. So after Kronstadt, basically, he did what many in the rebellion were asking for. He introduced what he called the New Economic Policy. So realizing that, first of all, this worldwide revolution was not imminently happening, and trying to ground the Russian Revolution in something more solid, he pulled back a bit on this dictatorship of the proletariat, meaning, instead of grain being requisitioned, producers would pay a tax. Instead of public services being free, they would cost money. Attempts were made to encourage foreign investment. While big business and banking remained under government control, small businesses were allowed to develop. So he brought some air into the market.
- 1.62** And as a result of this, a new class of people were formed, New Economic Policy, NEP. They were called NEP men. And by having this little space for these, what before had been a huge taboo, these bourgeois, now these people got very wealthy very quick by offering their services. And it's quite easy to become very wealthy when everyone else is so desperately poor, if only by comparing your assets to theirs. Sounded a lot like a return to capitalism, and it kind of was. Lenin called it state capitalism.

- 1.63 This was regarded not only as a huge betrayal, but also for people of the Menshevik persuasion. "And I told you so. We said you were going too fast, and now you're proving us right." And then it became a felony to point out this hypocrisy. As Lenin put it, "When certain people who may even be guided by the best possible motives begin to so panic just at the time when we're carrying out a retreat, beset with vast difficulties, at a time when it's vitally important to retain good order in retreating, it is necessary to punish severely, ruthlessly, the slightly violation of discipline."
- 1.64 When Lenin was a kid, he saw firsthand many people starving to death, food having been a problem for a long time in Russia. And now food became a problem again in the years of 1920 and '21. At first, Lenin made it illegal to use the words famine and starvation in the media, but banning discussion of hunger did not make people more fed. The problem increased. Russians went to train stations in hopes of getting food or going to somewhere where food was, and these gatherings turned into scenes of complete inhumanity.
- 1.65 One aid worker in Lenin's hometown saw things like a mother being driven mad by hunger, rocking her baby. And then suddenly, as it starts to cry, smacking in the face, beating the child furiously, her face distorted with rage. She rains blows with her fist on its little face, on its head, and at last, she throws it upon the floor and kicks it with her foot. The mother's eyes are fixed but apparently sightless as she loses her mind due to hunger. In 1921, Lenin's position was far stronger than it had been in 1919, and he was persuaded to accept help from abroad. The man who was in charge of this was Herbert Hoover. Hoover made his name by feeding the people of Europe during the Great War, civilians. Now, the man who was known as the Great Engineer set his sights on feeding the people of Russia.
- 1.66 This was humiliating for Lenin, and he said that, "One must punish Hoover. One must publicly slap his face so the whole world sees." I think it's funny, just historically, to have Lenin denouncing Herbert Hoover in 1921 because that's quite a Venn diagram in terms of what we envision of American history and worldwide history. Eventually, Hoover and his compatriots would pull out because what they saw was happening was the Bolsheviks were simply taking the grain and selling it for export, leaving the citizens hungry. At least 1 million people starved, probably far more. But this was just a practice run for what was to come a decade later.
- 1.67 On the morning of May 26, 1922, Lenin got out of bed in a very bad state. He had trouble walking. He had trouble moving his arm. He couldn't write. He couldn't even do basic multiplication. He had had a stroke. He remembered what Karl Marx's son-in-law had done with his wife in 1911, and he asked his wife to give him cyanide. The couple couldn't go through with it, so they called in a man who they knew could, Joseph Stalin.

Lecture 2: Stalin's Rise to Power

At a glance — Stalin's rise from Georgian origins to Soviet power.

- 2.1 The man who became known as Joseph Stalin was born Joseph Jugashvili in what is now the country of Georgia in the year 1878. Now, since the Bolsheviks, before they took power, had to engage in clandestine activities, many of them took on pseudonyms. Lenin's real name was Vladimir Ulyanov, and Stalin's name translates into Man of Steel.
- 2.2 The man was engaged in activities which, by any standard, would be regarded as criminal. The euphemism was expropriations, by which was meant armed robberies of banks, mail coaches, and steamships. They regarded it as permissible because this was a way to replenish the party treasury, to buy weapons, and to help take down the Tsar. Stalin was especially famous for the 1907 robbery of the Tiflis State Bank, which brought over 300,000 rubles into Bolshevik coffers. It goes without saying that many of these acts of expropriations alongside them brought killings in the interests of the cause.
- 2.3 You can see from the picture that young Stalin was, to put it mildly, a bit of a hunk. By 1920, Stalin had a fair bit of power within the Bolshevik Party. He had various roles, including editing their journal Pravda. "Pravda" is Russian for truth, a newspaper that continued throughout the entire reign of the Soviet Union. Now, while Trotsky, Lenin's right-hand man, was very big on developing Bolshevik ideology—the philosopher, he was the brains of the operation—Stalin was working behind the scenes. He was more the glad-hander, more the politician, something that would come to fruition in a few short years with disastrous consequences for Trotsky and his associates.
- 2.4 Stalin did visit Lenin during his stroke, and he promised to put Lenin out of his misery if things ever reached that point. But he also convinced Lenin that suicide would be premature. Lenin was a fighter, and Stalin encouraged him to stay on and fight. What kind of message would that send to the revolutionaries if the man who brought the revolution to reality took his own life, if that was not absolutely necessary? That December, Lenin had two more minor strokes, followed by a major one, and he would never write another word until the day that he died.
- 2.5 The big distinction between Lenin and Stalin in their ideology was what this idea of communism meant. For Lenin, it was a worldwide movement, the workers all over the world uniting in a revolution and bringing forth this sort of heaven on Earth, here in reality and everywhere in Europe, Asia, US, and so on and so forth. Stalin, on the other hand, viewed the idea of socialism in one country as much more practicable and the best path forward. And in a way, both men got their way. On December 28, 1922, the USSR was proclaimed, which was a combination of Russia, Ukraine, Belarus, and

Transcaucasia. Now, on paper, each of these republics still had a great amount of autonomy, but in practice, Moscow was in charge, and increasingly so.

- 2.6 As Lenin recuperated, the Soviet Union was run by a troika consisting of Stalin, Lev Kamenev, and Grigory Zinoviev. Stalin took control of Lenin's living arrangements, his correspondence, who could visit him, and who Lenin could write to. He was effectively a prisoner of Stalin. On January 21st, 1924, Lenin took his last breath without Stalin's assistance at all, and this left the Soviet Union at a crossroads. The great visionary was now gone. What would be the path forward for the Soviet Union? On the one hand, you had Stalin, on the other hand, you had Trotsky and his associates. The other two men sided with Trotsky against Stalin, but Stalin further consolidated his power, working the party members. And by 1927, Stalin succeeded in expelling Trotsky from the Communist Party, and by early 1928, succeeded in expelling him from the Soviet Union itself.
- 2.7 Trotsky continued to write about how the revolution was betrayed. He turned on Stalin publicly, and these books, published throughout the world, caused an enormous sense of embarrassment for those back home in the Soviet Union. For his part, Stalin was now in position to make Trotsky the scapegoat for everything that went wrong in the Soviet Union, something that was parodied very well by Orwell in 1984 with the character of Emmanuel Goldstein. Now, despite the civil war having won by the Bolsheviks, despite the communist revolution becoming manifest in what was now the Soviet Union, this idea of, without the capitalists withdrawing profits and having more to distribute to everyone, this cornucopia of wealth did not come to fruition.
- 2.8 A very easy example of how things became a problem was the idea of housing. As the cities became industrialized, more and more workers fled to them in search of work and food. Families were crammed into apartments already occupied by other families, and both eviction and finding a new place to live became impossible. Of course, a bit of this was by design. The vision in communist ideology was to have homes without kitchens so that everyone could eat equally in government-run cafeterias. In fact, hardcore communist architects began to design buildings where everyone would have to share bathrooms because this idea of shame and privacy in an individual were outdated bourgeois concepts.
- 2.9 Now, one of the Achilles' heels of the communist ideology is this idea that human beings often respond to incentives and in very nefarious ways. So quickly, now, if all it took for me to double my living space was to turn in the family who I was living with, many people were not hesitant to pick up that phone call. In fact, it became a joke, literally, in Russian culture, where someone would say, "Just think, Masha. I turned in a denunciation on Galkin, but Balkin had the bigger room." People would laugh about families being arrested for no reason, simply for the sake of people increasing their living spaces. In a way, you can't even really blame them, because the amount of concentration that these families had in tiny living spaces would make the legendary

Lower East Side of New York City, where all the immigrants were crammed together, seemed like paradises in comparison.

- 2.10** As bad as housing was, the food situation was even worse, both in terms of production and in terms of distribution. In 1928, the Soviet Union implemented what was the first five-year plan. It was a complete reversal of Lenin's NEP policies and an increasing centralization and central planning of the economy. As part of this was the idea to centralize and collectively plan farmland. Now, before, you'd have a farmer, and they had their plot of land, and that farmer knew his land very well. He knew how to work it and to produce. Now, the idea was to have all these farmlands collectivized into giant farms, centrally run. In effect, the farmer would be demoted from the one owning and running his own land to someone simply working the land on behalf of the state and for the greater good of the society.
- 2.11** Now, the main opponents to this were, of course, the wealthy farmers, the kulaks. Now, wealthy is a term that has a lot of different meanings. If everyone is starving and I have one cow, I'm pretty darn wealthy. I have access to milk. There were, of course, kulaks who had a lot more. But very quickly, the kulak became anyone who had enough food to put into his own mouth. As part of this class warfare and this idea that if you were a member of the wrong economic class, you were irredeemable, the government launched an assault on class enemies.
- 2.12** These kulaks were treated in several different ways. Some received prison sentences or even executed. Some were deported from their ancestral lands further into the Soviet Union, with over 2 million people being deported within the years 1930-31 alone. Of course, if you argued against these ideas, you were a kulak, or at the bare least a kulak sympathizer, which is hardly better than being a kulak yourself. As the Bolsheviks demanded more and more grain, the farmers rebelled. Land was abandoned. Farm animals were slaughtered and eaten or turned into leather simply to have something to show for it. Some state officials were met with violence, and riots broke out as peasants refused to hand over the fruits of their own labor. Again, this was food that was being taken out of their hands, not some kind of luxury indulgence.
- 2.13** Now, thanks to central planning and the Marxist ideology, the idea was, all right, if we produce, let's suppose, 100 tons of wheat this year, next year it'll be 101, next year 102, and we can increase exponentially. Now, this is something that might make sense mathematically, but in terms of practical terms, it's completely nonsensical, especially when it comes to things like crops. You have to deal with weather, you have to deal with disease, you have to deal with all sorts of inputs and outputs. Also, there's only so much that you can improve on a year-to-year basis. It might be easy to have some innovation, and this year to next year, we can improve a certain amount. But to say we're going to be able to have similar innovation every single year and increase exponentially is something that makes a lot of sense theoretically, but makes no sense in practical terms.

- 2.14** The year 1930 was a very favorable one for crops in terms of weather. 1931 had far worse conditions. So according to even official Soviet figures, the harvest requisitions fell from 23.9 million tons in 1930 to 18.3 million tons in 1931, meaning fewer, as opposed to this idea of increasing bounties year upon year upon year. Now, as a result of this also, these hungry peasants had no choice but to consume the seeds that they would have planted for the next year's harvest because they were starving, which meant the disaster was only going to increase exponentially. Even further, in their brilliance, the Soviet authorities took much of this grain not to feed the citizenry, but for export, to get currency for the Soviet government.
- 2.15** In 1932, an edict came, which said that public property is the basis of the Soviet system, and those attempting to steal public property must be considered enemies of the people. A punishment for being the enemy of the people was "the highest measure of social defense," execution, or at the very least, a prison sentence of no fewer than 10 years. In America, Emma Goldman had urged the hungry workers to take bread, and in the Soviet Union, hunger became grounds for the death penalty.
- 2.16** In 1932, the Soviets introduced a law which the Tsar had had, which had constantly been a focus of criticism by his opponents, the internal passport system. As more and more people fled to cities in search of food, but this became a problem for the Bolsheviks, so everyone was issued a passport, and travel within the country was made highly regulated.
- 2.17** As the historian, S. J. Taylor wrote, "Victims who were about to be deported were stripped of their shoes. Their clothes were taken and given to lower peasants as a bribe to ensure their cooperation. Kulak children were left as beggars on the street. Those transported to Siberia faced hardships. If a village existed, they were squeezed into it. Otherwise, they were simply abandoned without shelter in extreme cold, in order to build dwellings. Many managed to do so by working around the clock without sleep in order that they and the others would not freeze to death. And those employed as forced labor in mining regions faced starvation rations of one bowl of gruel a day and 8 to 10 ounces of bread."
- 2.18** They died in waves, but their numbers were replenished by the arrival of new deportees. In fact, only approved persons were allowed to reside within cities. When the secret police registered people, they made it a point to expel any kulaks or those who were otherwise disenfranchised. Government-approved activists descended upon the villages of the Ukraine, the bread basket of Europe, in the winter of 1932 to 1933. Everything that was edible was taken, and they were given special tools to ensure that every nook in every home could be searched for the slightest crust of bread or grain of wheat. Even a corn cob being dried out in order to have seeds for planting in the spring was fair game.
- 2.19** As historian Anne Applebaum recounts, "The activists had instructions to return, to surprise people in order to catch them unaware and with their food unguarded."

Families were searched and then searched again to make sure that nothing remained." One woman remembered how they came three times until nothing was left, and then they stopped coming. They would come at different times of day or night to make sure that whoever had food was being caught red-handed. If it happened that a family was eating dinner, the activists took bread off the table, and if soup was cooking, they pulled it off the stove and tossed out the contents. Then they demanded to know how it was possible that the family still had something to put in the soup. Because, again, keeping public property makes you an enemy of the people. By public property, we mean here food.

- 2.20 Not only was there no place to hide food, there was little possibility to hide having had food. Your own body would betray you. One look at a person would tell you if that person was starving or not. If someone had some fat to their face, you could tell at a glance that they were hiding food and therefore were an enemy of the people. This created an enormous incentive for villagers to spy and inform on each other. Turning in a neighbor for having a sack of grain was a great to ensure that you yourself would not be ransacked by these activists.
- 2.21 Not only that, those who couldn't produce the grain quota that had been imposed on them by the brilliant central planners were subject to a fine of five times the value of what the grain would have been. So if you can't produce one loaf of bread or the equivalent of grain that would make one loaf of bread, you are now fined with having to make five times that amount. Not having the food to fulfill your quota was proof that you were hiding food. And if you were hiding food, why aren't you handing it over?
- 2.22 In some villages, the requisitioners went from house to house, killing all their dogs and taking the bodies with them for good measure because that could be meat. They would slam fingers into doorways, needles jammed under fingernails. Those found concealing food were robbed of their remaining possessions, evicted from their homes, and thrown into the street without any clothes. To make sure that the peasants did not somehow steal the food that they desperately needed, fields and barns were kept under armed guard.
- 2.23 The activists even came for the tools used to make food, breaking millstones necessary to procure grain. If they took soup from a hungry family, they made sure to take the pot as well. The media, hand-to-hand with this, began a major campaign, portraying the kulaks as illiterate, selfish, subhuman hicks. If you were hungry, and everyone in the Soviet Union is hungry, it's because the kulaks were hoarding food and keeping it out of your mouth. The few Ukrainians who made their way to the cities, destitute and barely clothed, were treated with complete contempt and as worse than animals because it's their fault that everyone was hungry.
- 2.24 One Soviet citizen discusses how he was waiting in line in front of a store to buy bread. He saw a girl, 15, in rags, with starvation looking at her eyes, stretching her hand to everyone who bought bread, asking for some crumbs. Eventually, she reached the

storekeeper, and he began to berate her, telling her she was too lazy to work on a farm, and he hit her hand with the blunt edge of a knife blade. She fell down, lost the crumb of bread that was in her hand. Then he stepped closer, kicked her, and said, "Get up, go home, and get to work." She stretched out and died.

- 2.25** Some people in the line began to cry. But this was a country where basic human sympathy was grounds for suspicion, and then arrest, and then worse. The shopkeeper looked at the crowd and told them, "Some people are getting too sentimental here. It's easy to spot enemies of the people." Everyone in that line knew what he meant by those words and what danger they would have put themselves in, if they had given bread to a starving child. As one Soviet novel later put it regarding the kulaks, "Not one of them was guilty of anything, but they all belonged to a class that was guilty of everything."
- 2.26** Pregnant women trying to steal food were beaten to death, and the remaining children invariably starving. Children who tried to feed themselves were shot. Digging mass graves was difficult work, so that barely-living kids and the elderly were tossed alongside the dead in order to save extra work, and their last hours on Earth would be spent slowly dying, surrounded by the corpses of their countrymen. While a kulak originally meant being a small-time farmer, such kulaks only counted for about 5% of the population. But the system in place to identify the kulaks created the worst incentives.
- 2.27** As one Ukrainian writer later recalled, "It was so easy to do a man in. You wrote a denunciation, and you didn't even have to sign it. All you had to do was say that he had paid people to work for him or they had owned three cows." Worse, the poorest could do little to defend themselves against these accusations, whereas the richest could bribe their way out of it. The interconnectedness of economics led to a huge ripple effect in the Soviet economy. So the mass slaughter of farm animals led to an acute leather shortage. And as a result, the Soviet government made making shoes on an individual level a felony in order to force everyone to have their own shoes from the government, which often fell apart immediately.
- 2.28** Now, the Russians use, to this day, a use of humor called "anekdoty." These are little stories they tell each other when they meet, and they're often used to speak truths that are otherwise forbidden. There's one "anekdot" at the time, which is Soviet President Mikhael Kalinin was in Moscow, making a speech about how much the country had improved, and he was really excited about the new 20-story skyscrapers on Karl Marx Street in Kharkov. And a worker in the audience stood up to protest. He goes, "Comrade Kalinin, I live in Kharkov. Almost every day, I take a long walk on Karl Marx Street. There aren't any skyscrapers." Kalinin goes, "That's the trouble with you. You waste your time promenading instead of reading the newspapers and learning what's going on in the country."

- 2.29** It was a given that what was written in Pravda (truth), was "nepravda" (not true), but at the same time, those in the cities had no way of understanding what was actually happening in Ukraine. Now, this might make sense within a totalitarian dictatorship where the press is under strict government control. It made less sense for the Western newspapers. Now, the Western newspapers were in a difficult position because working in the Soviet Union meant that you're facing the Soviet apparatus. You were living in Soviet quarters at the leisure of the state. Your internal communications are often monitored. You were often followed around as well. Any story that you're trying to file has to make it through the Soviet censors who have no real incentive to be accommodating.
- 2.30** In fact, their job, or their lives possibly, would often be on the line to making sure that the story you're trying to file was in line with the Soviet line of the day. A censor could easily claim that he's waiting to hear from his supervisors before allowing the story to be released, and those supervisors had absolutely no incentive or any sense of urgency to release it. This obviously created an enormous incentive for Western journalists to file stories that were at least sympathetic to the Soviet point of view. In fact, many Western journalists were sympathetic to the Soviet point of view, because this was a country built on equality, where everyone's provided for, where there's no hunger or poverty. This certainly sounds like a noble goal, even if things are a little messy in the meantime.
- 2.31** When it came to coverage of the Soviet Union, first and foremost, then and now, was the paper of record, the New York Times. The New York Times' man in Moscow was someone by the name of Walter Duranty. As a young man, he was friends with Aleister Crowley, the satanist whose shaved head and declaration that, "Do what thou wilt shall be the whole of the law," so shocked the Victorians. In addition to smoking opium with Crowley, Duranty had an intimate relationship with Crowley's mistress before marrying her himself.
- 2.32** In 1929, Duranty managed to secure an interview with Stalin, and his reporting from within the USSR in 1932 earned him the Pulitzer, which then and now was journalism's highest honor. As early as 1921, the New York Times' Duranty was insisting that, "in a country rotten with corruption, the communists are honest." In 1923, after that famine that I mentioned earlier, Duranty wrote that "Lenin has often been called the red dictator, but Lenin never had the right to dictate, although in practice, his opinion generally carried the day, and that the secret of Lenin's authority, which did, in fact, amount to dictatorship, was that long experience had proved him right far oftener than his colleagues."
- 2.33** Duranty also told Westerners that all these concerns about the secret police, the Cheka, that Emma Goldman was so concerned about, were highly overblown. As he put it, "It is doubtful whether the total number of Cheka executions throughout the whole period, up to 1922, surpassed 50, 000. Though lives were cheap in Russia, and the

Cheka leaders pitiless in defending the revolution when in danger, they would have defeated their own object by the wholesale slaughter of workers and peasants on the scale reported abroad." They couldn't have killed so many people because it would have been counterproductive, and therefore they didn't.

- 2.34** He also said that, "I venture to say that no one who behaves himself, behaves himself, has any more reason to fear the secret police than the average American has to fear from the Department of Justice." After all, in his words, "Stalin is anything but remote or autocratic in method." As Hitler was coming into power with consequences that we're all quite familiar with, in November 1932, Duranty was explicitly saying, "There is no famine or actual starvation, nor is there likely to be." As he went on, "The Russians have tightened their belts before to a far greater extent than is likely to be needed this winter." It goes without saying that the reason people tighten their belts is because they don't have enough food and they're losing body fat.
- 2.35** He continued to report that the food shortage is insignificant as compared with conditions in 1920 and that the Bolsheviks are simply trying to introduce a new form of farming which they believe to be better and more efficient, not only for the peasants, but for the nation as a whole. As people went insane from hunger and sometimes ate their own children, New York Times readers could rest assured that this was simply a new form of farming. In fact, Duranty went out of his way to insist to his readers that he was not speaking from some ivory tower, but from first-hand experience.
- 2.36** As he put it, "I have just completed a 200-mile auto trip through the heart of the Ukraine and can say positively that the harvest is splendid and all talk of famine now is ridiculous and that the populace, from the babies to the old folk, look healthy and well-nourished." As to why so many peasants were fleeing their ancestral lands looking for food, he said, "Today, the labor turnover runs to 100% or more per year, due partly, no doubt, to hard conditions and the hope of finding something better elsewhere, but even more to an ancient habit of wandering and the desire for change." Russian people starving and fleeing to the cities is simply a tradition.
- 2.37** When an article was released in the London Times, giving some indication of the mass carnage that was happening in Ukraine, Duranty swiftly went on the attack. To the London Times correspondent, collectivization is one the blackest spots in his gloomy picture. He writes, "During the last two years, 70 million peasants have been driven, 14 million holdings, onto 200,000 collective farms. For anyone who knows the situation here as well as the writer in question clearly does, this is deliberate and ingenious perversion of fact."
- 2.38** As he put explicitly and dishonestly, "The Soviet press has made no secret of the food shortage and its effects. " And for a journalist to say the following, it's mind-boggling in retrospect. He said, explicitly, "There is no need for a foreign observer to tour the villages where it commonly happens that disgruntled or disaffected elements talk loudest while others are busy working." The idea of any journalist saying, "There's no

need to look into this mass starvation," is something that, it's hard for us, I think, to make sense of, other than in the most uncharitable interpretation.

- 2.39** However, there was one reporter who disagreed with Duranty, who thought, "There is a need to tour these villages," travel to which was forbidden, of course, by Soviet law. There was a young British man named Gareth Jones. He had been a private secretary to the Prime Minister of the UK, Lloyd George, before becoming a journalist. He used his connections to Lloyd George to get access to the Soviet Union and saying that this was to further ties between the USSR and the UK. On March 10, 1933, Jones took a train from Moscow toward the Ukrainian capital of Kharkiv. He was only 27, but he also knew something wasn't adding up.
- 2.40** So, what did Jones do? He got off the train 40 miles early and proceeded to walk through the Ukrainian countryside for himself and see what was going on. He knew better than to accept the words of the Soviet authorities. This was a time when cameras were nowhere near as ubiquitous as they are now, so we have little photographic evidence for what Jones saw. But as he went from village to village and saw the mass starvation, all the peasants told him the same thing. "We haven't had bread for over two months. We are doomed." After he left the Soviet Union, Jones held a press conference announcing what he saw with his own eyes. His articles were syndicated in various publications, making complete fools of the Moscow press corps.
- 2.41** Jones was not entirely alone. There was someone by the name of Malcolm Muggeridge. His father had been one of the founders of the Fabian Society, which led to the Labour Party. This was the big organization which introduced democratic socialism into the UK. What Muggeridge had done was filed his stories in a diplomatic bag as a way to get them out of the USSR without passing through the censors. Of course, as a result of what Muggeridge saw and what Jones saw, Duranty went on the attack. In a 13-page New York Times article headlined, "Russians hungry but not starving," Duranty claimed that the deaths were from diseases, and that larger cities have food, and that what these foreign observers saw in the country was no grounds for predicting disaster.
- 2.42** The current historical consensus of what became known as the Holodomor is almost 4 million people starved in Ukraine alone, with over 1 million others in the broader Soviet Union. Now, on the other hand, the media in the USSR was talking about bumper crops. We have more food than we know what to do with. So statistically, the predicted population, 1937, was going to be 170 million. And when the census came in, the number came in at 162 million, 8 million people discrepancy. Now, these results were never published because, of course, now it meant that the census had been disrupted by contemptible enemies of the people.
- 2.43** The head of the census bureau was executed, along with his colleagues. The editor of Soviet statistics was killed, as was the head of the Ukrainian Academy of Sciences' economics department. Their replacements knew what their job was, and they redid the census. Wouldn't you know it, 170 million, just as the central planners had

predicted. Malcolm Muggeridge was asked years later for what the consequences were for him telling the world that this famine was an organized one. He said, "Me? What happened to me? Oh, yeah, I couldn't get work." He was blacklisted. As for Gareth Jones, he was on location in northern China in 1935, when he was murdered one day short of his 30th birthday.

2.44 In September 1957, Walter Duranty, without a penny in his pocket, wrote to Arthur Sulzberger, the publisher of the New York Times, asking for a monthly pension. By 1934, even Duranty was admitting that, "I, myself, was lamentably wrong about the extent in gravity of the manmade famine in Russia during the fight to collectivize the farms in 1930 to 1933." But every reporter worth his salt tries always to tell the truth. Now, whether he's telling the truth or that he wasn't worth his salt is a question we can all ask ourselves. Sulzberger chose not to give Duranty a pension. And despite the fact that Duranty hadn't worked for the Times in 17 years, and despite the fact that Duranty had repeatedly lied about the mass starvation of millions of people in the New York Times, Sulzberger cut Duranty a check for \$2,500, which was exactly half the average annual salary of a worker at the time.

2.45 Even though Stalin was largely able to keep the famine from Western eyes, it's very hard to tell a population that you're not really hungry. So every hungry mouth, every person unhappy with this workers' paradise, was a threat to Stalin's hold on power. Now, he had a scapegoat in Trotsky, but of course, that only went so far. It became illegal to read foreign material, which helped the media very effectively create a false reality within this closed society.

2.46 But there developed a joke. Decades later, there's a Russian leader, and he has in his desk two letters from his predecessor. Shit's really hitting the fan. He knows in moments of crisis, those are what the letters are for. He opens the first letter, reads it, and the letter says, "Blame everything on me." Great. He goes out there, blames everything on his predecessor. The crisis passes and moves on. A few years later, there's another crisis in Russian culture. Things are reaching a boiling point. He doesn't know what to do. He reaches in his desk, reads the second letter, and the letter says, "Sit down and write two letters."

2.47 But at a certain point, there's only so many people you can blame. So the question became, what happens when Stalin passes? Who is Stalin's successor going to be? Lenin had died at a mere 53 years of age, and Stalin was a heavy smoker, and he had already been having some heart disturbances by the 1930s. January 26, 1934 was the beginning of the 17th Communist Party Congress, and with it came talk of who would be Stalin's successor, and his health gave them cover to discuss what that would mean. Now, I think we can all understand, if you're the man on the top and people start talking about who your successor is, that means they're already thinking about you not being in power, which is not what you want them to be thinking about.

- 2.48** The man that they settled on was someone named Sergei Kirov. He had received greater applause than Stalin at the event, which would be unthinkable a few years after that. And what they didn't realize was having a quasi-official replacement for Stalin meant that each of those people now had a target on their own backs. At the end of that year, December 1st, 1934, a young man named Leonid Nikolaev entered Communist Party headquarters, waited outside Kirov's office. And when Kirov came, for some reason without his bodyguard, Nikolaev shot him in the back and killed him.
- 2.49** The idea that such a brazen assassination could be the work of a lone gunman defied belief, just as it defied belief with the McKinley assassination in the United States. Rumors within the secret police began to point to Stalin himself. Now, whether Stalin can be blamed for Kirov's assassination or not, what there is no question of is that he took enormous advantage of this murder to unleash a terror upon the Soviet Union, the likes of which the world had never seen before. Kamenev and Zinoviev, who had worked with Stalin after Lenin had become incapacitated, were put on trial. And in 1936, they and several other old Bolsheviks confessed to conspiring with Trotsky to try to kill Stalin and overthrow the revolution.
- 2.50** Other trials quickly followed. Men who had fought alongside Lenin when Bolshevism was completely marginalized, radical ideology now claimed that they were working with Nazi Germany and Imperialist Japan to restore capitalism to Russia. The intensity with which they stood up and claimed their guilt contrasted strongly with their zombie-like demeanor. The trials raised more questions than they answered. What made them switch sides, if they had switched sides? Or what could possibly be done to such hardened revolutionaries to get them to admit their betrayals?
- 2.51** As one reporter put it, "Certainly one expects false evidence in a trial involving capital crimes, but one expects it in the direction of self-defense." The Society of Old Bolsheviks were among the many groups targeted with mass terror. These were the ones who had fought against the Tsar when it was really, really tough, and Stalin's name was not part of their memoirs. He had not been a major player, and they had all been eyewitnesses to that very simple fact. One by one, they began to disappear. Many were transferred to new jobs in new cities, but they never showed up.
- 2.52** There was another group called the association of the former political exiles and katorga prisoners. Before 1917, men who struggled against the Tsar often ended up with imprisonment in the katorga system, which was a series of labor camps in Siberia and the Russian far east that served the dual purpose of isolating those prisoners from the population at large, as well as breaking their spirits due to forced labor. And worse, since the environment was so inhospitable, they wouldn't have to do much to enforce discipline upon these men. Not only did they barely have enough food, but they had to work hard merely to stay alive from one day to the next.
- 2.53** These men who had been regarded by the Tsar as the biggest threats to his rule were now regarded by Stalin in the exact same way. But in this case, there would be no

release of them from imprisonment. Many were deported to the far east, but others simply vanished. As one journalist put it, "Imagine if you can, the 3 million Americans holding the most strategic posts of power and influence in our country, suddenly being subjected to a public inquiry into their past history, even onto their grandparents, their political faith, private conduct, and more intimate personal foibles. Imagine this inquiry conducted under conditions which made it the duty of every neighbor and charwoman and office boy to question and accuse these upper three million. Imagine that and you have some inkling of what took place in Russia."

- 2.54** The greater the number of men who could be made to confess to plotting with Trotsky against Stalin, the greater Stalin looked and the more justified this mass terror became. As early as 1928, Stalin was decreeing that "as we move forward, the resistance of the capitalist elements will increase, and that the class struggle will intensify," meaning, we are going to get more repression and more authoritarianism over time, not what Lenin had promised to Berkman and to Goldman. As he put it, "We are ousting and ruining, perhaps without noticing ourselves, by our progress towards socialism, thousands upon thousands of small and medium capitalist industrialists. Is it possible to think that these ruined people will sit in silence, not trying to organize resistance? Of course not."
- 2.55** The problem is, Trotsky hadn't even been in the Soviet Union since 1929. So how is he organizing all these people to create this kind of coup and to murder Stalin? So during his trial, 1936, Edouard Holtzman, who was one of the old Bolsheviks, testified that he had arranged with Trotsky's son to be in Copenhagen within two or three days, to put up at the Hotel Bristol, and to meet him there. Now, it's very easy or relatively easy if you're a totalitarian dictatorship to have control of the media within your own country. It's impossible to have control of the media in other countries. Six days after this, a newspaper in Denmark broke the news that there was no way for Holtzman or anyone else to have met Trotsky at the Hotel Bristol because the hotel didn't exist. It had been demolished in 1917.
- 2.56** As time went on, more and more innocent people were drawn to the Great Terror, and the stories used to retroactively establish their crimes not only were increasingly implausible, but were often literally impossible. There was a Bolshevik leader by the name of Pyatakov, and he went to being one of Lenin's rivals to being a member of the Supreme Economic Council, to being Stalin's prisoner. He was made to sign a confession that when he had been abroad, he had corresponded with Trotsky. Then they also made him say that he had met with Trotsky as well. Now they had to figure out where and when he could have met with Trotsky.
- 2.57** The problem was that Trotsky at the time was living at the Norwegian town of Veksal. And Pyatakov, to get from where he was, from Berlin to Oslo, then drive to Veksal, have a meeting and return, would have taken two days, but there were enough eyewitnesses to show that he had been in Germany pretty much every day. So if he couldn't take a non-existent train, they'd just say he took a non-existent plane. So he

stood up in court and said he had taken a plane near Oslo, drove to meet Trotsky to talk about overthrowing the Soviet government. And two days later, the Norwegian press exposed this as a lie because there 's only one airfield near Oslo where the plane could have landed, and no plane landed there during December 1935. And in fact, no foreign plane landed there from September 1935 through May 1936.

- 2.58** The Russians issued a statement saying that the arrival and departure of airplanes is possible in winter months, something which is true and of no relevance here. And what happened to Pyatakov? Well, this was an opportunity for Trotsky. He said, "I can prove that the story of the visit is false from beginning to end, and therefore, the entire system, these voluntary confessions, would be thoroughly discredited." And he demanded that Pyatakov's testimony be verified immediately before Pyatakov was shot. Stalin did not take the bait, and Pyatakov was shot alongside 12 of his fellow defendants shortly thereafter.
- 2.59** Then came the story of Lenin's last will and testament. As he was dying, Lenin wrote out what he wanted to happen after he passed. He criticized both Trotsky and Stalin and predicted that their rivalries would lead to an enormous split within the party. And Lenin had grave misgivings about Joseph Stalin, as he put it. "Stalin is too coarse, and this defect becomes intolerable in a secretary general. This is why I suggest that the comrades think about a way of removing Stalin from that post and appointing another man in his stead."
- 2.60** The document was immediately suppressed in Russia when Lenin's widow released it, but the entire testament was published in Western newspapers in 1926. One man who knew the truth behind this document was Ivan Smirnov. And of course, Stalin put Smirnov up for trial as well. Smirnov had been in jail for several years when the accusation came that he had been plotting with Trotsky. As far as alibis go, being in a Soviet prison is a pretty good one to argue against being a plotter. The prosecutor said that, "We know while in prison, Smirnov organized contacts with Trotskyites, for a code was discovered by means of which Smirnov communicated with his companions outside. "
- 2.61** As one refugee put it, "What could he write to them? Aim at Stalin 's head, not his belly?" To Westerners, this might sound plausible because, in our prison system, people in jail can write in and out. They can get letters, they get packages. But to Russians, this, of course, was a farce. Political prisoners were often vanished without a trace. Their friends and families had no idea what happened to them or where they were, if they were still alive. It goes without saying that Smirnov was, of course, convicted and executed of plotting with Stalin in May of 1937.
- 2.62** Even on his way out of power, Trotsky was insisting that the party is always right and that one cannot be right against the party. And on this, Stalin agreed. As he put it, "An enemy of the people is not only one who does sabotage, but one who doubts the rightness of the party line. And there are a lot of them, and we must liquidate them."

Even doubting the party was itself grounds for being an enemy of the people, which was grounds for execution. As a result of this, people were judged by their allegiance to the party as opposed to the quality of their work, which led to perhaps predictable but nevertheless deranged consequences.

- 2.63** Meteorologists were imprisoned for failing to predict weather that would harm crops. There was a linguist named Nikolai Marr who had idiosyncratic views about how language was developed. Now, his proletarian science, which is the good science as opposed to bourgeois science, which is the bad science, said that all the languages of the Earth not only came from one original language, but from four sounds, specifically, rosh, sal, ber, and yon. And professors who were opposed to this linguistic nonsense were exiled, their books withdrawn from circulation, and they were finally arrested. One year, many horses lost their lives due to an epidemic. The vaccines offered did not work. So the bacteriologists were arrested for sabotage. Astronomers rounded up since their theories of sunspot development were decreed to be decidedly un-Marxist.
- 2.64** The most famous example of this was someone named Trofim Lysenko, because when it comes to nature and nurture, the Bolsheviks were entirely on the nurture side, because they believed in a materialistic view of man that can be reshaped by society to create a perfect being in their own image. Therefore, this whole idea of genetics and carrying on what happened through ancestry was something that should be rejected. Lysenko thought that Mendel's idea that genes exist and that they can transmit characteristics was a reactionary idea, and therefore must be wrong. Because of this, Soviet biology became worldwide laughingstock for years, including Lysenko's claim that he managed to cross a tomato with a potato.
- 2.65** What happened was, anyone with technical expertise inevitably became a suspect when something went wrong. In 1937, a photographer was executed after one of his apprentices turned him in, simply because he pointed out that, before the revolution, the quality of photographic paper was better. Served him right for lying, right? As the kulaks were to blame for issues with food and agriculture, now there was a new class of invisible foes responsible for all the problems in the industry, the wreckers. Because the Soviet system was perfect, and not just perfect, but ideologically correct, therefore, all these problems in the industry must be the result of sabotage, conscious sabotage, by invisible omnipresent wreckers.
- 2.66** In 1937, the railway minister said, "I cannot name a single line, a single road, where there is no Trotskyite Japanese wrecking. What is more, there is not a single branch of railway transport where such workers have not turned up." He ordered the arrest of thousands of railway administrators and managers, which is an enormous attack on technical skill. The more evidence came that communism wasn't delivering on what it promised, the more proof you had that these wreckers were omnipresent and pernicious and affecting these catastrophes.

- 2.67 Eventually, showing up 20 minutes to work was not just grounds for dismissal, but a felony. Losing your job was regarded as sort of a treason against society because everyone was supposed to work as hard as they could on behalf of everybody else. The Russian newspapers ran articles where people stood up in court, admitting to things like placing bombs in mines to wreck the mines and the productivity.
- 2.68 As one member of the French National Federation of Miners pointed out, "I defy any technician, however competent, to organize the systemic placing of a mine in an explosive state without the inspectors, even if they were complete idiots, perceiving it within an hour." Let's just talk this through. Imagine you have a mine. Someone just walks in, they've got this thing of dynamite with the blasting cap. "What's that?" "Oh, it's nothing. This is just to help." No one's going to notice this? But this is what the Russian people were expected to believe.
- 2.69 The arts themselves were even worse, because artistry, by its nature, is subjective and open to interpretation. Shostakovich is one of the greatest composers of all time. He's still listened to and heavily admired today. On January 26, 1936, Stalin stormed out of the premiere of Shostakovich's new opera. A couple of days later, there were headlines talking about muddle instead of music and called the work "a grotesquery suited to the perverted taste of the bourgeois." Now, some members in the artistic community stood up for Shostakovich. There was a writer named A. Leznev who said that, "I view the incident of Shostakovich as the advent of the same order that burns books in Germany." He was tortured and shot.
- 2.70 A theater director denounced the angry, cruel headlines. His wife was stabbed to death in the eyes. He was tortured and shot, his body dumped in a landfill. Shostakovich's ex-girlfriend, who was a writer named Galina, was vanished. His brother-in-law, his sister, his mother-in-law, his uncle, all were arrested. Things got even more clever on behalf of the Soviet authorities to instill a false reality into the workers. After all, words are one thing, but photographs are indisputable proof. So what they began to do was falsify history itself.
- 2.71 Here we have an example of Lenin standing behind Trotsky. On the left, and if you turn to the right, you can see that Trotsky vanishes from the photograph. You could remember one thing, but you could just look at the picture and see for yourself that Trotsky was never there. Here's another example of Lenin giving a speech and Trotsky standing before him on the steps, and then Trotsky vanishes. Things got even more extreme, as you had a photograph of four men, Stalin among them, then down to three, then down to two, and then Stalin stood alone.

Lecture 3: Stalin's Paranoia Unleashed

At a glance — Stalin's paranoia unleashed — the purges and 'unpersoning'.

- 3.1** The Soviet Union thus began a process of what became known as "unpersoning", by which people not only ceased to exist in the present day, but their existence in the past was retroactively removed as well—something Orwell parodied very well in his book, 1984. A very famous example of this is the picture known as The Commissar vanishes. By rewriting the past, even the past that was in recent memory, Stalin began to have even more control over the present day.
- 3.2** The problem was, there was one group of people who knew with absolute certainty what Stalin had been up to with these show trials and what his level of involvement was. In the fall of 1936, Stalin turned on the secret police themselves. He started at the top, switching out his chief torturer, Yagoda, with Yezhov, to be people's commissar of the interior, which is the head of the NKVD, which is what the secret police were known as at the time. Then he could claim innocence of the entire terror and say that this had all been Yagoda's fault.
- 3.3** Yezhov brought 300 new officials with him. These were the understudies in Stalin's play of terror, and they knew that the entire main cast was about to be replaced. In March of 1937, Yezhov dispersed many of the main NKVD personnel, ostensibly to have them check on various regions of the Soviet Union. Separated and isolated, the men would never reach their supposed destinations. Their assistants met with the same fates. Yezhev took control of the passports so the agents couldn't travel abroad, and he took control of the aviation squadrons so they couldn't commandeer a plane.
- 3.4** Then came the mass arrests of Stalin's secret police. Some of the interrogators turned to suicide, knowing full well the privations they would certainly face under arrest, for they themselves had recently been the perpetrators of such tortures. A few jumped to their deaths from their windows in central Moscow, and there wasn't even a pretense of a trial for many of the others. Three thousand were executed in 1937 alone, and Yagoda's judges, those who had rubber-stamped the executions of hundreds of thousands of innocent people, they were also arrested en masse.
- 3.5** As one survivor wrote, "Many prisoners found considerable satisfaction in meeting their own judges who had bawled accusations of 'counterrevolutionary' and 'spy' at them, in prison on the same charges." For a good measure, Yezhov arrested Yagoda's family, exiling the man's wife, parents, sisters, nieces, and nephews, and Yagoda himself would finally be executed at the start of 1938. The biggest crime in the Soviet Union was knowing too much about Stalin, and the inevitable penalty for that was death.
- 3.6** If the secret police were a threat to Stalin's authority, there was another strong power center in the Soviet Union, as it is in any country, the military. In 1937, Stalin's purge

turned toward the military because they theoretically could have deposed him in a coup. Eight leading Red Army generals were arrested, the newspapers full of articles claiming that they were working for a foreign state, namely Nazi Germany. The fact that three of them were Jewish was of no relevance to these demented accusations for which no evidence was, of course, put forward. They were all tried and executed, something which would have enormous consequences during World War II when such brilliant men were not to be found in Stalin's staff.

- 3.7 Stalin's purge of the Red Army reached levels that seem incomprehensible to us. He killed three of the five marshals of the Red Army, 13 of the 15 army commanders, 8 of 9 admirals, 50 of 57 army corps commanders, 154 out of 186 division commanders, 25 of 28 army corps commissars, all 16 army commissars. Voicing disapproval of Stalin's purge was itself grounds for arrest. One woman was turned in. She commented that Mikhael Tukhachevsky, who had been marshal of the Soviet Union, was a handsome man. As a result of this, she was sentenced to 10 years for praising an enemy of the people, an enemy of the people who had been the pride and joy of the Soviet Union just days prior.
- 3.8 What Stalin unleashed with his great terror was an assault on civil society itself. Now, the bourgeois idea is that people working together, neighbors, family members, colleagues at work, students at your school, by working together collaboratively, you create the basis for what makes a society strong. But in the eyes of Stalin, this is the basis for a conspiracy. Parents were turned against children, neighbor against neighbors, husbands against wives. Any connection that was private was a threat to the common good, by which he meant himself.
- 3.9 Entire ethnicities were rounded up and deported to sever the connections between the people and their ancestral lands. The Cossacks were deported in the early 1930s, with parents and children automatically separated from one another in the process. Greeks who were in the Soviet Union were accused of plotting to hand over Ukraine to Greece, and 200,000 of them would be deported as a consequence of this insane claim. Half of Kazakhstan's eventual population consisted of people exiled from other lands.
- 3.10 In 1937, one order from the secret police demanded ethnic cleansing for the arrest of all remaining Polish war prisoners, all Polish refugees, and all anti-Soviet activists from Polish-speaking regions of the Soviet Union. This led to the arrest of people who simply had Polish-sounding last names, and the guards were instructed to "beat the Poles for all you are worth," which resulted in plenty of confessions from innocent people. As a result of this one order, over 100,000 people were executed without trial.
- 3.11 Jewish Socialists who escaped Hitler to the Soviet Union were accused not just of being filthy refugees, but also accused of being spies for the Nazis. Over half a million Jews were executed while others were sent to prison camps. German, Austrian, Yugoslav, Italian, Bulgarian, Finnish, Baltic, English, and French communists who emigrated to the

Soviet Union with this promise of building a better land were all shot or imprisoned. Thousands of Polish communists who fled Hitler were executed in 1937 alone.

- 3.12 Collecting stamps, speaking Esperanto, or even having a pen pal were grounds for arrest because now you're a spy, right? A veterinarian was arrested for treating dogs that belonged to foreigners. The Ukrainian writer Isaac Babel, his works remain with us, he had a worldwide reputation during his lifetime. But because he was friends with the French author, André Malraux, he was tortured and executed as a spy. We can see him on the left in happier times, and we could see him on the right after they got their hands on him.
- 3.13 Pravda and Izvestia were the two biggest Soviet periodicals. At one point, their entire staffs, almost entirely, were disappeared. Not only was contact with the outside world grounds for the death penalty, so was simply being a foreigner because you knew too much about reality. The American Communist Party saw African Americans as a target to further their cause, understandably in the 1930s, given the position of black Americans in the United States. There was even a pamphlet called *The Negroes in a Soviet America*, promising the former confederacy to be handed over to black Americans to govern as their own.
- 3.14 As a result of this, more than a few black Americans went to the Soviet Union as part of the outreach, to try to build a better world for themselves and their families. Jamaican engineer Robert Robinson immigrated to the USSR in 1930. Years later, he admitted that "every single black I knew in the 1930s who became a Soviet citizen disappeared within seven years." We'll never know what happened to them, but it's pretty clear what did.
- 3.15 In 1937 and '38, the terror turned to members of the government itself. The following people were all arrested—commissar for heavy industry, finance, agriculture, interior trade, education, military industry, justice, state farms, communications, sea and river transport, the chairman of the state bank, the secretary of the central executive committee, the Ukrainian Prime Minister, all his deputies, and 99 of the 102 members of the Party Central Committee. In 1936, Stalin introduced a new constitution. Everyone who worked on it were later executed as traitors. The President of the Belorussian Republic killed himself as well.
- 3.16 As Yezhov himself put it, "We are launching a major attack on the enemy. Let there be no resentment if we bump someone with an elbow. Better that 10 innocent people should suffer than one spy get away. When you chop wood, chips fly." What this meant in practice, I think anyone here can understand. This created an enormous sense of paranoia within the population as people understandably were led to the belief that there were spies everywhere and there was their duty to turn those spies in.
- 3.17 When Chopin's funeral march was played the same day that Zinoviev and Kamenev were executed, a radio listener wrote in to ask if this was a signal from Trotsky.

Illiterate peasants were accused of being Trotskyites, and they went to jail asking what it meant to be a [Trotskyite]. One prisoner explained, "Every Soviet citizen is suspected of espionage if he has ever been abroad or been associated with a foreigner. And of course, every foreigner is suspect." By association, they meant any correspondence with relatives, friends, acquaintances, or professional colleagues abroad. People who had earlier been sent by the government itself abroad to study were suspected of espionage because of those journeys. So were the employees of diplomatic and trade missions abroad. Of course, any encounter with a foreigner inside the Soviet Union was itself dangerous.

- 3.18** The manner in which these arrests were made were not exactly meant to keep the population in a state of comfort. It was the middle of the night. You'd hear a car stopping in the street in a time when very few people had cars. You'd hear the men walking up the stairs and pounding on the door when everyone in the building was asleep. The location was searched, the suspect taken away. The Russians, with our sense of dark humor, would joke how relieved they were that someone knocked on the door in the middle of the night to tell them the building was on fire. Smart people knew to pack a bag in the expectation that possibly they would be arrested. Parents vanished without saying goodbye to their kids because they were told they'd be back home momentarily.
- 3.19** One of those arrested later described the typical experience. From the moment he's arrested, the prisoner is kept in constant suspense. No matter what is done to him or where he is taken, he's given no explanation. This permanent uncertainty and complete helplessness in the grip of a silent, uncanny power produces in every prisoner exactly what is expected to produce, fear. He begins to fear every change in his condition. Perhaps it may be a change for the better, but he's afraid anyhow. The NKVD plays with virtuoso skill upon this fear. Even when the prisoner is not called for interrogation, he's never allowed to settle down. Women will be taken into staircases, stripped naked in order to lift their hands up. Every crevice is examined in the apartment building in view of their neighbors.
- 3.20** Men were treated no better. Anything that could be used to harm oneself or somebody else was confiscated. Glasses were taken away because, of course, you could break your glasses and slit your wrists. Prisoners were packed shoulder to shoulder in rooms with hot air, of people desperate to breathe, in cells where people were kept in complete isolation for months or even years at a time. Some were kept in solitary confinement for so long that they'd lost the ability to speak because the muscles of their mouths became atrophied from a lack of someone to talk to.
- 3.21** The enemies of the people were reduced to nothing more than animals. The whole process of the disintegration of personality took place before the eyes of everyone in the cell. A man could not hide himself even for an instant. Even his bowels had to be moved on the open toilet right in front of the room. He wanted to weep. If he wanted

to weep, he had to weep before everybody. If he wanted to kill himself, he would quickly be discovered by one of the cell's insomniacs and prevented from finishing the job. Prisoners were forbidden to talk, shout, sing, write on the walls of the cell, leave marks or signs anywhere in the prison, stand by the window, or attempt to communicate with those in other cells in any way. Napping was forbidden, and strong electric lights throughout the prison were never turned off.

- 3.22** What was fascinating is many of the interrogators would grow frustrated by the prisoners who refused to confess to their crimes. They knew that the prisoner was perfectly innocent, but it was just a matter of getting them to sign the confession that everyone knew was fake. As a result of this, it frustrated them because it was taking up precious time that they could be spending elsewhere. The crazier the reason for your arrest, the harder it was to prove your innocence. One Czech citizen was reported as having had to confess that he became a German spy early in the First World War, at a time when neither Czechoslovakia or the Soviet Union even existed.
- 3.23** People wrote letter after letter to the authorities in hopes of reaching someone who would release them, many to Stalin himself, with the claim being, "Oh, if only Stalin knew." The ones who were the most loyal to the party, the ones who were the most loyal to Stalin, were the ones who took the longest to realize what was being done to them. The guards understood the situation very well. As one admitted to his captive, "We never arrest anyone who's not guilty. Even if you weren't guilty, we can't release you because then people would say we're picking up innocent people."
- 3.24** This led to some questions in the West because, if you have this conspiracy, and there's hundreds of thousands of people confessing and being killed, how is it that this gigantic conspiracy, which reaches the top of the military, the top of the secret police, the top of the different governments in the republic, and the head of the USSR, only managed to kill one person, Kirov? That defies belief.
- 3.25** There was someone named John Dewey. He was the dean of American progressivism, the Dewey Decimal System, and he had a lot of work to do with education, progressive education. He formed what was called the Dewey Commission. They investigated these different claims about the guilt, the false guilt, of those men who were put on trial. As he put it, as the commission concluded, "It is hardly credible that, had all these men decided to overthrow the Soviet government through terrorism, they would have gone about it through such amateurish ways." So what did Stalin do? He created new victims, and perhaps the first imaginary victims in Soviet history.
- 3.26** Maxim Gorky remains known as one of the greatest writers of all time. He died in 1968. Valerian Kuybyshev had been a member of the Politburo who had died at age 46 in 1935. He'd been one of Stalin's closest economic advisors. And finally, Vyacheslav Menzhinsky, he'd been chairman of the secret police for eight years before dying in 1934. So, if we can prove that these three men had been murdered, that would mean

that Kirov wasn't the only victim of these terrorists. So, who could they blame? They blame the doctors.

3.27 The most outstanding heart specialist in the USSR was someone named Dimitry Pletnyov, and one of Yezhev's secret police operatives accused him of having bitten her in the breast, and the newspapers ran with it. He became known as the sadist Pletnyov. He was denounced by his former friends and students, not that they had much of a choice. Another target, Dr. Levin, had treated both Stalin and his daughters, and Dr. Kazhekov was the third target of these accusations. One at a time, the men were sat down and told what they had done. They had took Gorky from an overheated room into freezing cold over and over until he died, and they had their hands in the deaths of the other two. Pletnyov was spared death, but the other two doctors were executed. In any event, Kirov was now not only the only one who had been the victim of this nationwide conspiracy.

3.28 How did they get these men to confess to crimes, not only that they didn't commit, but that were literally impossible? Well, they were nothing, if not creative. We know someone named Konstantin Rokossovsky. He was 40 years old. When he was arrested, he was a brilliant military man. So they broke his ribs and they smashed his toes with a hammer. They pulled out his nails and they pulled out nine of his teeth as well. When that was not enough, they told him he was going to be executed. They took him in front of firing squads, but they never actually shot him. He didn't break, and eventually he was freed, and he worked alongside Stalin against Hitler with a smile full of new steel teeth. But he was one of the lucky ones.

3.29 Someone whose name is now lost to history, we call him Comrade Ivanov, was an old Bolshevik. He had repeatedly been arrested by the Tsar. After the revolution, him and his wife made the mistake of siding with Trotsky. They were deported to Siberia before being brought back in a prison in Moscow in 1936. For four months, they tried to break him, but old Bolsheviks do not break so easily. What are four months in a prison to someone who's done 10 years doing hard labor in some god-forsaken corner of Russia, right?

3.30 So Yezhov himself decided, "OK, what is taking so long?" So all he had to do was call the man's mother-in-law in front of him. He said, "This is the NKVD. Comrade Ivanov wants to know how his children are." The mother-in-law says, "It's the middle of the night. The young boy is asleep." Yezhov asked, "Ivanov, do you want me to give her a message?" And Ivanov understood what was happening. He got to tell her to take good care of the boy. So the Bolsheviks did in months what the Tsar couldn't do in a decade. They broke him. He cried when they hung up the phone, and he signed whatever confession they put in front of him.

3.31 In 1935, the Soviet government lowered the age of criminal responsibility to age 12, partly with the aim of threatening those in prison with the arrest of their children if they refused to confess to their crimes. In effect, hostage-taking was legalized. It's

amazing what human beings will do when their families are threatened and when they're aware of how little they can do to save their children. Eventually, every inquisitor of the secret police was obliged to have on his desk during the interrogation the law which decreed the application of the death penalty to children.

- 3.32** But this isn't even the worst of what was done. This is Stanislav Kosior. It's an unusual photo for the Soviets because he's right below Stalin. Stalin is laughing and rubbing his bald head. From 1928 to 1938, he had been first secretary of the Communist Party of Ukraine, a very important position. In December 1933, he blamed, of course, the kulaks for what had happened and thanked Stalin for Stalin's good work during that whole situation, but he knew too much. In 1938, he was pulled to Moscow to be the deputy prime minister of the USSR, not a minor position. In May 1938, he was arrested.
- 3.33** We don't know what they did to Stanislav Kosior. The most common means of torture is the conveyor, by which you're sat down and interrogated for hours. When your interrogator gets tired, a fresh interrogator is brought in and so on and so forth, and all your words are being used against you as you're deprived of sleep and basic human necessities. The goal was to get the complete disintegration of an individual's personality. Other methods are, of course, sleep deprivation. People were beaten. They gouged out eyes, perforated eardrums, pulled out fingernails and toenails, broke arms and legs, burned their victims with red hot irons, and mutilated sex organs. Others were beaten until their eyes popped out of their head. And prisoners who were beaten to death were legally registered as having had heart attacks.
- 3.34** We don't know what Kosior did because none of us know what torture is like. The closest analog we have is some Hollywood movie, and it's Liam Neeson tied to a chair, and his lip is split, and his hair is tousled, and he's spitting defiance in the face of his captor. But of course, this is a complete fiction. We don't know if Kosior was defiant. We don't know if he didn't talk. We don't know if he yelled, raised his voice. What we do know is that he wouldn't break, and this was a problem. We also don't know if they had their trump card in the back pocket the whole time or if they were forced to desperate measures by his intransigence.
- 3.35** What we do know is that, eventually, interrogators brought Kosior's teenage daughter, Tamara, and raped her in front of him, and that did it. That broke Stanislav Kosior. He confessed. He managed to outlive her because, shortly thereafter, she committed suicide by throwing herself under a train. Whether her death should be counted as one of the NKVD's victims, I will leave to historians to determine. I doubt that she is who the New York Times had in mind when they ran their 2017 editorial about how women had better sex under socialism, specifically referring to Eastern European communism.
- 3.36** These trials as a whole left foreigners with a logical dilemma. Former communist, Granville Hicks, put it, "If these men were innocent, the administration of the Soviet Union was a vicious, ruthless tyranny. But if on the other hand, they were guilty, then the leadership of the Communist Movement had been desperately corrupt from the

very beginning." But the show trials worked specifically on those people in the West who were the influencers of their time. As George Orwell put it, "What was frightening about these trials was not the fact that they happened, for obviously such things are necessary in a totalitarian society, but the eagerness of Western intellectuals to justify them."

- 3.37** As one literary critic put it, "In any view of the American cultural situation, the importance of the radical movement of the '30s cannot be overestimated. It may be said to have created the American intellectual class, as we now know it, in its great size and influence. It fixed the character of this class as being, through all mutations of opinion, predominantly of the left." And quite apart from opinion, the political tendency of the '30s defined the style of the class. From that radicalism came the moral urgency, the sense of crisis, and the concern with personal salvation that marked the existence of American intellectuals.
- 3.38** In fact, the same exact day that Kosior was arrested, a letter was republished in the New Masses, that's specifically on May 3rd, 1938, signed by a ton of these influencers, insisting that, "We, the undersigned, are fully aware of the confusion that exists with regard to the Moscow trials and the real facts of the situation of the Soviet Union, and that these trials have, by sheer weight of evidence, established a clear presumption of guilt of the defendants." In fact, most newspapers have discarded the earlier charges of frameup and now admit the validity of the trials, and that any confusion about whether these people were guilty was in part due to obscure the truth about the achievements of the Soviet Union as recorded by honest progressive opinion, including magnificent gains in industry and agriculture.
- 3.39** The influencers agreed with Stalin that the defendants resorted to duplicity and conspiracy and allied themselves with long-standing enemies of the Soviet Union, and degeneration may therefore be charged to the defendants and not to the Soviet Union, which gained strength internally and externally by the prevention of treason and the eradication of spies and wreckers. Eradication, of course, here being the death penalty. And wreckers, of course, meaning someone who doubts Stalin's wisdom. The influencers asked American leftists to, quote, "support the efforts of the Soviet Union to free itself from insidious internal dangers."
- 3.40** As the motto went at the time, "Communism is 20th-century Americanism." Journalist Eugene Lyons pointed out that these influencers gave every benefit of the doubt to an omnipotent state and its firing squads, rather than to its victims. There were no intellectual acrobatics which the fellow travelers would not undertake to save their lovely faith in Russia. Year after year, they had accepted and explained away horror and super-horror, falsification of history, corruption, terror, manmade famine, the death penalty for minor thefts, the punishment of relatives for alleged crimes committed by members of their family thousands of miles away, capital punishment for young children, concentration camps with the population running into millions.

3.41 The love affair with Stalin was even stronger in the UK than it was in the US. H. G. Wells, author of *The Time Machine* and *The Invisible Man*, *War of the Worlds*, was an enormous fan of Stalin and managed to get an interview with him in 1934. No mean feat. He told Stalin that "it seems to me, I'm more to the left than you." Meaning, if H. G. Wells is part of the Overton window, Stalin is basically a moderate. As he also put it, "I have never met a man more candid, fair, and honest," speaking of Stalin. "And it's to these qualities and to nothing occult and sinister that he owes his tremendous undisputed ascendancy in Russia."

Lecture 4: Poor Judgments, Harsh Realities

At a glance — Poor judgments and harsh realities, including Western intellectuals' admiration for Stalin.

- 4.1 H.G. Wells was not alone in his love affair with Joseph Stalin. George Orwell, whose name is still widely known to us today, could not get his publisher to publish his memoir of his work in the Spanish Civil War called *Homage to Catalonia* because he was too critical of the work of the Stalinists that he fought alongside. As he put it, "The upshot is that, if from time to time you express a mild distaste for slave labor camps or one-candidate elections, you are either insane or actuated by the worst motives."
- 4.2 Other outlets like *The Nation* and the *New Republic*, which are still with us today, opined upon these trials. When *The Nation* heard about the so-called Trotskyist trial, they wrote, "It was to be expected that under the velvet glove of the new Soviet Constitution, there would be still the firm outlines of the Iron Hand. There can be no doubt that dictatorship in Russia is dying and that a new democracy is slowly being born." As Eugene Lyons wrote, "The impending death of thousands of communists was thus another confirmation that the dictatorship was dying."
- 4.3 Loyalty to family is a quintessentially bourgeois virtue, and this is something else that Stalin turned his guns against. Being married to an enemy of the people was in itself now a felony, one which you could very little say to proclaim your innocence against. Starting in 1934, if a military man was abroad and fled, not only his spouse, but his entire family would get sent to a prison camp. And under Soviet equality, this applied from the lowest to the highest. Mikhael Kalinin was the Soviet Union's head of state, and in 1938, his wife was arrested, tortured, and sentenced to 15 years for supposedly being aligned with Trotsky.
- 4.4 Vyacheslav Molotov, who was the Soviet Union's second-in-command—we still have his name from the Molotov cocktail, which was used not by the Russians, but against the Russians by the Finns—his wife was arrested and sentenced to five years in a labor camp. Stalin took out members of his own family. His first wife was widowed, and he arrested her brother, her mother, and his second widow's brother-in-law was shot.
- 4.5 School children were taught the lesson of Pavlik Morozov, a young boy who turned in his kulak father to the authorities for supposedly hoarding grain, for which Pavlik was killed by his dad. There were statues built to him, and the lesson to the children was perfectly clear. If your parents are doing something that is against the law, meaning against the Communist Party, turn them in, even if it costs you your own life.
- 4.6 The children themselves were not immune from being arrested. It took only one night of interrogation to get a 10-year-old boy to admit that when he was seven, he had joined a fascist ring. Other children who were not suspects themselves were forced to denounce and approve of the arrests of their parents. They were brought up in front of

their whole schools and berated until they confessed that it was a good thing that mom or dad had been taken away. This is not something that had been new to Stalin. This was happening from the very beginning. Sergei Maslov wrote about a May 1920 arrest of a group of Moscow pickpockets between the ages of 11 and 15. May 1920, this is when Woodrow Wilson was still in the White House.

- 4.7 As he wrote, "The children were confined in a cellar and isolated from the other prisoners. Threats and promises of reward were alternately used to make them point out their accomplices. They were dragged daily about the town on trams, in motor cars, and taken to railway stations to point out their accomplices. At first, they pretended they didn't know anyone. Then they were beaten that night and began to betray their associates. This torture went on for two weeks. If the child had the bad luck not to meet or point out a comrade, he would be cruelly beaten. To escape the savage punishment, the children finally pointed out innocent boys who they did not know." Maslov writes how the adult inmates "had never heard such heart-rending cries as those of the children when they understood that they were going back to the cellar."
- 4.8 There was a moment when children in large cities tried to organize for their rights. They called themselves Revenge for Our Parents, and they issued a leaflet arguing against the mass arrest of so many loyal citizens. They were all arrested, as well as their siblings and their remaining parents. In this case, the parents were arrested for having failed to denounce the pamphleteers for their counterrevolutionary activities, those pamphleteers being their children. Calling attention to the needs of such children was in and of itself taken as criticism of the government because why are you being so soft on enemies of the people? One day there'd be a family, dad's arrested, mom's taken after, and the next day that kid is an orphan. But not only was he an orphan, he's a pariah because no other families wanted to have anything to do with him.
- 4.9 There was much hand-wringing at the Kremlin about all these children who understandably began to take their own lives. We know of one story about a father who tried to take in their daughter's friend, who was 13, who was left without parents after both were arrested. He went to the NKVD secretary for advice about what to do because he knew he was putting himself and his family at risk. The secretary said, "It's a delicate matter, but it is improper for you to keep her. My advice to you is, try to get rid of her." He did as he was advised, put her out in the street. Her fate can be imagined, but perhaps shouldn't be.
- 4.10 Class warfare meant that people could be punished for the circumstances of their ancestors. It became commonplace for young people to denounce their families and repudiate their bourgeois origins, often with their parents' support and approval, in order to save themselves. Things reached demented levels. The author Sheila Fitzpatrick recounts the story of one communist who informed on his mother-in-law before being arrested for being related to her.

- 4.11 Karl Marx very famously wrote that "religion is the opium of the people," and the communists took particular pride in turning religious people against their faith. Soviet newspapers were full of letters from priests renouncing and denouncing religion. Even more intense were moments when worshippers in church sat in horror while their priest told them that religion was deceit and that he no longer wanted to be a weapon in the hands of counterrevolutionaries, whereupon he ripped off his vestments and left the church. The assault on religion was something that had been there from the very beginning and continued through the end of the Soviet Union's existence. Instead of God, there was only one man, and that man was Joseph Stalin.
- 4.12 You might not know this man's face, but you probably know his name. This is Upton Sinclair. His book, *The Jungle*, is still read in high school. It was an exposé, supposedly, about the unsanitary conditions in meatpacking factories. The book ends, spoiler alert, with a worker falling into a vat and being rendered into lard for sale for the general public. They couldn't believe it's not butter. After being serialized in a socialist newspaper, *The Jungle* was published as a book in 1906. Teddy Roosevelt was not a fan of the young Sinclair, but the novel worked its magic. And by June 30th, President Roosevelt was signing into law the Federal Meat Inspection Act and the Pure Food and Drug Act, which became known as the FDA to this day. Sinclair had only been 27 years old, and he was already changing the face of America.
- 4.13 He was part of a new class of journalist activists called muckrakers, who used their influence to promote and help issues that are a great concern to society. Muckraker being, of course, a nice euphemism for shit-stirrer. His explicit purpose in writing *The Jungle* was to spread the message of socialism to the American people. As he put it, "I aimed at the public's heart, and by accident, I hit it in the stomach." Sinclair was a democratic socialist, skeptical of communism. He ran for the House of Representatives in the 1920s as a socialist, the US Senate in 1922. When both those failed, he tried to run for California governor in 1926 and in 1930. In 1934, he chose to run as a Democrat, realizing that 50% of people are going to vote a certain ticket simply because their grandfathers voted that ticket, and in order to get anywhere, it's necessary to have a party which has grandfathers.
- 4.14 He seized the Democratic Party nomination for California governor two years after FDR set record landslides in his defeat of Herbert Hoover. Sinclair had a plan—this is at the height of the Great Depression—called EPIC, End Poverty in California, which was heavily criticized because if the government was going to be guaranteeing work, why wouldn't it cause everyone else from America to go to California and get jobs for themselves at a time when unemployment was at unprecedented levels and not budging? FDR met with Sinclair, and Sinclair left the meeting thinking that FDR was going to come out for his view of having production for use instead of production for profit. But of course, FDR being FDR, loved to have people think that he was on their side when he was on his own.

- 4.15 When FDR finally did give the talk that he promised Sinclair, he did not come out at all for production for use instead of production for profit. In fact, he doubled down and said, "America has what we call an accept as a profit system." He reiterated his view of free enterprise as the basis of the American society. Needless to say, Sinclair did not win his race, and he took it very hard indeed. Sinclair went back and forth with Eugene Lyons, who had been a communist reporter, who went to the Soviet Union and whose views changed very heavily when he saw firsthand what was happening there. Together, they published an exchange of letters called *Terror in Russia?* The question mark being, of course, Upton Sinclair's. As he put it, "It is a fact that the Russians have never learned to govern without killing."
- 4.16 There's something interesting about having Upton Sinclair, the great progressive socialist, advocating mass murder on the basis of tradition. Regarding the Holodomor, he said, "I would venture to doubt that 5 million people were permitted to die, permitted being a very odd choice of words, when people were being forced to hand over all their food." As he put it, "My guess is that it's nearer to 1 million, but that is enough." A million here, a million there. What's the difference? As he put it, "The Russians did it by force because that is the only way anything has ever been done in Russia," even though supposedly the Soviet Union was a new society based on new principles and a complete repudiation of the failed tactics of the past.
- 4.17 He explicitly endorsed the deaths of millions of people, as he put it, and this was shocking to see in writing, to be honest. "My belief is that the million or 5 million lives which were sacrificed will mean the savings of hundreds of millions of lives in future times." There was this expression, I think it was original to Walter Duranty, that you can't make an omelet without breaking a few eggs. We had the broken eggs; where were the omelets? And of course, these broken eggs meant millions of people who were starved to death. Sinclair further lied that there has never been in human history a great social change without killing, that our civil war cost a million lives, and if anyone argues that Lincoln and Grant were mass murderers, the only way you can answer is to point out the gains in the preservation of the Union and the ending of slavery.
- 4.18 Now, to compare lives that are lost in warfare, as opposed to a war against an unarmed citizenry of people who are just trying to feed themselves, is a dubious comparison at best, in my view. As for murdering all these so-called wreckers, Sinclair said, "If such persons were sent into this country and committed wholesale wrecking of machinery and destruction of human life, we would shoot them, and no doubt, other nations which were getting ready to make war on us, would denounce it as a terrible and barbarous action." Needless to say, the amount of people who engaged in industrial sabotage in the United States who were executed for it was hardly in the hundreds of thousands, if any existed at all.
- 4.19 Sinclair insisted that the Russians did have free speech despite what Eugene Lyons saw for himself. How did he know this? Because "more than 3 million of my books have

been translated and published in Russia." As for the victims of these purges, he said, "When they started the war on Stalin, they did so at their own risk and perfectly well knowing it. If the medicine they had to swallow is bitter, the answer is that it is their own medicine, which they have been brewing and administering throughout their political careers." He compared those victims to Benedict Arnold, saying that "he would have been hanged if we had been able to catch him."

4.20 Regarding the trials, which he regarded as obviously phony, he goes, "Over and over, I asked myself, is it conceivable that the revolutionists, trained in a lifetime of war against the Tsar, would go into open court and confess to actions which they had not committed? I ask, is there any torture, any kind of terror, which would induce him to such a thing?" If Upton Sinclair couldn't think of such a thing, obviously it couldn't have happened. That's just how reality works. As historian Robert Conquest put it, "The Stalin epic is replete with what appear as improbabilities to minds unfitted to deal with the phenomena," similarly with the argument that Stalin couldn't have killed millions of peasants since that would have been economically unproductive.

4.21 Writing in 1994, the communist writer Eugene Genovese explained his thinking. He goes, "About 20 years ago, picking up on some passages in Roy Medvedev's book, *Let History Judge*, I wondered if Comrade Stalin had not killed more communists than were killed by all the bourgeois, imperialist, fascist, and Nazi regimes put together. It can't be true, said I. Has Comrade Medvedev taken up serious drinking? So I sat down to do some rough arithmetic. You do not have to be good at math to do that much arithmetic. Alas, Comrade Medvedev had not taken up serious drinking."

4.22 Sinclair further defended Stalin, saying, "Having watched the international policy of the Soviet Union from day to day as it has developed, I say that its record is pretty nearly perfect and that upon that record is entitled to the trust of every friend of democracy and peace." And he said, "I will leave a litmus test to determine whether the Soviet Union has now become counterrevolutionary. When Hitler learns that the Soviet Union has become counterrevolutionary, he will reduce the ardor of his crusade against it. When that happens, I will admit that Stalin has sold out the workers." Not long after that, the Molotov-Ribbentrop pact between Hitler and Stalin was signed, a non-aggression pact between the two. Needless to say, Upton Sinclair did not ever admit that Stalin had, in fact, sold out the workers, and he was not alone.

4.23 On August 14, 1939, a group of self-described 400 leading Americans, influencers of their time, wrote an open letter calling for, quote, "greater unity of the anti-fascist forces and strengthening of the front against aggression through closer cooperation with the Soviet Union." There was no mention of Hitler's crimes. There was no argument that if Hitler wasn't stopped, millions of people would be killed. In fact, they insisted that, on the domestic scene, the reactionaries have "encouraged the fantastic falsehood" that the USSR and the totalitarian states, meaning Mussolini and Hitler, are basically alike. They insisted that it's impossible for any honest person to come to any

conclusion concerning their guilt or innocence of other charges or the nature of their crimes, if any, regarding those who have been put on trial by Stalin.

- 4.24 They defended the Soviet system. They had a list of 10 ways it differed from Hitler, including that the Soviet Union has emancipated women in the family and has developed an advanced system of childcare, as we have seen the children certainly were taken care of, so to speak. They insisted that "the best literature, from Homer to Thomas Mann, the best thought from Aristotle to Lenin, is available to the masses of the Soviet people." They claimed that "the Soviet Union considers political dictatorship a transitional form and has shown a steadily expanding democracy in every sphere." That the new Constitution grants Soviet citizens universal suffrage, everyone can vote for the Bolsheviks. It's great. It's universal.
- 4.25 Civil liberties, the right to employment, to leisure, free education, free medical care, to equality of the sexes in all fields of activity, and to equality of all races and nationalities. The list of credentials of the signatories of this letter is remarkably contemporary. We have Stanford, Smith, Columbia, Harvard, Wellesley, Sarah Lawrence, NYU, Syracuse, Yale, MIT, Vassar, Williams, the University of Chicago, Colgate, Bryn Mawr, the New Yorker, and The Nation. Specifically from Columbia, we had their professor of zoology, who certainly was in a position to advise on keeping beings in captivity. These men and women, it was their job to promote ideas to the American people. They were the creators of public opinion. They had the power to declare an ideology as being mainstream and desirable. Indeed, they defined what mainstream and desirable discourse consisted of.
- 4.26 Hannah Arendt, writing about these so-called fellow travelers, wrote, "The sympathizers who are to all appearances still innocuous fellow citizens in a non-totalitarian society can hardly be called fanatics. Through them, the movements made their fantastic lies more generally acceptable, can make their propaganda in milder and more respectable terms, until the whole atmosphere is poisoned with totalitarian elements which are hardly recognizable as such, but which appear to be normal political reactions or opinions. The fellow traveler organizations surround the totalitarian movements with a mist of normality and respectability that fools the membership about the true character of the outside world, as much as it does the outside world about the true character of the movement."
- 4.27 Days after the letter was published, Hitler not only reduced the ardor of his crusade against the Soviet Union, but signed that non-aggression pact. Shortly thereafter, Hitler invaded Poland from the West, and Stalin followed from the East. American organizations that advocated for involvement in Europe to fight fascism, literally overnight, changed their names to advocating instead of being anti-fascist before peace, fearing US involvement in what Stalin was doing.
- 4.28 As the 1930s drew to a close, the Great Depression was still plodding along with no end in sight, and the question became if FDR was going to run for an unprecedented third

term. His vice president, "Cactus Jack" Garner, was quite a conservative, and before FDR even made his own decision, he announced that he would be a candidate for the presidency. As such, FDR had to find a running mate. The man he chose was his Secretary of State, Henry Agard Wallace. Wallace was regarded as a bit of a new ager at a time when the term didn't even exist. There were a series of letters he exchanged with this weird Russian theosophist called the Dear Guru letters which were seen as a major scandal to be dealt with. FDR insisted that Wallace was not a mystic, but just a philosopher, a liberal philosopher. And while there was pushback from the Democrats, Wallace had until recently been a Republican, FDR still held power and managed to force his pick of vice president on the convention, something which presidential candidates had previously not been able to do.

- 4.29 In 1944, as FDR was thinking about running for a fourth term, Wallace got himself into a heap of trouble by publishing a pamphlet called *Our Job in the Pacific*. When Roald Dahl, the children's author, got news back to Britain about what it contained, including advocating the decolonization of East Asia, Winston Churchill flipped his shit, got on the phone to the White House, and the Brits were not alone. Wallace had a reputation of being too much of a leftist, even by FDR and standards, when the Democratic Party held complete a monopoly of control.
- 4.30 On July 11th, 1944, three things happened. FDR officially announced that he would be seeking a fourth term. FDR decided to dump Henry Wallace from the ticket, and then FDR met with Wallace to strategize about their forthcoming campaign. Ten days later, and with FDR's covert blessing, Robert Hannegan, who was head of the Democratic Party, and other party insiders, used all their power to make sure that Wallace was removed from the ticket, and Missouri senator Harry S. Truman was nominated as the vice presidential candidate instead. Five weeks after he was inaugurated for an unprecedented fourth term, FDR was posing for an artist, and he either said, "I have a terrific pain in the back of my head," or, "I have a terrific headache," before he keeled over and died.
- 4.31 Harry Truman had been having drinks with the Speaker of the House. The call came for him to go to the White House immediately. He asked First Lady Eleanor Roosevelt, is there anything he could do for her? Her husband had just died. And she goes, "Is there anything we can do for you? You're the one in trouble now." A year after he would have been inaugurated as president, Henry Wallace published a book called *Soviet Asia Mission*, which was about his trips abroad as vice president. As vice president, Wallace had visited Siberia and the Far East, and he discussed his impression of the people and the places that he saw. And while FDR was administrating concentration camps for Japanese Americans on American soil, his vice president was touring one in the Soviet Union and offering his approval of the conditions that these concentration camp prisoners faced.

- 4.32 There are very few words from Russian that have made their way into English. People think robot is a Russian word. In fact, it comes from Czech. People also think bistro is a Russian word because it's Russian for quickly, quickly. Supposedly, it went from what Russians were yelling at French waiters and then became French, then became English. But there is one word whose Russian origin is not in dispute, Gulag. The Gulag Archipelago, which Solzhenitsyn wrote about very famously, was a series of concentration camps which spread across the Soviet Union, the biggest country in the world.
- 4.33 As one reporter put it regarding what the intellectuals thought of the Soviet Union, "To a good many onlookers, the Russian Revolution is a great experiment. The 160 million inhabitants are the raw material of the experiment, and a formula for economic perfection is its objective. The application of pressure here and there, as required by the research experts, the exiling or physical extinction of a portion of the population, it's all part of the experimental process." Those who are squeamish are just white-livered sentimentalists in a class with vegetarians and anti-vivisectionists. In other words, if you were worried about children killing themselves in concentration camps, you're basically a soy boy. It was the guinea pig theory of revolution. Of course, the animals squeal, but why should superior people be concerned about the noise?
- 4.34 When you peer down from above, watching objectively, the Russians look quite small. Jean-Paul Sartre, the famous French existentialist, said, "As we were not members of the party, it was not our duty to write about Soviet labor camps." And he said, "I find these camps intolerable, but I find it equally intolerable the use made of them every day in the bourgeois press." Sure, we're imprisoning entire families and starving people to death, but it's just as bad to make a fuss about it.
- 4.35 Theodore Dreiser was one of the great naturalist writers of all time. His books, *Sister Carrie* and *Jennie Gerhardt*, are still read today. As he put it, "It seems to me, whether badly managed or well managed, that it is at least a setup, the Soviet Union, which should be preserved and fought for. If that means serious and in some cases seemingly cruel sacrifices, it is, as we say, just too bad. But after all, if by any process whatsoever, this or any other, Russia is seriously crippled or destroyed, what good would freeing those prisoners do?"
- 4.36 As Henry Wallace toured the Gulag in the Siberian town of Magadan, he discussed how over 40 million people have taken the place of the previous seven million who existed there under imperial Russia, meaning under the Tsar. He compared it to the Wild West. In the same way that Americans pushed triumphantly to the Pacific and created Los Angeles, San Francisco, Portland, and Seattle, this is what the Russians are doing with Siberia and the Far East. He repeated the Russian propaganda when he said, "Twelve years ago, the first settlers arrived and put up eight prefabricated houses, and today, Magadan has 40,000 inhabitants and all are well housed." He went on to say, "The

remarkable fact is that this Siberian urban growth is taking place in advance of rail and motor road communications."

- 4.37 He was oblivious to the fact that all these trips to Siberia were both one way and permanent. He insisted that "the people of Siberia today are a hardy, vigorous race, but not because they are whipped into submission. The only whip driving them is the necessity to master a vast new land." They're basically cowboys. It's like the Lone Ranger. As of 2020, farmers were still uncovering dozens of bodies of people who had been executed over there by the secret police.
- 4.38 They literally put on a song and dance performance for Wallace, the prisoners did, and he said, "I don't think I've ever seen anything better put on by the talent of a single city." What he did not realize was that the conductor was a prisoner, the lead ballerina was a prisoner, and the choir were all prisoners. The captives had rehearsed all night and signed an oath to comport themselves as Soviet patriots, and the two singers who had known English were shipped away. And when the vice president's show ended, the prisoner performers were loaded back into trucks and returned to the camp.
- 4.39 Wallace further insisted that there exist "no two other countries more alike than the Soviet Union and the United States of America." This was the vice president. And insisted that the people of the United States should have been taught the truth about the Russian Revolution from the very start. I would agree with him. "There is nothing irreconcilable about our aims and purposes, and those who so proclaim are wittingly or unwittingly looking for war." And that is, in my opinion, criminal. Why denouncing labor camps would lead us to war is a question I would leave for Wallace and his defenders to answer.
- 4.40 In fact, it was Orwell himself who pointed out that when Wallace was asked by a newspaper interviewer why he issued falsified versions of his speeches to the press, Wallace replied, "Oh, so you're one of those people who are clamoring for war with Russia?" As for what Stalin had done to the Ukrainians, Wallace dismissed the concerns. He put it, "Collective farming to Stalin was a method of making agriculture more productive, of getting the food surplus necessary to support urban workers. We in the United States may regard the methods employed as too costly in human terms." Killing millions of people, that's just your opinion, man.
- 4.41 Decades after Wallace's visit, the hidden history of the Gulag system was better understood. Its roots lay in the bizarre katorga system of prisons, which held so many revolutionaries before the revolution. That said, in 1916, there were fewer than 30,000 total prisoners held by the Tsar, but the Gulag routinely held 2 million people at a time. Though the Gulag system greatly was expanded under Stalin, by 1921, Lenin was already running 84 camps for potential enemies and those deemed to be undesirable elements. That number hit 30,000 camps under Stalin, and it was under his reign that the camps began to be used for slave labor.

- 4.42 Solovetzky is regarded as the first Gulag camp, and in 1926, that's where the concept of using forced labor as a method of reeducation first began to be implemented. In 1923, there were a few hundred prisoners there, mostly political foes and former allies of the Bolsheviks. By 1925, there were 6,000, including those who fought that Kronstadt rebellion. That winter, a quarter of them died due to the terrible conditions they were under, including workload, poor food, and an epidemic of typhus, a disease which is spread by lice.
- 4.43 The guards regularly left undressed prisoners in the cold. They would put prisoners to the bench, meaning they were forced to sit on poles for up to 18 hours without moving, sometimes with weights tied to their legs and their feet not touching the floor, a position guaranteed to leave them crippled. Sometimes they were made to go naked to the baths up to 2 kilometers away in freezing weather. They were given rotten meat on purpose. They were refused medical help. At other times, they were simply given pointless tasks, simply for them to do something. In other words, to move snow from one place to another or to jump off bridges into rivers whenever a guard shouted "dolphin."
- 4.44 Rounding up people and bringing them via train to the far east was hardly an idyllic trip. Lice and the diseases they carried were, of course, ubiquitous. The simple need to relieve oneself was used as a mechanism of control by the guards or simply in exercising cruelty. All it took was one prisoner losing bowel control or getting sick to turn the atmosphere in the carriage even more unbearable. It often took a month for the trip from Moscow to the Gulag region of Kolyma, a month in which a prisoner was literally removed from his former life and basic human civilization.
- 4.45 The captives would often go days without any water, and when they were fortunate enough to receive their one full cup, they would have to choose between drinking it all at once or rationing it throughout the day. Passengers who stuck their cups between the window bars to catch rain would be threatened with getting shot, and it was not an idle threat. Stops to discard the dead was a common occurrence, and it goes without saying that many of the children and infants aboard the train cars never made it to the camps. Mothers often killed themselves, slitting their throats with glass, or sometimes grew mad in the conditions, forcing their infants to be taken care of by others.
- 4.46 Those who survived the train ride were still not done because the Kolyma camps were only reachable by boat, and the juvenile delinquents who so plagued the prison system were found there as well. Now, they served a purpose of keeping the captives in a state of fear, for they reveled in being abusive toward the adults by spitting on them or urinating on them. And actual criminals were part of this trip as well, seizing control of the ship's plank. Literal murderers and the like, they far outnumbered the guards who themselves were often too afraid to interfere or simply didn't care. Indeed, the criminals were told explicitly, "You have broken the law and must pay the penalty for it. But you are not enemies of the people. The enemies of the people are the

counterrevolutionaries, and they alone are responsible for everything that goes wrong in our country. They must be annihilated."

- 4.47 Guards would be threatened or bribed by criminals to let men into the separate women's hold, gangs of whom had their way with the female captives, one after another. One eyewitness describes such a raid. "Several men attacked each woman at once. The woman bit, cried, and wailed. The rapists smacked them back. When the rapists ran out of women, some of the bulkier men turned to the bed boards and hunted for young men. These adolescents were added to the carnage, lying on their stomachs, bleeding and crying on the floor. The male captives sat there watching the whole thing. Anyone who tried to assist would be crushed to death. And after the raid, the guards blasted the hold with water, and they went out and dragged out both the women who had been injured and those who had been killed."
- 4.48 Much of the skepticism about the conditions in the Soviet Union was based on the very logical premise that this maltreatment made no sense, for a large number of the captives who finally reached the camps were useless in terms of labor, due to the horrors they had suffered en route, horrors that in some cases could have been prevented simply by giving them some water. But that would have been extra work for the guards who had little incentive to lift a finger to assist a group of people who had been officially declared to no longer be members of the human race.
- 4.49 Arriving at the camps, the guards were greeted by various signs, with one example being the claim that, "With just work, I will pay my debt to the fatherland," something that the Nazis later mocked with their slogan over Auschwitz, "Arbeit macht frei," work makes you free. Signs reminded prisoners that he who does not work does not eat, but even he who worked did not eat much either. Being too weak to fulfill one's work quota was taken as evidence of being a counterrevolutionary. Here, at last, was proof that we have the wreckers, because they're not fulfilling their quota, even in the camps.
- 4.50 In 1937, during the Great Terror, the nature of the camps took an even more dark turn. Stalin now sent regional quotas to the NKVD, telling them how many people he expected to be arrested with the numbers broken down by each given region. It became their role to find that number of men and women to arrest and send away. For example, if Stalin said he wanted to find 10,000 criminals in the Turkmen Soviet Socialist Republic, the secret police would arrest 10,000 people, regardless of whether that many criminals existed there or not.
- 4.51 The Gulag became a place where the deaths of prisoners was not an accident or a cost, but a goal. Outdoor work in the camps was compulsory all year long, only pausing if the temperature reached 58 degrees below zero Fahrenheit. Working inside was not much better. Coal miners had to deal with water dripping on them, causing severe short-term and long-term consequences. In 1937 as well, Stalin decided the prisoners were being treated too well. So afterwards, it was forbidden for them to use fur to stay warm, and

they had to use wadding for protection and walk in canvas shoes instead of felt boots, if they had even been given shoes at all, which they often did not.

- 4.52** Soviet sources themselves admit that, in many of these camps, the death rate reached 97 to 98% of the inmates. When one free citizen tried to warn camp administrators what's going on and all the people who are dying, he said, "What people? These are the enemies of the people." Other officials were as blunt, saying, "We are not trying to bring down the mortality rate." Not only do they have to work interminably, they're also subjected to workshops where speakers blather political ideology at them. As one camp survivor recalled, "For hours and hours, the lecture went on, trying to prove that God did not exist, that he was some bourgeois invention, that we were lucky to be living in the greatest country on Earth. They didn't just want to oppress us. They wanted us to thank them for it."
- 4.53** Personers often had to be beaten in order to get them to bathe in the freezing cold rooms, where they would then have to stand around naked afterwards. The Gulag food was disgusting even by prison conditions. Sometimes it was watery soup with fish heads or a piece of fat floating inside. Some prisoners were forced to eat outside where the food invariably froze. Religious people were a specific target of the Soviet Union. One group of female prisoners refused to wear numbered clothing due to the dictates of their religion, so the numbers were stamped directly on their skin. In 1930, another religious group regarded Soviet passports, money, and the like as symbols of the Antichrist. They were shipped to an island in the West Sea and told they could have food only if they signed for it. When they repeatedly refused, they were simply left there to starve to death, which they naturally all did.
- 4.54** Diseases of malnutrition were almost universal in the camps. Peeling potatoes is a punishment in the American military, but in the Gulag, it was a highly coveted role because then you might have access to some food. The prisons developed their own rules. If a prisoner stole clothes, tobacco, or anything else, he could expect a beating. But if he was caught stealing another person's bread, that earned a death sentence. In typical Russian dark humor, there was a little song about Kolyma. It goes, "Kolyma, wonderful land, 12 months winter, the rest summer." For about two months in winter, there's no sunrise at all.
- 4.55** The brutal cold forced inmates to get creative in order to try to stay warm. One of humanity's earliest mechanisms for staying warm meant that female prisoners and guards often engaged in illicit activity. Any infants who were born as a result of this were taken away from their mothers after a year, handed over to the secret police. The women were told, "You have broken the regulations. Connections with men are not permitted. Therefore, the children are ours, not yours. They belong to the security organs, and we will bring them up." Estimates range as to whether it was 500,000 or up to a million of such infants who were seized over the years who would never be reunited with their mothers.

- 4.56 Those infants still fared better than the children who had been imprisoned in the Gulag themselves, where even being seven years old was not enough to stave off beatings and humiliations. Parentless boys and girls were taken to children's homes, and they had to deal with all of this, as well as sexual assaults, both from older children and the administrators. Those children who grew up in the conditions of the Gulag grew up to become themselves something inhuman, as one former prisoner recalled. "If one of the prisoner's criminal leaders was gambling, lost everything and staked his life as well, the boys would kill him for a day's bread ration or simply for the fun of it, and the girls boasted that they could satisfy an entire team of tree-fellers."
- 4.57 As World War II came around, the regulations became even stricter, and a law was issued that any worker who left his job in a war plant for no matter what reason was subject to from 6 to 8 years of imprisonment. Hundreds of young girls between the ages of 18 and 20 were sent to the camps for running away to their villages because they could no longer endure the starvation in the cities where they had been forced to work. Some had only gone home for a few days to visit a sick mother, but the factory manager would not give them any days off, and when they returned, they were arrested. They came as teenagers to Kolyma and were transformed into full-fledged prostitutes.
- 4.58 Running the Gulag was not a particularly safe position. The chief of the Gulag, Feodor Eihmans, was shot in 1938, and his two successors shot one after another in 1939, all of this feeding into the mentality of "if only Stalin knew." It was their fault, not his. Escape was impossible because there was simply nowhere to go in the Arctic wilderness. In fact, when prisoners escape, the guards often didn't bother searching for them, knowing that they would either return or freeze to death on their own. It's not an exaggeration to say that the entire economy of the Soviet Union was heavily based on the forced labor of hundreds of thousands of innocent people being kept in prison in the camps of the Gulag.
- 4.59 Contact with the outside world was mixed at best. Some prisoners could have visits with family members a couple of times a year, but even that was based on the family knowing where the captive had been taken. And worse, maintaining contact with someone who had been a counterrevolutionary or kulak was very risky. Foods and gifts that were sent to the camps were used as plunder by the guards, and letters were piled up in stacks of thousands by guards who couldn't be bothered to distribute them.
- 4.60 In 1948, as President Truman ran for reelection, Henry Wallace ran against him as the candidate of the Progressive Party. He finished fourth with a little over 2.4% of the vote. But as time went on, information came out from the prisoners who had been there when he had visited Magadan. In fact, one schoolboy at the time said that he remembered the visit very vividly because the most unusual thing was that suddenly the windows of the shops were full of Soviet foodstuffs. God knows where this stuff came from. Of course, as soon as Wallace left, the produce left as well.

4.61 In 1951, a woman named Elinor Lipper, who had been a Swiss national before being caught in the Gulags, and was later liberated, wrote a book called *11 Years in Soviet Prison Camps*. She had been there when Wallace had visited the camps. As she sneered, "Every prisoner who was there at the time owes Mr. Wallace a debt of gratitude, for owing to his visit, that for the first and last time, the prisoners had three successive holidays." In order to make sure that Wallace never saw a single prisoner, they were put in a room and shown movies from morning till night for three days straight. Eventually, by 1952, Wallace realized how badly he'd been had. He said, "I had not the slightest idea when I visited Magadan that this far-north Pacific port was also the center for administering the labor of both criminals and those suspected of political disloyalty. Nothing I saw suggested slave labor. I had not the slightest idea that there were many slave labor camps in Siberia in 1944, and that of these, the most notorious was Magadan."

4.62 In 1952, Wallace admitted, "More and more, I'm convinced that Russian communism, in its total disregard of truth, in its fanaticism, its intolerance, and its resolute denial of God and religion, is something utterly evil." 1952 would have been the end of his second term in office if he had succeeded FDR when he had been FDR's vice president. By this point, Robert Hannegan, who had been head of the DNC, who had worked with FDR to make sure that Wallace wasn't the vice presidential nominee and that Harry Truman would be his replacement, had passed away at the very early age of 46. His tombstone just has his birth date and the date of his death, but he had joked that he had wanted it to read, "Here lies the man who stopped Henry Wallace from becoming president of the United States."

Lecture 5: The Price of Division

At a glance — The price of division — the postwar settlement and a divided Europe.

- 5.1 Hitler and the Nazis were defeated in 1945, and it was the Russians who had reached his bunker first. They proudly raised the hammer and sickle flag of the Soviet Union over the Reichstag as well. The US lost a little bit over 400,000 men in World War II, but the Soviet Union lost between 8 and 12 million in addition to a similar number of civilians. Stalin sent many Russian ex-POWs to the Gulag upon their return to the USSR, both as punishment for having been caught and for knowing too much about the outside world.
- 5.2 After World War II was done, dominion over Eastern Europe was ceded to the Soviet Union by the Western powers. All the land that Lenin had surrendered to Germany under the treaty had been regained by Stalin. Bulgaria, Poland, Hungary, and Romania all had governments installed that answered to Moscow. The Baltic states, Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania, fared even worse. They lost their status as nations and were incorporated into the USSR as new Soviet Socialist Republics. No one knew what to do about the Japanese colony of Korea, so they split it down the middle, and the Soviets had the north, and the West had the south.
- 5.3 On March 5th, 1946, Winston Churchill announced that "an iron curtain has descended across the continent. Behind that line lie all the capitals of the ancient states of central and Eastern Europe —Warsaw, Berlin, Prague, Vienna, Budapest, Belgrade, Bucharest, and Sofia. All these famous cities and the populations around them lie in what I must call the Soviet sphere, and all are subject in one form or another, not only to Soviet influence, but to a very high, and in many cases, increasing measure of control from Moscow." The Cold War had begun.
- 5.4 For a brief period, the United States had been the world's was only nuclear power, but aspiring of Stalinists and fellow travelers in various American-classified agencies delivered the bomb to the Soviet Union by the end of the 1940s. By 1940, Czechoslovakia would also be taken over by a Soviet-led coup, and the Cold War turned violent shortly thereafter when each half of Korea declared itself the rightful government of the entire country. This led to the Korean War with the United States and the newfound United Nations fighting in the south, and Russia and China fighting along the north, and the Korean people paid the price. The war effectively ended in a draw, and the Korean people still to this day remain separated.
- 5.5 Alongside Stalin through all this was the last and perhaps most malevolent of his many accomplices, Lavrentiy Beria. It's him right there. He's not as widely remembered as Nazis like Goebbels or Himmler, but what he's most remembered for is his infamous quote, "Show me the man, and I'll show you the crime." Beria was in charge of the secret police and expanding the Gulag, and he bragged about his ability to get

confessions out of innocent people. "Let me have one night with him and I'll have him confessing he's the king of England."

- 5.6 In typical Russian humor, one anecdote put it that, one morning, Stalin discovered that his favorite pipe was missing, so he called in Beria, instructed him to find the pipe. A few hours later, Stalin found it in his desk and called off a search. "But, Comrade Stalin," Beria said, "five suspects have already confessed to stealing it." Beria bragged about his ruthlessness, saying, "When we, Bolsheviks, want to get something done, we close our eyes to everything else." He was a being of pure ruthlessness. And one of his subordinates said, "Beria is a man for whom it costs nothing to kill his best friend, if that best friend said something bad about him." It's clear why he got along so well with Stalin.
- 5.7 When Beria took over the head of the secret police from Yezhev in 1938, the worst of the Great Terror had receded and the number of victims caught began to decrease. His coup de grâce may have been getting an agent past security and having Trotsky assassinated in Mexico with an ice pick to his head in 1940. For Beria and his conquests, things often got personal. As in the story of the actress Tatyana Okunevskaya, she was a popular actress. Beria invited her to perform, and when she accepted the invitation, he instead took her to a private home where he proceeded to try to get her drunk. Then he began to seduce her.
- 5.8 To further entice her, he promised to free both her father and her grandfather from prison if she went along. He told her, "Scream or not, it doesn't matter." After he had his way with her and let her go, he nevertheless had her arrested and sent to the Gulag, nor did he keep his word about her family because he knew that her father and grandfather had already been executed. She was not alone, for Beria was one of the worst sexual predators of all time. He had his men drive him around Moscow at night looking for women to pick up. Resistance from them would lead to extreme consequences, though compliance was often not better. Fifty years after his death, they're still finding the remains of his victims on the grounds of his former home.
- 5.9 With a bureaucrat's obsessive attention to detail, both him and his bodyguard kept lists of all the women that he engaged with. There remains some dispute as to whether his sexual predations reached literal children or if he contented himself with mere teenagers. Stalin knew. In fact, when he learned his daughter was at Beria's house, he called her in a panic and told her to leave right away. Stalin made that point explicitly when he was faced with criticism as the Red Army made its way west toward Berlin, and the men engaged in assaults on the women citizenry that they encountered. He goes, "How can a man react normally? And what is so awful in his having fun with a woman after seeing such horrors as they've seen?"
- 5.10 After he invaded Poland in 1939, Stalin was stuck with tens of thousands of Polish prisoners of war that included many of the Polish intellectual elite. This had the potential to be a new anti-Soviet power center, which therefore was a threat to Stalin's

power. Beria, Stalin, and other Soviet officials had a discussion. "What should we do about these Polish captives?" They came with the inevitable conclusion, execution. Two years later, things took a sudden turn. Stalin couldn't believe that Hitler broke their pact and invaded the Soviet Union under Operation Barbarossa. For days, the Red Army desperately waited instructions while Stalin was MIA, unable to believe the reports that were being told to him from the front, thinking these were just provocations.

- 5.11 Worse, his purges had wiped out many of the Soviet Union's best and brightest military leaders, just a few years prior. As Stalin himself put it, "Everything's lost." Lenin left us a great legacy, but we, his heirs, have shitted out our asses. As the Nazis worked their way east, they uncovered mass graves in Russia's Katyn forest. It was there that Beria's men had left the remains of all the massacred Polish prisoners of war. It was a huge embarrassment internationally for Stalin, and the Russian claims that these dead were victims of the Nazis were met with great skepticism.
- 5.12 Though Stalin's relationship with Hitler vacillated from rivals to non-aggressors to co-conspirators against Poland to outright foes, there was one group that the two men both despised, the Jews. Even when Stalin met with Churchill and FDR at Yalta to plan against Hitler, Stalin still found time to rant to the US president about how Jews were parasites. His comments were censored from the official record of the conversation. In fact, all Soviet organs remained deliberately silent about the slaughtering of the Jews by the Nazi conquerors of Poland when the Nazis invaded the USSR, and the silence continued even after Hitler invaded the Soviet Union.
- 5.13 In fact, the Jewish populations in the Soviet Union were completely oblivious as to themselves being the targets of the Nazis. When the Germans invaded the Ukrainian town of Korosten, the Jewish population greeted them with food as a welcome. His own family wasn't safe from Stalin's modern pogrom. When Stalin's son Yasha was captured by Hitler's men, Stalin had his Jewish wife arrested as a plotter and thereby left his three-year-old granddaughter without any parents. Yasha killed himself a few months later. When his daughter, Stalin's daughter, fell in love with a Jewish screenwriter, he had the man arrested as a British spy before slapping the hell out of her for good measure. As he screamed, "Such a war is going on, and she's been busy the whole time fucking," even though she'd only shared an innocent kiss with her crush.
- 5.14 As the war proceeded, any Jews in the Soviet Union who felt the need to organize came under great suspicion. The Polish ambassador of the UN demanded the release of the leaders of the Bund, which is Poland's strongest and largest Jewish party, which had fallen into Russian hands. He had been told that "it has been established that they were working on behalf of Germany." When he protested the absurdity of Jews from Poland working on behalf of Hitler, his protests were met with a shrug. "And yet Trotsky turned out to be a German agent." Jews were arrested en masse and put on trial in the

Soviet Union and Soviet-dominated countries. Then those trials were used as proof of a Jewish conspiracy.

- 5.15 In 1948, the Soviet Union became the first country to recognize the newly formation of Israel, expecting it to be a bulwark against the West due to conflict between the Israelis and the former British rulers. When Golda Meir, who was Israel's first ambassador to the Soviet Union, visited Moscow in September of 1948, tens of thousands of Russian Jews came out to welcome her. Stalin ordered the arrest of any one of them who could be identified from photographs of the event.
- 5.16 During World War II, a Soviet organization called the Jewish Anti-Fascist Committee was created to mobilize world opinion to help the USSR fight against Hitler. After the war, any Soviet Jew who wrote to them inquiring about Israel was arrested. Stalin's campaign against the USSR's Jewish population came with the same tortures and farcical accusations as had previously taken place in the Great Terror. Jewish intellectuals and writers began to be systematically driven from their jobs as traitors.
- 5.17 Lina Stern was the USSR's most prominent female scientist. They called her Einstein in skirts, and her discoveries regarding the blood-brain barrier still hold up decades later. That didn't save the 71-year-old woman from arrest. Her interrogators called her an old whore and claimed that when she was at conferences abroad, she was selling her body. And she snapped, "At my age, I would be the one paying." While many of her co-defendants were shot, she managed a lighter sentence of deportation to Kazakhstan.
- 5.18 Now, throughout his life, Stalin liked to drink and he liked to smoke. And even as he entered his 70s, he would host drunken parties that lasted until 5 in the morning, expecting his subordinates to be available, should he decide to ring them in the middle of the night. Now, as his health naturally deteriorated, this was proof that obviously the medical community was trying to kill him, the wreckers, but now they're doctors. Stalin's doctor obviously was the best that the Soviet Union had to offer. When he advised Stalin to take some rest, Stalin repeatedly screamed for the man to be put into irons. He took it not as informed medical opinion, but as an attempt to remove him from power.
- 5.19 Stalin remembered what happened to Lenin after his first stroke. A cadre of doctors were arrested, and Stalin explicitly demanded that they be tortured. He insisted that the interrogators "throw the doctors in chains, beat them to a pulp, and grind them into powder." Once again, virtually all of them confessed to whatever was asked of them. The Soviet press began to increase references to "rootless cosmopolitans" and other euphemisms for Jews that had been popularized by the Nazis. Commissions were set up for the purpose of removing Jews from medical facilities, and Jewish medical school graduates began to be deported to the far east in order to practice.
- 5.20 In fact, letters were published in Pravda, arguing that "Soviet people are naturally outraged by the ever-widening circle of treason and treachery, and the fact that, to our

sorrow, many Jews have helped our enemies to form a fifth column in our midst," arguing that these Jews should be deported and sent to the far east in order to "protect them." Mao's doctor in China was a Soviet Jew. Agents were sent to arrest the man for supposedly trying to poison him. The president of the Jewish advocacy group, B'nai Brith, told the US State Department explicitly that he believed the Soviets have decided upon a campaign of extermination. After all, the Soviet Union already had a functioning concentration camp system.

- 5.21** It seemed as if the Jews would need a miracle to stop the worst from happening again, less than 10 years after what had happened before, and they got one. It's not clear who personally discovered Stalin on March 1st, 1953. After neither his staff nor his subordinates heard from him all day, a brave soul finally decided to enter his chambers to check in on him, and they found him on the floor, immobile, still alive in a pool of his own urine. Now they didn't know what to do. Nothing of import could be done in the Soviet Union without Stalin's approval, yet he was obviously unable to grant it. Beria was informed. He got on the phone, but that only put the sword of Damocles over his head.
- 5.22** He knew perfectly well what happened to his predecessors. If it looked like he was plotting against Stalin, he could be killed. If it looked like he was working with the doctors who were supposedly plotting against Stalin, he could be killed. After hand-wringing, the decision was made to ask the Minister of Health to get help. But there was one major problem. The best doctors in the country would have been the ones assigned to Stalin and other top Soviet officials, and those were the men who Stalin had accused of plotting against him. In what can be seen as either the height of irony or the epitome of farce, the doctors who were being held in government torture chambers began to be asked about medical advice.
- 5.23** One asked, "What specialist would you recommend for one of our most important people who had just had a stroke?" He recommended eight men. Unbeknownst to him, all eight of them were currently imprisoned. The captor still had more questions, and despite his confusion, the physician nevertheless did his best to explain what a Cheyne-Stokes respiration was. He was unaware that the tentative diagnosis reached by the doctors who had been sent to help Stalin were men who were so incompetent that they couldn't figure out how to operate a respirator.
- 5.24** His daughter Svetlana was there to see the end. As she put it, "His death throes were agonizing. For several days, he lay unconscious, choking on his own fluids as a cerebral hemorrhage spread throughout his brain. His face gradually darkened, his lips turned black. He was being slowly strangled. He began vomiting blood at one point, and at what seemed like the very last moment, he suddenly opened his eyes, cast a glance over everyone in the room. Then something incomprehensible and awesome happened that, to this day, I can't forget and don't understand. He suddenly lifted his left hand as

though we were all pointing at something above and bringing down a curse on us all." And with that, Stalin perished.

- 5.25** Just days after his death, the edifice he had built began to be undone. The Gulag system quietly began to be disassembled, and a broad amnesty was declared, liberating miners, mothers with young children, and those serving terms of fewer than five years. Nearly a million total inmates had been released, a mix of political prisoners and criminals, in a nation where the line between the two was often blurred. Publicly, and in unprecedented terms, the government began to acknowledge not just mistakes, but brazen wrongdoing.
- 5.26** The Internal Affairs Ministry released a statement acknowledging the doctors that had been accused were arrested without any legal basis and admitted that they had been tortured into professing their guilt. Pravda referred to the newly freed doctors as "honest and esteemed figures of our state," while also doing a complete reversal on one demonized Jewish writer, now rehabilitating him as "the people's artist of the USSR who has been shamelessly slandered."
- 5.27** But now the question is, what would happen if Beria took over? He would have no issue dispatching those who got in his way. His sadism was well known throughout Kremlin circles, and now Soviet leaders found themselves in a position where they'd have to live in perpetual fear of what tortures Beria would visit upon them and their families. They took fewer than four months after Stalin's death for Beria to be arrested. He was accused of a slew of crimes at a trial in December 1953 and was executed immediately thereafter. In his place, the comparatively unknown Nikita Khrushchev took over as the new leader of the Soviet Union.
- 5.28** Now, Khrushchev was no saint. He had a lot of blood in his hands. He had been party leader for Moscow, taking part in the purges. How much guilt can be ascribed to him personally is a matter of debate because this was a time when it was clearly kill or be killed. Then came February 25th, 1956. For four hours in the middle of the night, Khrushchev delivered a speech called On the Cult of Personality and its Consequences. No journalists or foreigners were permitted to attend. Due to the unusual circumstances under which the talk was held, it has become known as the Secret Speech. Three years after Stalin's death, Khrushchev turned his back not just on Stalin, but on Stalinism itself and from the same rostrum that Stalin had just recently occupied.
- 5.29** Khrushchev opened by talking about how it's impermissible and foreign to the spirit of Marxism-Leninism to elevate one person, to transform him into a superman possessing supernatural characteristics akin to those of a god. Such a man supposedly knows everything, sees everything, thinks for everyone, can do anything, is infallible in his behavior. Khrushchev made it clear he's talking specifically about Stalin and his absolutely insufferable character. He said explicitly that Stalin's confessions were acquired through physical pressures against the accused and that honest communists

were slandered, accusations against them were fabricated, and revolutionary legality was gravely undermined.

- 5.30** Enemies were actually never enemies, spies, wreckers, but were always honest communists. They were only so stigmatized and often no longer able to bear tortures. They charged themselves with all kinds of grave and unlikely crimes. "How is it possible that a man confesses to crimes which he had not committed?" Khrushchev asked. Only in one way, because of application of physical methods of pressuring him, tortures, bringing him to a state of unconsciousness, deprivation of his judgment, taking away of his human dignity. In this manner were confessions acquired.
- 5.31** Khrushchev then gave some credence to the conspiracy theory that the murder of Kirov was not the act of a lone gunman, or of those who ended up paying the price, but possibly of Stalin himself. He pointed out that the agent assigned to protect Kirov was killed in a car accident in which no other occupant of the car was harmed and how top NKVD officials were executed in 1937. We can assume that they were shot in order to cover up the traces of the organizers of Kirov's killing.
- 5.32** He went on to question the very basis of Stalin's Great Terror. He said, "The mass repressions at this time were made under the slogan of a fight against the Trotskyites. Did the Trotskyites at this time actually constitute such a danger to our party and to the Soviet state?" No. Trotskyism was completely disarmed. Stalin put the party and the NKVD up to the use of mass terror when the exploiting classes had been liquidated in our country and when there was no serious reasons for the use of extraordinary mass terror.
- 5.33** Not only was he condemning Stalin's internal rule, he also condemned his role in what led to World War II, talking about how the role of Stalin in our movies, films, and novels was entirely improbable. In fact, Churchill had warned Stalin that the Germans had begun regrouping their armed units with the intent of attacking the Soviet Union. Khrushchev confirmed the mass deportation of entire peoples within the Soviet Union. He joked that the Ukrainians avoided meeting this fate only because there were too many of them and there was no place to which to deport them. Otherwise, he would have deported them also.
- 5.34** Claims which had been made with a straight face under Stalin were now met with laughter, such as the claims that there was a danger of Georgia leaving the Soviet Union and joining Turkey. And yet this was the accusation under which thousands of alleged Georgian separatists have been exiled or killed. And as for that doctor's plot, Khrushchev said, "We found it to be fabricated from beginning to end." Khrushchev concluded, "It is necessary for this purpose to condemn and to eradicate the cult of the individual as alien to Marxism-Leninism."
- 5.35** For many communists around the world, reading the transcript of Khrushchev's speech was the end of the line. They'd been happy for years to dismiss criticism of the Soviet

Union, and Stalin in particular, as capitalist propaganda. There were some claims that this speech was a forgery, but few took such claims to heart. In America and other liberal democracies, party members handed in their cards and quit. It turned out the criticism was true, all of it. The Soviet Union was no worker's paradise. It was a worker's slaughterhouse. As Mikhael Bakunin, Marx's foremost rival, had once said, "When the people are being beaten with a stick, they are not much happier if it is called 'the people's stick.'"

- 5.36** Throughout the Eastern Bloc, a process of de-Stalinization began. Two big exceptions to this were China and North Korea, creating a rift between East and West that was never fully healed. But in other communist nations, Stalin's veneration began to be reversed. The Russian city of Stalingrad had been renamed in his honor in 1925. Khrushchev reverted it to Volgograd. In Prague, there was a 50-foot -tall statue of Stalin leading a group of workers. It took them five years to build it. It was dynamited into nothing. Statue after statue, honor after honor, monument after monument, all began to fall.
- 5.37** Yet the biggest, most famous communist monument was yet to come, and not in the Soviet Union either. That honor would be visited upon the people of Germany, specifically the citizens of Berlin. After World War II, Germany was divided by the Allies into four occupation zones, Soviet, French, American, and British. The German capital of Berlin, which is located entirely inside the Eastern Soviet zone, was itself split into four, as you can see on the map here. Though Germany was still largely in ruins, local elections were held in the Soviet zone in the fall of 1946. The German communists tried to win control of the democratic processes, but despite their efforts, the Social Democrats were the clear victors with 98% of the vote in a three-way race. The communists came in third with 20% of the vote.
- 5.38** In no district did they come in first, not even the ones where they had the majority before Hitler's reign. Russians were in a bind and took appropriate measures. That winter, they began mass arrests of supposed Nazis and subversives. In practice, that simply meant anyone opposed to domination from Moscow, no matter where they landed on the political spectrum. Then came the People's Police, which was a further hardening of authoritarianism under Soviet control. Finally, the Soviets reopened camps. Buchenwald, which was now called NKVD special camp number 2, was near the city of Weimar, and Shachsenhausen, which is number 3, was near the city of Berlin. Close to 200,000 people rounded up and carried away when the world was still reeling from the horrors of the Holocaust. Years later, over 10,000 bodies would be uncovered at Shachsenhausen alone, the majority of whom were children and the elderly.
- 5.39** How to handle Germany was an enormously difficult question, even among the Western countries, of course. The Westerns wanted to reinvigorate Germany as a country partial to them, and this, of course, did not sit well with Stalin. But the Russians were outnumbered three to one by the French, Americans, and the British. Then that June came the introduction of a new Deutsche Mark via the British and the Americans,

and providing a stable currency would have enormous utility in a nation where hunger was rampant, the black market utterly out of control, and memories of Weimar-era hyperinflation were still fresh.

- 5.40** On June 24, 1948, the Soviets did their best to seal off West Berlin from the rest of the country. They closed down the canals, they closed down the railways, they closed down the roads. No one was getting in or out with them knowing about it and approving it. Food, coal, and medicine would soon become urgent problems. Harry Truman was facing another crisis in his accidental presidency. A conveyor belt of planes taking off from West Germany was organized as a response to the Soviet blockade, delivering what was needed to the beleaguered West Berliners. Soon, there was a plane landing in West Berlin every minute, packed to the gills with the necessary goods. Yes, an iron curtain had descended across Europe, but curtains can only reach so high.
- 5.41** The Berlin blockade was a complete disaster for the USSR. Stalin had played hardball, hoping for negotiations and confessions from his former allies, and instead, they told him to eff off. Regardless of one's politics, preventing a civilian population from access to food and medication was widely regarded as not just wrong, but downright unconscionable. The Americans did not hesitate to rub their victory in Stalin's face. When it became apparent that the Russians were under orders to withhold fire, many Western planes intentionally flew in confrontational ways, daring the Soviet forces to do something about it.
- 5.42** Stalin held back from launching what surely would have been World War III. In 1949, West Germany, which was officially called the Federal Republic of Germany, and East Germany, the German Democratic Republic, GDR, became their own country countries. The French, American, and British occupation zones made up the former and would become part of NATO, which is a multinational alliance dedicated to mutual defense, and the Russian zone became the latter, and in 1955, would co-found the Warsaw Pact, which was a counterweight to NATO. The Cold War was hardening into two superpowers with dueling spheres of influence.
- 5.43** Despite East German propaganda and claims of being a worker's paradise, Germans began voting with their feet to immigrate to the West. They didn't have to learn a new language. They didn't have to adapt to new culture. It was the same exact population, so typical barriers to immigration simply didn't exist. No amount of communist propaganda to the contrary could explain why, given the choice, citizens were choosing to live in West Germany over East Germany. Claims that the thousands of immigrants were all fascists or spies or provocateurs persuaded no one.
- 5.44** Walter Ulbricht was the leader of East Germany, and he had a crisis on his hands and very few positive options. His country was hemorrhaging citizens at enormous rate and, worse, it was the highly skilled, educated workers like doctors and engineers who were the first to flee to the West in order to have safety and far higher wages. On August 13, 1961 alone, over 2,000 Germans registered as refugees in the West. He decided the

situation needed to stop, and at 1 AM that day, Operation Rose began. It would have been considered unthinkable for the simple reason that no one would ever have a reason to think it. How do you divide a city in half?

- 5.45** Though city life has many disadvantages, the advantages of cities are plentiful. They're centers of arts and culture. They are breeding grounds for new ideas. They're centralized locations to do business. They're dense. Everything is in close proximity to one another. The more urbanized the city tends to be, the more tightly packed it ends up being. It takes decades for cities to grow into an integrated whole, streets feeding into streets, neighborhoods developing their own character. Integration is both a natural and a manmade trend for cities. And now, for the first time in history, possibly, Ulbricht tried to disintegrate a city.
- 5.46** Tanks and personnel carriers surrounded West Berlin in case things got completely out of control. The streetlights were turned dark to hide what the authorities were doing. There were 81 crossing points between West and East Berlin. 68 of them were closed down. All 193 of the streets on the border were closed. The railways, both above and below ground, were blocked. Even shafts of the sewage system were inspected to make sure people weren't sneaking through. As all this happened, barbed wire was beginning to be laid down alongside concrete bolsters and tank traps. We are tempted to think that "the reaction from the Western world was fast and furious," but that's simply untrue. It took a long time for information about what was happening in Berlin to reach Western Europe and the United States, and even then, it wasn't all that clear exactly what the communists were up to.
- 5.47** The idea of enclosing an entire city or even just part of a city was inconceivable and absurd. So it's little surprise that many people didn't appreciate that, yes, the East German authorities were laying the literal groundwork for what would become later known as the Berlin Wall. The official name for it was the Anti-Fascist Rampart. The Wall was so effective in keeping fascists out that not a single one, even so much as tried, to sneak in to East Germany. The traffic was almost entirely in the other direction. People began to be separated from their friends, their family, and their colleagues.
- 5.48** President Kennedy only found out by noon, and by then there was a little that could be done about it. The East German authorities made sure to construct their barriers strictly on GDR territory, and per the post-World War II agreements, they continued to respect the rights of American troops and others to cross. Though Westerners did not quite appreciate what was happening, some Germans understood the situation exactly. Take the case of Conrad Schumann. He was only 19 years old, but he was already an armed East German border guard. Thirty-six hours after the basis for the wall began to be laid down, he stood face-to-face with the citizens of West Berlin, staring at each other across three-foot-tall barbed wire.

- 5.49 He listened to the West Berliners berating him in harsh terms, comparing him, not entirely unreasonable, to those who had guarded concentration camps not that long ago and not that far away. So at 4 in the afternoon, Conrad Schumann made the right decision. He chose peace. He paced back and forth, planning the next step in his mind. At that moment, photographer Peter Leibing, who was himself only 20 years old, he stood nearby. He realized that that young border guard was up to something. Now, Leibing had experienced photographing horses, so he knew when to take his shot when he needed it. His camera had no motor drive. If something was going to happen, he was going to have one and only one chance to get the picture.
- 5.50 On the far side of the barbed wire, a West German police car pulled up, engine running, urging Schumann to defect. With one quick motion, he threw his cigarette aside, jumped the barbed wire barrier, dropped his weapon to the ground, and ran into the car, which took him to safety. At the precise moment Schumann made his leap, Leibing took his shot with his camera, and he got the photograph of the border guard hopping the fence to freedom. Less than two days after the Berlin Wall began to be built, the world already had an iconic picture to represent those who chose to be free rather than to hurt their fellow man.
- 5.51 His reasoning for his action was quite simple. He didn't want to kill someone for crossing the street. Close to where he jumped, there's now a statue of Schumann, based on this photograph, complete with the gun over his shoulder and the barbed wire under his feet. Anyone can go there and look and ask themselves if they would have had courage to leave for freedom when pressured to do evil. He was not alone. Nine other border guards also defected within those first couple of days. Yet there remained, and there will always remain, plenty of young men who are more than happy for decades to follow orders and shoot their countrymen for leaving the workers' paradise.
- 5.52 In the very early morning of Friday, August 18, 1961, came the cranes. Behind Berlin's historic Brandenburg Gate, a beautiful landmark defined by five pathways, the GDR dropped concrete slabs to block the gate in perpetuity. By the time the sun rose, a five-foot-tall barrier had risen like a middle finger to decency. In less than a week, the emerging Berlin Wall had grown from an impossible hypothetical to drudging reality. Ida Siekmann would be the first one to die only nine days after the wall began being built. Her street opened to the French sector, and residents therein could easily pass to West Berlin. Five days after Operation Rose, the building's previous entrances were boarded up and new ones were created, and these new entrances ensured that the residents could only exit the spaces that were under Russian control.
- 5.53 Her only surviving relative, her sister, lived a few blocks away, but now she might as well have been on the other side of the world. Physical contact between them had been virtually impossible, and it was almost certain that other forms of communication would become banned as well in the very near future. After all, contact with members

of foreign nations was legally regarded as spying, something even Western nations do not take lightly. She had one opportunity to escape. People had begun repelling down from their windows into West Berlin. Others had jumped to escape with firefighters waiting to catch them below.

- 5.54** On the morning of August 22nd, 1961, she threw down a quilt and some other objects down into the street. The firefighters tried to get the rescue net open in time, time which was of the essence. If she did not manage to escape now, she could be certain she would never be allowed near the border again. She might be imprisoned or shot, or who knows what else. She jumped before the net was ready, severely injuring herself in the process. She was a nurse by profession, and she died en route to the hospital and became the first victim of the Berlin Wall. Her death came one day before her 59th birthday, one that she so desperately wanted to spend with her sister.
- 5.55** Two days after she died, the shootings began. One young man, Günter Litfin, tried to flee by jumping into the harbor and swimming across. The guards yelled at him to swim back, and then one unleashed a barrage of bullets. He was only 24 when he was killed. The East German press merely said that he died in a tragic accident. His brother only learned about his death after he was arrested and interrogated all night to see if he had something to do with it.
- 5.56** About a year after the Berlin Wall was constructed, a bunch of East German kids planned to make a break for it. But when the time came, only Peter Fechter and his buddy Helmut had come up with the nerve. By this point, the Berlin Wall was already a far more imposing edifice. There was a wire fence on the near side, which the two young men managed to circumvent. Now they were in the death strip, which was the area between the wire fence and the further wall. And past that death strip was West Berlin. As the border guards opened fire, Helmut made it over. Fechter, however, was not quite so lucky. He was shot in the pelvis and slid down, laying there exposed. There had been a skirmish between East and West German guards a few days prior, and that left the East German guards too rattled to try and rescue Peter, while the West Germans could not reach him to help.
- 5.57** As Fechter lay on the ground, a crowd began to gather screaming, "murder, murder," at the East Germans. They threw bandages down at him to try to help him, anything to save his life. He could hear West Berlin from where he lay on the concrete and under the barbed wire. An hour is a very long time to die. Did Fechter review his life, not in an instant, but in excruciating detail? Was he worried that he was causing a problem for his family? Maybe he was scared he hadn't told his mom enough times that he loved her. For all we know, his thoughts turned to some girl he had crush on in school, someone who he wrote really bad poems for and who thought him a nuisance, but maybe she liked the attention. The only thing he had to keep him warm on that ground was his blood.

- 5.58 As the minutes passed, his screams turned into cries for help. There must have been some point where he wondered what was taking them so long to help him. Then another point where he suspected help wasn't coming at all. And then a final one when he understood that this was the end. Nowadays, there's a monument to him at the spot where he was killed. Anyone can go there and stand and remember what it's like to be 18 years old, to be a complete idiot as all 18-year-olds are complete idiots, and to think of all the things that happened in your life since turning 18. That first date that was really the start of something special, that stomachache that didn't go away, that argument where you said things you immediately knew you shouldn't have. All those possibilities, both the great moments and the banal, that come with having one's entire life ahead of them.
- 5.59 But Peter Fechter would have none of this because some border guard just followed orders and shot the young brick layer in cold blood. This wasn't 1930s Ukraine, this wasn't even World War II Dachau, this was Berlin in 1962. Photo cameras were common, videos increasingly accessible and affordable. Everyone all over the world could see the footage of Fechter's dying agony. It's still on YouTube. They could watch his feet dangling as a guard eventually carried away the body, holding it in his arms exactly like a sleeping child. You could see his hands covered in his own blood.
- 5.60 The East Germans later said he was a fascist, but everyone understood what he really was, another victim of the Berlin Wall. The East Germans never had a good reason to explain why all these fascists were still to be found in East Germany and why it would be a bad thing for them to flee the country. It didn't matter, though. True to the egalitarian principles of communism, the concrete monster that was the Berlin Wall consumed everyone equally.

Lecture 6: Conservative Unity

At a glance — Conservative unity and escapes across the Berlin divide.

- 6.1** But not every escape from East to West Berlin met with such tragic circumstances. Take the story of Heinz Meixner. He was 20 years old, a lathe worker, and he was an Austrian who commuted from West Berlin to East for work. And he fell in love with a girl from East Germany named Margarete. He knew he had to get her out and his future mother-in-law for good measure. Now, Checkpoint Charlie was the most famous crossing point between the two Berlins. So Meixner borrowed a scooter. He went there to cross and, distracting the guard who was checking the passport, he measured the height of that steel beam that lifted up to allow cars to pass through. It was approximately a yard off the ground, which is enough to prevent almost any car from going through, almost any car.
- 6.2** Meixner found an Austin Healey Sprite sports car for rent. And without the windshield, it was 90cm tall. Room to spare. He took off the windshield and then he let out some of the air from the tires for good measure. He put his fiancé in the space behind the driver. Mother-in-law is in the trunk. He surrounded her with bricks in case the guards opened fire. And on the morning of May 5, 1963, he drove to the guard from East Berlin and showed him his passport. And this time he floored it, instead of going on to the customs inspection.
- 6.3** He drove around the vertical bars, ducked his head, and easily drove under the steel beam before the guards could register what was going on. He was long out of their sight before they realized what that little red sports car was up to. And Heinz and Margarete were married in due course. Two months later, a young man named Norbert Konrad attempted to do the exact same thing with his East German girlfriend. He rented the same exact car and he left the windshield on so as not to arouse the guard's suspicion. And it worked.
- 6.4** But not every attempted escape to West Berlin ended in joy or such extreme tragedy as Peter Fechter. Journalist Anna Funder interviewed a woman named Miriam who had attempted to scale the wall in 1968 at the age of 16. And by then the Berlin Wall had become a massive edifice indeed. In its completed form, the wall was 104 miles long, including 66 miles of reinforced concrete slabs. It was built of the hardest concrete to withstand ramming, and each slab was six inches thick and weighed two and a half tons. They were cemented together, topped with asbestos piping, and extra protection was provided by over 300 observation towers, 65 miles of trenches, 250 dog runs, and 20 massive concrete bunkers. Next to the wall was a death strip of constantly raked sand, which was 100 yards wide and equipped with hundreds of mines and automatic firing devices.

- 6.5 So Miriam got over the barbed wire fence, she transversed the concrete strip, and then pressed herself against the kink in the wall. And she's wondering why no one has spotted her. Then she turned and locked eyes with the one guard who was there, a German shepherd dog who was chained to the wall. "I don't know why it didn't attack me," she said. The dog looked at her, she looked at the dog, and the dog walked away. Perhaps even a dog had the decency to understand that it shouldn't attack a harmless teenage girl. She then climbed the second barbed wire fence. She could see the Western guards. She only had a little bit more to go. And then she triggered the tripwire.
- 6.6 The sirens began immediately. The Western guards lit her up with a searchlight to save her from being blasted by East German weapons. As the border guards grabbed her, they made it a point to call the teenage girl a piece of shit. She was taken and imprisoned in a 6.5 by 10-foot cell without any contact with the outside world. For 10 days, the process was the same. Go to bed at 8pm, get woken up at 10pm, six hours of interrogation, and then bed at 4am before being woken up at 6am again to repeat the process. If she fell asleep, the guards banged on the door or physically shook her and eventually they took her mattress away.
- 6.7 The questions remained the same. Who put you up to this? Who conspired with you to make this foolish attempt to escape? A collective society needs collective punishment for its crimes. And surely no 16-year-old girl is going to take it upon herself to defy the government of the German Democratic Republic. Eventually she made up some ridiculous story about a man with little feet who went to a bar that she knew.
- 6.8 Now, the strategy for these interrogations was almost universally the same. The classic scenario was the corner-to-corner interrogation room. The rooms on the second floor overlooked the edge of the prison and allowed a glimpse of the outside world. Interrogator's chair and desk were situated at an angle to this window corner facing into the room. And when the prisoners are brought in, he, or in Miriam's case, she, was placed on a small stool in the far interior corner of the room, so that he crouched there, facing the interrogator, who was a good 10ft away. The psychological effect, and this was done through research, was to make the prisoner feel uncomfortable and apprehensive, subject to an animal-like unease, which the interrogator could increase by simply staring at them and saying, "I have plenty of time. I have nothing but time."
- 6.9 It was clear to the prisoner that just outside their line of vision, a window revealed the world they had lost in exchange for a lonely, silent cell. Often the prisoner had an urge to talk, to make something happen, to get him off that stool and get out of there. Miriam was sentenced to a year and a half in prison. The very first day, the guards gave her introduction. They stripped her naked. They took her to a room with a deep bathtub. One guard held her legs, the other her hair, and they kept dunking her into ice-cold water over and over. When she was allowed to catch a breath, the guards

began to call her names. "Filth, bitch, traitor." She started to think they were killing her, which was precisely the point.

6.10 See, what was happening to Miriam was not unique because Miriam had fallen into the hands of the Stasi. The name Simon Wiesenthal lives on to this day. As a Nazi hunter, he spent decades trying to track down those members of the Third Reich who escaped justice by fleeing abroad. His analysis of the East German secret police was a very blunt one. As he himself put it, the Nazi hunter, "The Stasi was much, much worse than the Gestapo, Hitler's Gestapo, if you consider only the oppression of its own people." The Gestapo had 40,000 officials watching a country of 80 million, while the Stasi employed 102,000 people to control only 17 million. Roughly 2% of the German population were informants, which is a huge percentage if you stop to think about it.

6.11 We tend to think that if we were forced to inform on our neighbors, it would have to be under duress. Something's happening to our kids, our loved ones, our job's on the line. In fact, this was not the case. There was no shortage of people who tripped over themselves to inform on their countrymen without any pressure or even reward, other than some sort of status or a sense of, hey, I'm doing my part. Some quite literally just had nothing better to do. One Stasi recruiter said, "Some of them were convinced of the cause, but I think it was mainly because informers got the feeling that they were somebody." Someone was listening to them for a couple of hours a week, taking notes. They felt they had it over other people. It was an easy way for low status, obedient people to become more important than they otherwise would have been. The recruiter said, "It was pitiful, actually. They were hardly paid at all."

6.12 After the Stasi files were opened, Germans were allowed to learn who had informed on them and what they had said. And everyone in the former East Germany had to ask themselves, "Do I want to know what they had on me? And do I want to know who told?" There were people whose job it is to prepare people to read what had been in their files. There's one woman named Frau Trumpelmann who explained the nature of the files and then was at hand to comfort the people as they read. But the strain on her was very great. How do you work with poison every day and not yourself become poisoned?

6.13 One of her recent readers had been imprisoned for five years under the East German regime for attempting to escape into the West. She had found out by reading her file that it was the man who she was living with who had denounced her to the Stasi. And they still lived together. Just that morning, he had told her to have a great day at the archive. She collapsed into Frau Trumpelmann's arms.

6.14 It was with the rise of Walter Ulbricht's successor, Erich Honecker, as the head of East Germany, that the decision was made to lessen the Stasi's use of brute terror and focus on mental warfare. The term for it, the very German term, was zersetzung. It's a word that's translated into English as disintegration or corrosion. But what they were disintegrating or corroding was the human minds of their targets. It worked by, say,

coming home and finding your socks on the pillow for no reason. OK, maybe I forgot, you know, brain fart, so on and so forth. But the next day, and the day after that, finding your socks on your own pillow, Nothing was stolen from your house. Why is someone putting their socks on the pillow? But who can I complain to? And what can I complain about? That there's socks on my pillow?

- 6.15** They often took things, the Stasi often took things even further. They would want the target to know that they were being watched. They would intentionally produce noises when someone was making a phone call. They would stop the target repeatedly and search them every time. A target might find their bicycle's tires slashed not once, but over and over and over. Obviously, this wasn't a coincidence. But the police wouldn't slash bicycle tires, right? Or would they? And if not them, who else is doing it? And why? And why weren't they being arrested? In fact, the Stasi perfected techniques for breaking up groups which were a threat in their minds to the East German regime.
- 6.16** All it took was one Stasi operative in an organization urging its members toward increasingly radical and aggressive actions. And then all the members could be arrested for associating with aggressive radicals or not turning them in. And the Stasi could then truthfully say the group had been an audience to illegal conversations. Yet as sinister and feared as the Stasi were, East Germany's leader, Erich Honecker, was still not the most hated figure in the GDR. That honor would probably belong to the woman who became his third wife and his long-time partner in crime, Margot Honecker. Unusually in communist circles, Margot had become a prominent politician in her own right before hitching her wagon to Honecker's.
- 6.17** In '49, she became the youngest member of Parliament at the age of 22. The two crossed paths and began an affair, even though he is 15 years older than her and already married. Walter Ulbricht encouraged Honecker to get divorced and marry Margot, and being a dutiful communist, Honecker followed orders and agreed. She became minister of national education in 1963, and Honecker, her husband, replaced Ulbricht as East German leader in 1971. And while Honecker and his regime dominated the adult citizens in the German Democratic Republic, it was Margot's role to come for the children.
- 6.18** This earned her the German nickname of "die hexe," the witch. She was a bit of a fashionista at a time in a place where wearing conspicuous clothing was more than a bit suspect. Her job was to make sure that East German children grew up to be loyal, obedient citizens, or else. Part of her plan was to make sure that children had reliable homes to grow up in. And reliability, of course, was a degree to which parents were in line with the reigning communist ideology. The GDR took thousands of kids from unreliable parents and gave them to good communists to raise as their own. Any further contact between parents and their children was impossible. They had no idea where their kids went.

- 6.19** Sometimes the government wouldn't even bother to wait a week before taking newborn infants away, a situation that was even worse than what happened to those women in the Gulag. It was a devious way to ensure that parents were obedient. Every single East German child was effectively a hostage of the government at all times, an extreme measure even by communist standards. Some parents spent decades trying to track down what happened to their kids, with different degrees of success. Sometimes they learned their adult children were no longer interested in seeing them, for whatever reason. And others met and stared at each other, two strangers who had only had their biology in common. Those crucial bonds made when a child is very young are almost impossible to reestablish at a later date.
- 6.20** Yet these forced adoptions weren't Margot's most horrific technique. The most notorious tool for her control was held in Torgau, which is a two-hour drive south from Berlin. It was at Torgau that Margot ran the worst of the "Jugendwerkhof" in East Germany. The term means youth workshop. But the reality is, Torgau was a prison for children. We can argue about whether the conditions at Torgau are worse than a standard prison or merely the same. But what is indisputable is that 12-year-olds are not very compatible with being held in solitary confinement. One teenage survivor described being locked up after her stepfather molested her, driving her to attempt suicide. She was nevertheless imprisoned, like all the others.
- 6.21** The children at Torgau were locked in with no possibility of escape, without any contact with their families, with no hope of letting them out of the 65-foot-square room. No matter what they did, they knew that if they panicked or acted out or screamed for help, that would only make conditions worse. And if they didn't know, they learned very quickly. Margot's staff was there to make sure of that. When they first arrived at Torgau, the kids would be held in holding cells. They had to wait several days for the director to bother seeing them. And while they waited, they weren't allowed to sing or to whistle, to make any noise at all. They couldn't even look out the window. That was a whole other world, one that did not concern them any longer.
- 6.22** The goal was not to save these imprisoned children, but to break them. As with any other environment, the predators knew to go where the prey was. And the more helpless the prey, the easier it was for the predators. Not only could the Torgau caretakers assault the children who were ostensibly under their care, they were permitted to take the children home with them on weekends, to use however they saw fit in the privacy of their own homes. As one German newspaper reported that "not everyone, of course, could handle the conditions." One 17-year-old escaped and drowned himself. Others used shirts to hang themselves, drank grease, swallowed needles. One boy locked himself in his room, poured wax all over his body, and set himself on fire. Another teenager tried to kill himself so there would be distraction for his friends to escape. He survived, and they did not manage to escape.

- 6.23** In a sense, Torgau can be an extreme metaphor for all the people on the far side of the Berlin Wall, or even the far side of the Iron Curtain. They were trapped, literally and figuratively, with no hope of escape, living in countries where human life was nothing, less than nothing. And they knew it. Indeed, what possible argument for hope could you give them? And there had been attempts over the years to try to liberate themselves from the shackles of the Soviet Union.
- 6.24** Imre Nagy was Prime Minister of Hungary from 1953 to 1955, and when Stalin passed away, he attempted to soften his government's authoritarianism, and this displeased the Kremlin, and he was pulled away from his position. After Khrushchev's secret speech in 1956, this led to widespread Hungarian unrest. Nagy was returned to power in an attempt to mollify the population. It did little to ease the tensions. For 13 days, Hungary was in full revolt against being a Soviet satellite, and he announced that his country would be withdrawing from the Warsaw Pact, and that was a bridge too far for Khrushchev. On November 4, 1956, the Soviets launched a full invasion of Hungary. Nagy was arrested alongside many others who took part in the uprising, and a new administration, one in lockstep with Moscow, was installed in his place. He was imprisoned and tortured for almost two years and was hanged in 1958.
- 6.25** Nor was that the only example. January 5, 1968, witnessed Alexander Dubcek taking on the leadership role in communist Czechoslovakia. He began to implement a series of reforms that he regarded as socialism with a human face. The idea was having socialism to make sure that people were happy, healthy, fed, and had jobs, not this sort of authoritarianism that helped no one other than those who were in power. Freeing political prisoners became a topic of discussion, as well as some modicum of free speech and possibly even democratic reforms. This period became known as the Prague Spring. It was a renaissance of civil society blooming throughout every aspect of the Central European country.
- 6.26** As spring turned to summer, word came down from Moscow that Dubcek was moving too quickly. And the final straw came when Dubcek started to distance himself from the Warsaw Pact, just like Imre Nagy had tried to do a decade prior. On July 16, 1968, Dubcek was given a written warning by other members of the Warsaw Pact that he was playing a dangerous game, pointing out that "the peoples of our country won a victory over Hitlerite fascism at the price of immense sacrifices." What became known as the Warsaw Letter went out to state that "the strength of our ties depends on the internal strength of our system of each of our fraternal countries."
- 6.27** And thus was born the Brezhnev Doctrine, named after Khrushchev's successor. The policy was that the socialist nations, and the USSR especially, had an obligation to defend the goals that socialism had made. If a given nation were to turn against socialism in a counterrevolutionary manner, the other nations had a duty to intervene in order to prevent that, by force if necessary. It wasn't only Russian citizens who could not escape the USSR. Neither could those countries allied with the Soviet Union.

- 6.28** One month after the letter, forces from Bulgaria, Poland, Hungary, and the Soviet Union invaded Czechoslovakia with support from East Germany. Prague's citizens witnessed firsthand whether it was true that the city's cobblestone streets were there in place to make sure it's easier for Russian tanks to move. Dubcek was arrested, but he was scared of Nagy's fate. He got expelled from the party and shuffled off to some crappy job deep in Slovakia. President Lyndon Johnson, his Secretary of State, and the American ambassador to the UN all refused to do or say anything.
- 6.29** So where would someone trapped behind the Iron Curtain look for hope? What possible reason would they have to think the totalitarians would ever give up on their absolutist ideology? Why would their rulers ever voluntarily renounce their power? And who could possibly stop them militarily? The Korean War was a draw. The Vietnam War was a disaster for the West. The Soviet Union clearly wasn't going anywhere. Thus became the era of détente, starting under President Nixon and heavily associated with his adviser Henry Kissinger, who just passed, détente was a semi-official policy of being realistic and acknowledging the world would be forever divided into a communist east and a liberal democratic west for decades, if not centuries to come.
- 6.30** People need to accept that this is how things are, not how you wish them to be or how you imagine them to be. And pretending to be otherwise is both utopian and naive and dangerous to boot. We would just have to figure out a way to live with one another. Working with this concept of détente was the idea of MAD, mutually assured destruction. Both the United States and the Soviet Union had enough nukes at this point to blow up each other dozens of times over, almost certainly destroying life on Earth in the process. Therefore, it was necessary to take steps to avoid the Cold War escalating into open warfare, as has happened several times over the previous decades.
- 6.31** The bipartisan American foreign policy consensus was tethered to the view that the Soviet Union was not going anywhere. Experts agreed that only a lunatic playing a dangerous game with nukes would think differently. As Lyndon Johnson's 1964 campaign ad said, "We must either love each other or we must die." It took the pairing of one woman and one man to throw this consensus into the trash. Her view was that consensus seems to be the process of abandoning all beliefs, principles, values, and policies. So it is something which no one believes and to which no one objects. As for him, in 1977, he said, "My idea of American foreign policy toward the Soviet Union is simple, and some would say simplistic. It is this. We win and they lose."
- 6.32** What's gone down in history as one of the great political romances of all time, in retrospect, might be better viewed as a Hollywood buddy comedy. Though their worldviews were highly compatible and often identical, the relationship between President Ronald Reagan and Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher emphasized the cliché that politics makes for strange bedfellows. He was a smooth operator, always with a joke on hand, relying on anecdotes instead of data to get across his point of view. She was strident, serious to the point of being a scold, someone who didn't hesitate to

lecture whoever happened to be in earshot. Neither of them took the traditional path toward heading the governments of their respective countries.

- 6.33** The woman who would become the second Mrs. Dennis Thatcher was born in 1925 above her father's grocery store in suburban Grantham, the incarnation of bourgeoisie that Lenin so despised for the small-minded provincialism. She was always a daddy's girl, and Margaret Roberts' interest in politics was sparked at an early age by her father's local career. He served at the Grantham town council starting in 1927, became alderman in 1943 and mayor in 1945, and was voted out when Labour took over, a quiet trauma that Margaret witnessed firsthand. She got a chemistry degree at Oxford, though her classmates universally agreed that she was unexceptional and possessed little of the future charm and charisma that would make her a politician.
- 6.34** Already well spoken, with strong ideas, young Margaret made three attempts for parliament between 1950 and 1954 and lost all three. Marrying Dennis Thatcher in 1951 gave her some financial freedom to study law and pass the bar, as well as the resources to balance focusing on her political career while raising a pair of twins. In 1959, Margaret Thatcher was given the nomination for the safe Conservative seat of Finchley, and she was elected to Parliament five days before her 34th birthday.
- 6.35** Reagan's path was a very different one. He was born in 1911 under President Taft in a rural Illinois town, and became a lifeguard and graduate of Eureka College, not quite as impressive as Thatcher's Oxford degree. He was tall and handsome, became a radio broadcaster, learning the skill of running his mouth for hours without having anything to say, a very useful skill for any politician to have. A lucky trip to Hollywood earned Reagan a contract as an actor, and eventually he became President of the Screen Actors Guild, thereby becoming the first union leader to become President of the United States.
- 6.36** When he once gave a speech to a citizens' group denouncing fascism, Reagan also added a line condemning communism. And the dead silence from the audience made him realize just how prevalent Stalinist infiltration of Hollywood had become. The media claim was that investigating Communist Party activity in the 1950s McCarthyism was all a witch hunt. But as the playwright Molly Day Thacher put it, no relation, "Those witches didn't exist. Communists do, here and everywhere in the world. It's a false parallel witch hunt." That phrase would indicate that there were no communists in the government, none in the big trade unions, none in the press, none in the arts, none sending money from Hollywood to 12th Street. No one who was in the Communist Party and left uses that phrase. They know better.
- 6.37** Reagan's brief marriage and divorce to fellow actor Jane Wyman led to him going on a date with a young starlet named Nancy Davis. She had reached out to him because she shared the same name as an actress who had been identified as a communist. And the two were inseparable ever since. By the 1960s, his acting career began to dry up. He started spending time criss-crossing America under the auspices of General Electric,

speaking about issues from a conservative perspective. Then and to the day he died, a huge FDR fan, Reagan remained a Democrat despite his political views. As he put it, "I was still saying the same things that I'd said for six years during the Eisenhower administration, but I was suddenly being called a right -wing extremist."

- 6.38** He was campaigning for Nixon during the former vice president's 1962 run for governor when a registrar in the audience stood up and challenged him as to his party of choice. He changed his party affiliation to Republican on the spot before continuing with his speech. Nixon's 1962 campaign for governor was bitter and divisive. When the results came in, his opponent, Pat Brown, was reelected by a five-point margin, 52% to 47%. Two years prior, Richard Nixon had almost been elected President of the United States over JFK. And now he was humiliated and disgraced and very famously gave that press conference when he said, "But as I leave you, I want you to know, just think about how much you're going to be missing. You don't have Nixon to kick around anymore," saying this was to be his last press conference, one of his many, many lies.
- 6.39** On a national stage, things are about to get even worse for the Republicans. The argument was that since Herbert Hoover, the Republicans have simply nominated a me too candidate for the White House, that the voters had not had a choice but an echo. By nominating a strong conservative, the Republican Party would have a path to victory on their own terms and not merely a watered-down version of the left. President Lyndon Johnson had been inaugurated on November 22, 1963, and the Republicans nominated Arizona Senator Barry Goldwater to fight him in 1964, less than one year after JFK had been so tragically assassinated. One of the very few celebrities to pitch their wagon to the Goldwater campaign was Ronald Reagan. And he gave a speech where he talked about what was called a time for choosing.
- 6.40** Not too long ago, two friends of mine were talking to a Cuban refugee, a businessman who had escaped from Castro. And in the midst of his story, one of my friends turned to the other and said, "We don't know how lucky we are." And the Cuban stopped and said, "How lucky you are? I had some place to escape to." And in that sentence he told us the entire story. If we lose freedom here, there's no place to escape to. This is the last stand on Earth.
- 6.41** Despite Reagan's best efforts, Lyndon Johnson won reelection with 61% of the vote, a record since James Monroe was reelected without opposition in 1820. The Democrats managed to pick up two more Senate seats, giving them a 68 to 32 lead in the Senate. And the House results were even worse. The Democrats had a 295 to 100 seat lead, something that hadn't been seen since FDR's heyday. The Republican Party was effectively powerless in Washington. Goldwaterism was dead and buried. Conservatism was done for. Yet Reagan's speech was very well received and did more for his career than it did for Goldwater's. And thus Reagan set his sights on the California governor's mansion.

- 6.42** To have a washed-up, has-been actor become governor of California would have been a joke if it wasn't so ridiculous. When Reagan was criticized for having no experience, he had a quick retort. He said, "The man who has the job has more experience than anybody. That's why I'm running." Even though his election seemed improbable, his margin of victory was a surprise. He trounced Pat Brown 58% to 42%, winning 55 out of California's 58 counties. Yes, including LA, and by double digits. Now his ascension to the governor's mansion in California was paralleled by Thatcher climbing the ladder in Britain.
- 6.43** Under the British system, the opposition party has a shadow cabinet consisting of members of parliaments who serve as parallels to the current members of Her Majesty's government. So when Labour is in power, the Conservatives have a shadow health secretary and so on and so forth. And in 1927, Margaret Thatcher was recommended to Ted Heath, who was leader of the opposition, for just such an assignment. He was looking for women to appoint and he had few female conservatives to choose from. The Tory whip, Willie Whitelaw, recommended Margaret Thatcher, and he'd said, "Willie agrees that she's much the most able, but he says once she's there we'll never be able to get rid of her." And he was right.
- 6.44** She became shadow secretary of state for education and science in 1967, an affirmative action hire. And after Conservatives took control of parliament in 1970, she became education secretary. In 1968, Richard Nixon was elected President of the United States. In 1970, Reagan was reelected governor of California. And in 1972, Richard Nixon was reelected as president over George McGovern by 61 to 38%, a margin almost identical to how badly LBJ had beat Goldwater just eight years prior. The American population was vacillating between Republican and Democrat at swings that we have not seen in our lifetime.
- 6.45** Now the volatile American political situation was paralleled in the UK as energy costs went through the roof under the Conservatives. Starting on New Year's Day 1974, commercial usage of electricity in the United Kingdom was limited to three days a week and working overtime was illegal. Television companies were ordered to stop broadcasting after 10:30pm. Under Queen Victoria, it had been said that the sun never sets on the British Empire because it truthfully stretched across the globe. By the time of Queen Elizabeth II, however, the British couldn't even keep the lights on at home.
- 6.46** In the aftermath of the introduction of a three-day week, Ted Heath, the Tory, called an election for February 1974. It was basically a draw. Labour had 301 seats. The Tories had 297. The new Labour government immediately increased the wages of miners by 35%, which sounds crazy until you realize that British inflation was 16% in 1974 and would almost hit 27% the following year. Now it was Labour Prime Minister Harold Wilson's turn to call an election to kind of break the stalemate. He needed 318 seats to get a majority and he got 319 seats.

- 6.47 With Tories and the Labour in close ideological alignment, it became impossible to persuade swing voters to choose anyone other than who they had chosen last election because there was no effective difference between the two parties. This was the era of the middle of consensus. As Thatcher later put it, "Consensus doesn't really give you any direction in life."
- 6.48 Now, in January of 1975, Ted Heath put himself up for a vote for his own party to validate his leadership. And Thatcher decided that she was going to throw her hat into the ring to challenge him for the leadership of their party. Now, this was regarded as a bit of a joke. So she was kind of a Karen. Her whole shtick is, "I'm the working mom who's got two twins at home, and I got to worry about the budget and putting food on the table. But also, I've got these political views." But, like, that's cute. But like, you're gonna be leading the Conservative Party? Let's be serious. When the votes were cast, the sitting leader of the Conservative Party, Ted Heath, got 119 votes and Thatcher got 130 votes. He withdrew before the second ballot. And even though three new men entered, she got the victory.
- 6.49 For the first time in history, a major Western political party would be headed by a woman. And not just a woman, but that woman, or as she became known, TBW, that bloody woman. And it was Red Star, which is a Soviet army newspaper, they gave her the nickname that stuck with her for the rest of her life, the Iron Lady. The American economy was not doing much better than the British. Under the presidency of Gerald Ford, who succeeded Nixon after he resigned from Watergate, unemployment hit 8.8% and inflation reached over 12% in 1974 alone. Ford was increasingly viewed as incompetent to fight these issues. His campaign to "whip inflation now," with little WIN buttons, was seen as both clueless and pointless. And Reagan decided to challenge him for the nomination in the 1976 election.
- 6.50 The last time an incumbent had been denied his party's nomination had been Chester A. Arthur in 1884. And just like Ford, Arthur had been a vice president who only succeeded to the Oval Office when his president, James Garfield, was assassinated. One of the biggest issues separating Reagan and Ford was their attitude toward the Soviet Union. Now, according to Ford's idea of détente, any act that could be perceived as hostile should be avoided because it would be seen as a provocation. But there were cracks that were beginning to appear in the Russian society for a very specific reason, and that is the growth of technology.
- 6.51 The Soviet bloc witnessed the rise of something called samizdata, which were blurry photocopies of texts that were illegal to possess. Solzhenitsyn's masterpiece, The Gulag Archipelago, revealed the practices of the Soviet Union's prison system both to citizens in the USSR and abroad. Citizens in these communist countries understood this work was true in all its essentials, quite unlike what they learned to read in the newspapers.
- 6.52 Ford barely managed to squeak out a win against Reagan in the 1976 convention before going on to lose his reelection to Jimmy Carter in 1976. Late 1978 saw the

Winter of Discontent, which was Britain's greatest labor stoppage since 1926. First, there was a strike by the Ford Motor employees, and that was supported by the Transport and General Workers Union. Then came the lorry drivers, which were the version of the Teamsters. Gas stations closed down, distribution channels were crippled. And then the railway men had their turn.

- 6.53** On January 22, 1979, there was a day of action. Over 1.5 million workers went on strike. Schools shut down, airports were closed. The ambulance drivers struck, even though they responded to some emergency calls. 1,100 hospitals under Britain's socialized system were reduced to only treating emergencies. For a couple of weeks, even the gravediggers went on strike. The sick weren't getting help. The dead weren't getting buried. And when the trash collectors went on strike, the garbage in London's famed Leicester Square stood taller than the people. The UK was fast becoming a dystopian novel.
- 6.54** On March 28, 1979, Margaret Thatcher, leader of the Opposition, stood on the floor of Parliament and said, "Mr. Speaker, I beg to move that this House has no confidence in Her Majesty's Government." Now Labour needed a majority of the vote to avoid being forced to call an election. And there were plenty of seats from minor parties that the Prime Minister could cut deals with to maintain his hold on office. But when the results came in, Labour had a total of 310 votes. But 311 members of parliament had expressed no confidence in the government. It was the first time a British government had been forced to stand down over 50 years, and for the first time ever, a woman would be leading the Tories into the general election.
- 6.55** Thatcher very famously went on television and said, "I can't bear Britain in decline. I just can't. We who either defeated or rescued half Europe, who kept half Europe free when otherwise it would be in chains, and look at us now." She worked with the agency Saatchi & Saatchi on an ad campaign that was very simple and very clear. Labour isn't working. 44% of the voters agreed with her, enough to give Conservatives 339 seats to Labour's 269. Margaret Thatcher was going to become the United Kingdom's first female prime minister.
- 6.56** Jimmy Carter's presidency was not regarded as a big success, to put it mildly. And the GOP saw a golden opportunity to retake the White House. But the 1964 Goldwater campaign was still very fresh in the minds of the Republican establishment. And if Goldwater could only carry six states, his successor, Ronald Reagan, didn't seem like he was going to be able to do much better. He was too old, he was too out of touch, he was too conservative, he was too extreme. Polling in January of 1980 had Carter leading Reagan 62% to 33%, an even bigger landslide than what LBJ served to Goldwater in 1964.
- 6.57** Then, as now, Iowa was the first state for Republican voters to weigh in on who they wanted to be the nominee. There was a Stop Reagan campaign by Republican voters and establishment members who did not want to give up what they saw as an easy

win. And their chosen candidate was George H.W. Bush, who had been director of the CIA, head of the Republican Party, ambassador of the UN, and a two-term member of Congress. And sure enough, Bush won Iowa. Next would be New Hampshire. If Reagan lost New Hampshire to Bush as well, it was effectively going to be the end of the Reagan campaign.

- 6.58** His campaign sponsored a debate to be hosted by a local newspaper. He invited all the other Republican candidates, while Bush had been under the impression that the debate would just be between the two of them. So there was a big interaction, there was a big kind of blow-up on stage, and the moderator, Jon Breen, asked the sound guy to cut off Reagan's mic. It was one of the few moments where Reagan lost his cool and snapped at him. "I am paying for this microphone, Mr. Green," getting the man's name wrong. The other candidates all applauded him from the stage. The audience erupted into enormous cheers, and Reagan got accolades for putting a journalist in his place.
- 6.59** And from then on, it was a straightforward path for him to get the nomination. So eventually, Reagan forced President Carter to agree to a debate. Carter came off as miserable and peevish, didn't even think to smile, while Reagan, Mr. Hollywood, stood there effortlessly and seemed horribly unthreatening compared to the caricature that had been made of him in the press. His home run moment was when Carter criticized him for having previously been against Medicare. Reagan smiled, looked at him and goes, "There you go again." As politely as possible, calling the President of the United States a liar to his face in front of a captive national audience.
- 6.60** And Reagan ended the debate with a very simple question to the voters. "Next Tuesday, all of you will go to the polls, will stand there in the polling place, and make a decision. I think when you make that decision, it might be well if you would ask yourself, are you better off than you were four years ago?" When the election results came in, it was Goldwater in 1964 all over again, but only it was Jimmy Carter who only took six states. Reagan was elected in a landslide, and his coattails ushered in a Republican Senate for the first time since Eisenhower.
- 6.61** As 1981 began, what had seemed an absurdity five years prior was a reality in both the U.S. and the U.K. Both governments were now under the control of members of the right-wing half of each nation's respective right-wing party. Popular music had a field day with this, and as one song by the British band Fun Boy Three put it, "The lunatics have taken over the asylum." So this clip is how Reagan ended the 1980 debate against Carter.
- 6.62** Next Tuesday is Election Day. Next Tuesday, all of you will go to the polls, will stand there in the polling place, and make a decision. I think when you make that decision, it might be well if you would ask yourself, are you better off than you were four years ago?

- 6.63 Now a couple of weeks after he was inaugurated on March 30, 1981, a gunman named John Hinckley Jr. managed to shoot President Reagan, his press secretary, a Secret Service agent, and a cop before being apprehended. One of his agents immediately covered Reagan as a human shield when he saw that he was being shot. Reagan began to spit up blood, which led both him and the agent to think that the President had been shoved so hard that he had broken a rib. The decision was swiftly made to reroute Reagan's limo from the White House to a nearby hospital. He insisted on walking into the hospital to demonstrate to the Americans that all was well. But he swiftly collapsed once inside.
- 6.64 It was when the medical team started examining Reagan that they realized that the President had been shot. His wife, Nancy, distraught, arrived just as Reagan began being prepped for surgery. He looked at her and said, "Honey, I forgot to duck." His nonstop wisecracking must have been reassuring and maddening. He wrote down to his nurse, W.C. Field's quip that, "All in all, I'd rather be in Philadelphia." And when he was in the operating room, Reagan took a second to take off his oxygen mask, look at the surgical team, and tell them, "I hope you're all Republicans." "We're all Republicans today," the surgeon said, who was a Democrat.
- 6.65 And the year 1981 was a difficult one for Margaret Thatcher as well. Under the British system, the Prime Minister's cabinet is composed of members of Parliament. Now there are plenty of moderate and liberal Tories, and she appointed several of them to various positions, and she referred to them as the "wets", in the same way of saying that someone is all wet. As opposed to this were the Thatcherites who were the "dries." She would never have a strong dry majority throughout her entire prime ministership. As Thatcher anticipated, her monetarist approach to the economy in the short-term caused a worsening of economic conditions as a means of eventually resolving the problems of both rising unemployment and of inflation. Not only was Labour not working, neither was the Conservative approach.
- 6.66 As she acknowledged it, she said, "Yes, the medicine is harsh, but the patient requires it in order to live. We did not seek election and win in order to manage the decline of a great nation." By 1981, the worst economic news was beginning to pass and her political hand was strengthened. And that September, in a bid to reassert control of her government, she had a very public reshuffling of her cabinet, which became known as the purging of the wets. Nevertheless, Thatcher was still regarded largely as a transitional figure. It was cute that this kind of housewife was going to be the Prime Minister, but let's get serious. At some point, this stunt is going to go away and we're going to have a real person in charge, running the government.
- 6.67 There's a movie that some of you might know called King Ralph, and in this movie, the entire royal family is killed in a freak accident, and therefore the person who's like, 300th in line to the throne, John Goodman, becomes King Ralph. And it was basically

this kind of thing. It's like, really, you're the Prime Minister? It's cute, you know, this lady. But let's move on and become adults.

6.68 Well, things came to a head in 1982. On April 2, 1982, Argentina invaded the nearby Falkland Islands, which had been a loyal British—which had been a loyal British colony for over a century. Thatcher had withdrawn military protection the year prior, and this led the Argentinians to believe that if they reclaimed the islands, the British couldn't or wouldn't do anything about it. Everything was now on the line, including her government and Great Britain's dignity itself.

Lecture 7: The Cold War Thaw

At a glance — The Cold War thaw and the late-Soviet era.

- 7.1 Everything was now on the line, Great Britain's dignity and Margaret Thatcher's role as Prime Minister. She decides to send a task force to secure the Falkland Islands, but they were so far away that it would take weeks for them to get there. In the interim, President Reagan sent his Secretary of State, Al Haig, to Number 10 Downing Street, in the hopes of mediating a diplomatic solution of some sort.
- 7.2 The American suggestion was a compromise. The Argentine forces withdraw, the British have some administration, and then there would be some soon-to-be-determined international authority. Compromise was not a word that Margaret Thatcher was particularly fond of. As she put it, "Interim authority to do what? I beg you to remember that in 1938, Neville Chamberlain sat at this same table, discussing an arrangement which sounds very much like the one you're asking me to accept. Were I to do so, I would be censured in the House of Commons, and properly so. Britain simply will not reward aggression. That is the lesson of 1938."
- 7.3 A war zone was declared around the Falklands. Despite the enormous difficulties in fighting so far away from the British mainland, British troops made strong headway, swiftly recapturing one of the islands with no British casualties. Soon thereafter, Thatcher's forces sank the Argentine ship, General Belgrano, killing 300 Argentine troops in the process and causing a bit of controversy for Thatcher because the ship was outside the maritime exclusion zone. But as the foreign office put it, "If it hadn't wanted to be sunk, it shouldn't have been there."
- 7.4 President Reagan himself tried to call on May 31st to try to de-escalate the situation, and again, she wasn't having it. "I didn't lose some of my finest ships and some of my finest lives to leave quietly under a ceasefire. How would the President feel, supposing Alaska was invaded?" Two weeks later, the Argentinian forces surrendered and British control over the Falklands was restored. This led the way to Thatcher having an enormous landslide the following year. The Tories gained 58 more seats, dropping Labour down to 209, their worst result since 1935. Thatcher was no longer a joke or a transitional figure, but an established government leader in her own right.
- 7.5 It was only a few months after Thatcher's landslide that Reagan stabbed her in the back and stabbed her hard. There's a small island called Grenada off the coast of Venezuela with a population of about 90,000 people. Despite having a communist coup in 1979, Grenada nevertheless remained a member of the British Commonwealth with Queen Elizabeth II as head of state. In late 1983, American naval vessels were spotted near Grenada. On October 24, 1983, Thatcher's right-hand man, Geoffrey Howe, stood in the House of Commons and insisted that there was no reason to think there would be any American intervention in Grenada. He said, and he believed, that the Reagan and

Thatcher administrations were in close contact and that she would be given fair warning if the matters were to turn militarily.

- 7.6 What Howe didn't know was that, two days earlier, President Reagan had already approved an invasion of Grenada by American forces, and he chose to keep that matter from Thatcher. As he later admitted, "I didn't want her to say no." She was completely humiliated by the United States, subsequently invaded to liberate the island nation. She had constantly talked about the special relationship between the US and the UK. Now it was obvious to her that America and Great Britain often had different ideas in mind for maintaining their power. Not long after that, he called her to apologize.
- 7.7 But the difference between the parliamentary system and American system is that the Prime Minister has to go in front of the House of Commons and answer questions directly from the opposition. Now Thatcher had to face her opponents and tap dance around the fact that President Reagan had so publicly humiliated her. A couple of months later, about a week before Christmas, 1983, the IRA, the Irish Republican Army, planted a car bomb outside London's world-famous Harrod's department store. The area failed to get evacuated, even though the IRA had called in the threat. Six people were killed, dozens more injured, as the bomb damaged five floors of the store.
- 7.8 Thatcher's husband, the first gentleman of the UK, Dennis Thatcher, nevertheless went there for presents. And as he put it, "It wasn't as crowded as it normally is, but no damned Irishman is going to stop me going there." The following year, Dennis almost had to eat his words. In mid-October 1984, he was staying with Margaret and other Tory leaders at Brighton's Grand Hotel for a Conservative party conference. At 3 AM in the morning of October 12th, a few minutes after Thatcher finished editing the speech she was going to give, she heard a loud thud, followed by a different sound. She knew it was a bomb immediately. And later learned that that second sound was that of a falling chimney making its way through several floors.
- 7.9 Five people were killed, a few dozen injured, some very seriously, but none were the main targets of the bombing, which was Margaret Thatcher. The next day, the IRA released a statement taking credit for the bombing, telling Thatcher, "Today, we were unlucky, but remember, we only have to be lucky once. You'll have to be lucky always." But the conference went on as planned. Nine days later, President Reagan took part in his second and final debate against a Democratic nominee for President, Jimmy Carter's vice president, Walter Mondale. The first debate had gone poorly for Reagan, and there was talk that he was too old to be reelected, a question which was asked of him directly.
- 7.10 "You already are the oldest President in history, and some of your staff say you were tired after your most recent encounter with Mr. Mondale. I recall yet that President Kennedy had to go for days on end with very little sleep during the Cuban Missile crisis. Is there any doubt in your mind that you would be able to function in such circumstances?" "Not at all, Mr. Truitt, and I want you to know that also I will not make

age an issue of this campaign. I am not going to exploit, for political purposes, my opponent's youth and inexperience." [laughter]

- 7.11** The consummate actor, Reagan, paused, took a glass of water and let the joke ride. Mondale was laughing. The moderator was laughing. The audience was laughing. And Mondale later said, "You'll see that I was smiling, but I think if you come in close, you'll see some tears coming down because I knew he had gotten me there." Reagan went on to win every single state, with the exception of Mondale's home state of Minnesota, which Mondale only carried by less than 4,000 votes out of 2 million. The popular vote was 59% to Reagan, 41% for Mondale. It was almost a perfect inversion of LBJ's victory over Goldwater 20 years prior.
- 7.12** Now, Reagan had been trying desperately to meet with the Soviet leaders in 1982. He had reiterated an invitation to Brezhnev to suggest a summit instead of a meeting, maybe in Finland or Switzerland. But that would never come to pass because Brezhnev died on November 10th, 1982. Reagan could meet with Brezhnev's successor, Yuri Andropov, or his successor, Chernenko, because as Reagan pointed out, "they kept dying on me." And you can see perhaps why the Soviet leaders wouldn't want to meet with Reagan, because at this time, his views of the Soviet Union very publicly took on a strident tone.
- 7.13** As he put it, he referred to Russia as "an evil empire" and said that "they are the focus of evil in the modern world." This was not exactly the language of diplomacy, especially with two nations with such enormous nuclear arsenals. What Reagan began to do was exactly what the Russian people had been doing for decades, using jokes to undermine Russian authority and speak truths which would otherwise be forbidden.
- 7.14** The commissar went out to the farm, their state farm, and stopped one of the workers and asked him how things were, any complaints. And he said, 'Oh, no, sir. Never heard anyone complain.' He said, 'How are the crops?' 'The crops are wonderful.' 'What about the potato harvest?' 'Oh,' he said, 'the potatoes.' He said, 'Comrade, if we piled the potatoes up in one pile, they would reach the foot of God.' And the commissar said, 'This is the Soviet Union. There is no God.' He said, 'That's all right. There are no potatoes.'
- 7.15** But what the President of the United States was saying is that the Soviet Union is a godless, dishonest country that cannot afford to feed her own people. When Andropov died, Thatcher thought it would be a good idea to go to Moscow to attend the funeral to make some connections. She said it would give her a good opportunity to meet the man who would emerge as the new Soviet leader, Chernenko. While she was there, she invited several of the USSR leaders to meet her in Great Britain. One of these men was a young reformer by the name of Mikhail Gorbachev.
- 7.16** On the morning of December 16th, 1984, Gorbachev drove down to Chequers, which is the country estate set aside for the Prime Minister's use, to meet Thatcher for lunch.

He barely picked up his fork before she went full Thatcher on him. She lectured him about how central planning doesn't work and how markets do. She lectured him about the Soviets funding the British unions in the midst of another national strike. She lectured him about the USSR refusing to let Jewish citizens emigrate to escape anti-Semitism, even though others were allowed to leave the country if that was their desire. Then she lectured him for not having touched his food.

7.17 Gorbachev paused and replied with the Russian equivalent of dry British wit. He said, "I know you're a person of staunch beliefs, someone who adheres to certain principles and values. This commands respect. But please consider that next to you is a person of your own ilk. I can assure you that I am not under instructions from the politburo to persuade you to join the Communist Party." She burst into a hearty laugh, put aside her notes, and the two had a sincere heart-to-heart. As she very famously told the BBC shortly thereafter, "I like Mr. Gorbachev. We can do business together."

7.18 But of course, Gorbachev was a politician, and he had his own agenda. A week later, Thatcher visited Reagan at Camp David, the President's retreat, and she made a point to tell him what she thought Gorbachev was up to, and she made a point to proclaim to him how loyal she was to that special relationship between the United States and Great Britain. But there was one big issue that Gorbachev wanted Thatcher to speak to Reagan about, a message that she was happy to pass on. As he said, "Tell your friend President Reagan not to go ahead with space weapons." In other words, Gorbachev wanted Thatcher's help to stop star wars.

7.19 Mikhail Gorbachev was born in Russia in 1931 at the height of the famine. Within a couple of years, three of his father's siblings would succumb to the famine, which killed somewhere between a third to a half of his village. The following year, his paternal grandfather was arrested for not having met the government's sowing plan, even though he hadn't been given any seeds to sow. His maternal grandfather was also caught in the Great Terror, was arrested in 1937 for supposedly being part of a Trotskyite organization. And instantly, the young Mikhail Gorbachev became a pariah. As he put it, "Even the neighbor's kids refused to have anything to do with me." He had witnessed firsthand what Stalinism meant in practice. The issue with terror and totalitarianism is, when you kill and torture people, they often have children. And when the children grow up, they're rarely happy about it.

7.20 When his grandfather was eventually released, he learned what had been done to him. Trying to get him to confess, as Gorbachev wrote, "the investigator blinded him with a lamp, beat him unmercifully, broke his arms by squeezing the door. And when these standard tortures proved futile, they invented a new one. They put a wet sheepskin coat on him and sat him on a hot stove." Despite all this, Gorbachev grew up as a believer in the Soviet system, and he rose through diligence and hard work swiftly through the ranks of the Communist Party.

- 7.21 Due to this work, he was one of the few Russian citizens allowed to go abroad. When Gorbachev visited Prague in 1969, he first understood how the Soviet Union was seen by other citizens in other communist countries. Specifically, when he visited a factory the year after the Prague Spring, the workers literally turned their backs on him in a blatant show of contempt. The USSR's power was not viewed, like the Soviet newspapers claimed, as fraternal help. Seven weeks after Reagan was inaugurated for his second term, Gorbachev was appointed as the new General Secretary, the first Soviet leader to be born after the Russian Revolution. He was only 54 years old.
- 7.22 As he saw it, one of the primary obstacles preventing peace between the US and the USSR was Reagan's strategic defense initiative. Both Reagan and Gorbachev viewed a nuclear exchange between the two as effectively bringing about the end of the world. You can no more win a nuclear war than you can win an earthquake. What was fascinating is both men secretly committed to not retaliating, should a nuclear war be launched, though neither knew that was the other's position.
- 7.23 Before he had assumed office as President, Reagan took part in discussion about what would happen if the Soviet Union struck first. One participant in the meeting argued that, should the missiles be fired, the US should launch a response before we were hit. Reagan said, "That would be the wrong thing to do." His advisors left the meeting almost certain that he would not retaliate in the event of an attack. Gorbachev was even more explicit. After he took over the USSR, he was walked through a simulated nuclear strike so he would know what to do, should the worst ever happen. As he sat there being told that missiles were flying toward the Soviet Union, he refused to retaliate. As he put it, "I will not press the button even for training purposes." The two hawks were secretly hardcore doves.
- 7.24 That led to a possibility. Could the threat of nuclear war be removed forever? Thatcher did not agree. In her perspective, nuclear weapons cannot be uninvented. This was the thinking behind the strategic defense initiative, SDI, or as it was properly called Star Wars. Basically, the idea was, you would have these satellites, and the satellites would fire defensive missiles, and if a missile was fired at one country or the other, that missile would be destroyed. Thatcher herself thought this was crazy. As she put it, "Even if an SDI system proved 95% successful, which is a significant success rate, over 60 million people would still die from the missiles that got through."
- 7.25 Reagan privately told himself that he would offer the SDI technology with the Soviets, and this would convince them that this would not leave the US as a unilateral military power, one that could strike down the Russians' missile weapons as well as fire their own. Correspondence between the two ensued, and there was a meeting set up for the two men in November 1985 in Geneva. This was the big moment, the leader of the United States meeting the reformist leader of the Soviet Union. So Reagan walked up to Gorbachev and had his icebreaker. And he told him that he was certain that if the

United States and the Soviet Union were threatened by an invasion from outer space, the two men would cooperate.

- 7.26** As journalist Lou Canon put it, "Gorbachev, who did not have at his fingertips the Marxist position on the propriety of cooperating with the imperialist against interplanetary invasion, changed the subject." Reagan thought this meant he scored a point and he repeated what he said to Gorbachev to a group of high school students when he returned to the United States. He also repeated it to his advisors to mixed reactions. After that, Colin Powell, who was then Deputy National Security Advisor, struggled to keep interplanetary references out of Reagan's speeches. When the subject came up, Powell rolled his eyes and said, "Here comes the little green men again," that the big story of Geneva is that the two had hit it off as human beings.
- 7.27** In fact, the two were of such similar minds that Reagan eventually asked his team, "Why wait until the end of the century for a world without nuclear weapons? Maybe we could both destroy our arsenals in the near future." Thatcher did not think this made sense. As she put it, "It was one of the few times when I think his aspirations left the reality of human nature." She said, "It was inconceivable that the Soviets would turn over their last nuclear weapon. They would cheat. I would cheat." The two men agreed to a one-on-one meeting to prepare the ground for a later, larger Washington summit. Gorbachev proposed either Iceland or Thatcher's home turf of London as two possible locations. Reagan chose Iceland. With two weeks' notice, Reykjavik, the capital of Iceland, was given notice that they would be hosting an event of historic proportions.
- 7.28** The other issue is, it was a lot easier for America with her market-based system to generate the funds to continue an arms race. Gorbachev, with the backwards planned command economy of the Soviets, simply did not have the funds to meet American military might. And Reagan made a joke of this himself.
- 7.29** I've been collecting stories that are told in the Soviet Union by their people among themselves, which reveal they've got a great sense of humor, but they've also got a pretty cynical attitude toward their system. And I told this one, Bill, you'll have to hear it again. I told it in the car. I didn't tell this one to Gorbachev. You know, there's a 10-year delay in the Soviet Union of delivery of an automobile, and only one out of seven families in the Soviet Union own automobiles. There's a 10-year wait. And you go through quite a process when you're ready to buy, and then you put up the money in advance. And this happened to a fellow, and this is their story that they tell, this joke, that this man, he laid down his money, and then the fellow that was in charge said to him, "OK, come back in 10 years and get your car." And he said, "Morning or afternoon?" And the fellow behind the counter said, "Well, 10 years from now, what difference does it make?" And he said, "Well, the plumber is coming in the morning."
- 7.30** But this joke about Soviet inefficiency certainly had a ring of truth to it. So American experts had been arguing whether the Soviet Union had been spending somewhere

between 9 to 11% of their gross domestic product on the military, or was it more like 11 to 13%? The actual number was somewhere between 30% to 40%, and to provide perspective, during World War II, the highest the US spent of GDP on the military was 35%. The Soviets are spending that much every single year, which is an unsustainable cost. As Gorbachev explicitly told Reagan, "The US has money and can do things that the Soviets cannot do." This whole vision that Lenin had of efficiency through a planned economy did not come to fruition. Seventy years later, after the revolution, there were still no omelets.

7.31 As the two men met, Reagan had a very straightforward proposal. First step of the plan, each scraps 50% of their missiles. Then when SDI reaches a point where it could be tested, the US would permit Soviet observers to observe the tests. When the test showed that the system was effective, they would each destroy the balance of their missiles, and each country would share the SDI technology. At 10 years, when all ballistic missiles were eliminated, they would each deploy Star Wars simultaneously. As Reagan's deputy director of the CIA put it, there appeared to be only two people on the planet who thought SDI would actually work, Reagan and Gorbachev. But this remained a sticking point during Iceland.

7.32 Gorbachev found it absolutely incredible that Reagan would share this technology with his lifelong enemies, the Soviets. In fact, as Reagan's director of US arms control and disarmament, Ken Adelman, admitted, there was no way Reagan ever would. Reagan kept insisting on the use of Star Wars as a metaphor, saying that "when the use of chemical weapons was prohibited after World War I, the world did not reject gas masks. They were the guarantee of our protection against such a weapon in case someone decide to use it." Over and over, Gorbachev brought up why Star Wars was unacceptable, and Reagan being Reagan, over and over, Reagan brought up his gas mask metaphor. "That's the 10th time you talked about gas masks," Gorbachev eventually snapped, only exaggerating a little bit.

7.33 Gorbachev began to give Reagan everything he wanted. He agreed with Reagan about reducing and possibly eliminating not only nuclear missiles, but nuclear weapons entirely. He agreed about the need for transparency and mutual verification. When Reagan pointed out he couldn't withdraw nukes from Europe and leave them vulnerable to Soviet invasion, Gorbachev volunteered to massively reduce conventional forces as well. As Reagan put it, "I couldn't believe what was happening. We were getting amazing agreements. I thought we were in complete agreement and we were going to achieve something remarkable."

7.34 Gorbachev sat there and gave Reagan everything he wanted. But Gorbachev, of course, was still a Russian. He leaned forward, smiled at the President, and said, "This all depends, of course, on you giving up SDI." Reagan Reykjavik has now become shorthand in conservative circles for holding fast to one's principles when everything is on the line politically. All Reagan had to do was give up his silly Star Wars program,

which at best was many years from being technologically feasible. He just had to compromise. Reagan refused. He walked.

- 7.35** Thatcher, for her part, was delighted. "My own reaction when I heard how far the Americans had been prepared to go was as if there had been an earthquake beneath my feet." The whole system of nuclear deterrence, which had kept the peace in Europe for 40 years, was close to being abandoned. She even began to say behind closed doors that the Americans were crazy.
- 7.36** Gorbachev was unlike many of his predecessors because throughout his career, he had spent a fair amount of time in the West. In 1983, he spent a week in Canada as part of the Central Committee's Secretariat for Agriculture, studying farming techniques because the Canadian climate was similar to the Soviet one, something that certainly holds true to this day, if you'd catch me. He spent time in Italy, Belgium, the Netherlands, France, and West Germany in the early 1970s as a member of Soviet delegations, and he saw that liberalization was key for the well-being of the citizens of the USSR.
- 7.37** In early 1986, Gorbachev gave a speech announcing his policy of "perestroika", rebuilding, and "glasnost", which meant openness. He saw that honest conversations with Reagan and Thatcher, where all parties agreed, made plain their concerns and goals, allowed for, at the very least, mutual trust and respect. This liberalization of information was met with no small amount of hostility from entrenched bureaucrats and Communist Party officials. As Gorbachev realized, the removal of the curtain of secrecy was tantamount to a death sentence for some organizations because their uselessness would be exposed. Not just the emperor, but the entire court would be found to have no clothes. But once the floodgates were open, little could stop them.
- 7.38** Revelations about Soviet labor camps, Stalin's collusion with Hitler, these became topics of public discourse. Solzhenitsyn's Gulag Archipelago was eventually serialized and published. Even Lolita was cleared for publication by a Russian court. As historian Michael Dobbs pointed out, "The rewriting of Soviet history became so extensive that Soviet secondary schools were obliged to cancel their history exams pending the release of new textbooks." Western shows began to appear on Soviet television, and people could see for themselves how others lived in the West, and they were not, as had been claimed for decades, destitute and hungry.
- 7.39** A few months after Reykjavik, Gorbachev invited Thatcher to visit Moscow in March of 1987. On February 27, 1987, she had a seminar with the UK's greatest experts on the Soviet Union to prepare herself. They informed her that there was no sign of adoption of market principles in the Soviet economy, and there was no likelihood the Soviet ideology would change fundamentally. The foreign office, which she had hated all her life, gave her two silver-handed hair brushes as her official gift to Gorbachev, even though he was completely bald. Thatcher and Gorbachev got along very well when she

got to Moscow, arguing for hours, but in an atmosphere of mutual admiration rather than mutual distrust.

- 7.40 When Thatcher first stepped foot into the Prime Minister's office in 1979, she recited the prayer of St. Francis of Assisi. "Where there is discord, may we bring harmony. Where there is error, may we bring truth. Where there is doubt, may we bring faith. And where there is despair, may we bring hope." And now, in 1987, it was to the Russian people that Margaret Thatcher was bringing hope. This Methodist, this daughter of a green grocer from suburban Grantham, who was the epitome of the hated bourgeoisie that Lenin so despised, was now walking the streets of the Soviet Union, being treated by the Russian media better than she was treated by the Western media. She was not presented as an enemy, but rather as a cousin or a friend.
- 7.41 In a move without precedent, Thatcher was interviewed for an hour on Soviet television by three Russian journalists, and it was aired, unedited, that same evening. Over 120 million people ended up watching the Iron Lady, although, in all fairness, it's not like there was much else on. They saw Thatcher ask the interviewers explicitly, "What do you think are the advantages of a socialist society?" And they didn't answer. They simply changed the subject.
- 7.42 The Russian people were very familiar with the image of a strong, forthright woman who runs circles around the men around her. When she insisted that "we both want above all peace," and pointed out that it was the Soviet Union that had deployed ICBMs in Western Europe, and that the USSR had a very good anti-ballistic missile defense system around Moscow, they knew that she was telling the truth and that it was their media that had been withholding it from them.
- 7.43 A few months after Thatcher's visit, Reagan planned a trip to West Berlin to deliver a speech for the city's 750th anniversary. There was one line that was a huge problem among his staff, but Reagan insisted on delivering it.
- 7.44 General Secretary Gorbachev, if you seek peace, if you seek prosperity for the Soviet Union and Eastern Europe, if you seek liberalization, come here to this gate. Mr. Gorbachev, open this gate. Mr. Gorbachev. Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall.
- 7.45 Though this won Reagan accolades in the West, this really put Gorbachev in a difficult position because if he could be seen as bending the knee to the West, this did not suit his purposes at all. He had to go slowly and carefully against the bureaucracy that had been in place for decades. The following year was Reagan's turn to walk Red Square with Gorbachev. At one point, Gorbachev took a young boy from his mother's arms and gave him to Reagan and said, "Shake hands with grandpa." When Gorbachev had been that boy's age, contact with a foreigner would have been a one-way ticket to the Gulag. Now it was something to celebrate.
- 7.46 A smart reporter asked Reagan if he still regarded the USSR as an evil empire, and the American president said, "No, I was talking about another time, another era." One

month later, Gorbachev gave a major speech and pointed out that the imposition of a social system from outside, by any means, let alone military, are dangerous trappings of the past period, and that power politics in all their forms and manifestations are historically obsolete. No one, not even Gorbachev himself, realized that, in uttering those words, he had committed himself to freeing half the world. The rest was just application.

- 7.47** It had started with Poland. On October 16, 1978, the man who chose the regnal name of Pope John Paul II, became the first non-Italian Pope since the 1500s. And not only a non-Italian Pope, but someone from the far side of the Iron Curtain. One of John Paul's predecessors, Pope Paul VI, had wanted to visit Poland in 1966 to commemorate the 1,000th anniversary of Christianity coming to Poland, but they had refused him. And Brezhnev tried to send Pope John Paul II a similar message, saying, "We know that he's a wise man. Tell him that he's sick and that it's better for him not to come to Poland." He was a wise man and he was in perfectly good health, and he came to Poland anyway.
- 7.48** Pope John Paul II delivered a series of several outdoor masses. Over 10 million Poles came out over the course of his trip to join him in prayer. On June 2, 1979, he stood in Victory Square, which is the largest city square in Warsaw, in front of a crowd of almost 300,000 people. He prayed for his home country and her people, concluding with a desperate plea, "I cry out from the depths of this millennium. Let your spirit descend and renew the face of the earth, the face of this land." The faithful had been told for years that they were alone, but now they saw they had the numbers, not those who preached the doctrine of communism.
- 7.49** The following July saw a series of labor strikes around Poland. Workers protested a hike in prices without an increase in wages. The media did everything it could to suppress news of what was happening, but this was 1980, not 1940. It's far more difficult to suppress the flow of information and far easier to create underground newspapers and radio broadcasts. An agreement in August 1980 reaffirmed the people's constitutional rights in Poland to freedom of speech and of the press. And importantly, it allowed for the establishment of a trade union not under control of the Communist Party and it guaranteed workers the right to strike. Inspired by the Pope, the newfound organization called itself Solidarity. By December of 1981, Solidarity was so popular that they had the ability to threaten a crippling general strike as the Polish authorities continued to crack down on dissent.
- 7.50** And the Polish authorities called their bluff. They didn't have a choice. Moscow told them in no uncertain terms that if they don't crack down, they would send in the tanks. And this was something that Moscow had done in the lifetime of virtually everyone, if not everyone, in the Polish leadership. On December 13th, 1981, the Polish government declared martial law, and they abandoned even the pretense of a country where law had any meaning.

- 7.51** Hundreds of telecommunication exchanges were raided. Telephone lines were cut in order to prevent what they called misinformation from spreading. A curfew was imposed. Huge swaths of industry were placed under military control. Airports shut down, borders sealed, and travel to and from major cities was heavily controlled. When coal miners went on strike, the government fired at them, killing eight men. Other protests were met with similarly deadly consequences, but the persecution worked. The protests died down, and eventually, a year later, martial law was repealed. The leaders of Solidarity were given relatively short prison sentences, but the organization was now banned. What had been a nationwide labor movement now became a heavily weakened underground resistance force.
- 7.52** Thatcher visited Poland in November 1988 with the same general who had imposed martial law seven years prior. But now he had toned down his authoritarianism and let her know that he wanted to open dialogue with Solidarity. She was delighted to be able to act as an intermediary. She met with Solidarity's leader, Lech Walesa, and she urged him to meet with Jaruzelski, the general, and to exchange views to make sure that the authorities heard what he had been telling her. Lech Walesa just pointed to the ceiling. He goes, "No problem. Our meetings are bugged anyway."
- 7.53** The following month, Gorbachev delivered a major speech at the UN and promised that within two years, the Soviet military would be reduced by half a million personnel. Rather than sending in the tanks, as his predecessors had threatened and done, he would be removing them from East Germany, from Czechoslovakia, from Hungary, in addition to withdrawing tens of thousands of Soviet troops from these other countries. Polish government officials were thus free to negotiate with Solidarity without the threat of a Soviet gun to their heads.
- 7.54** Jaruzelski insisted that they didn't have a choice but to start these talks. This was a controversy within the leading party of Poland. The Prime Minister agreed with Jaruzelski, saying, "We are not dreaming about giving up power. We're talking here about arranging to retain power." Jaruzelski threatened to resign if he didn't get his way. The Prime Minister, the Interior Minister, and the Defense Minister, they all joined the first secretary in his threat. The government was already losing its sense of legitimacy with the population, and this, they saw, would be a way to regain it.
- 7.55** They announced that they would be engaged in official talks with Solidarity. For two months, the government met with Solidarity leaders and discussed every issue. There were 92 total sessions of what became known as the roundtable talks, because the talks were held around circular tables to be sure that no one could be seen as sitting at the head. Solidarity was given access to the airwaves, so they could directly explain to the Polish people what was being negotiated that day.
- 7.56** In March of 1989, another nation followed Poland's lead. Miklos Nemeth, who was Hungarian Prime Minister, paid a visit to Gorbachev in Moscow to let him know he had made a decision and effectively to ask for permission. 300 kilometers of barbed wire

and electrified fencing separated Hungary from democratic Austria. He wanted to tear it all down. He told Gorbachev it had outlived its usefulness. Hungary was not isolated from the outside world, and Hungarians had been permitted to travel abroad. In fact, the Hungarian capital of Budapest was and remains a tourist destination. The fence was expensive and it did little good, with fewer than a dozen Hungarians trying to cross it anyway.

7.57 Gorbachev seemed not to bat an eye. To be completely sure that he had permission to proceed, Nemeth reminded Gorbachev that the USSR still had 80,000 troops stationed in Hungary. He didn't want 1956 to happen again. Gorbachev told the Prime Minister, "If something happens, you can be certain that there will be no instruction or order from us to crush it." That same day, Gorbachev met with the General Secretary of the Hungarian Socialist Workers Party, who asked Gorbachev to remove the nuclear weapons that had been held in Hungary for years. Gorbachev agreed on the spot. He decided to push his advantage. He said, "To distance us from the memories of 1956, I put it to you that all Soviet troops should leave Hungary." Gorbachev agreed as well. He wanted to hold off to see if he could use the withdrawal as a bargaining chip to get NATO forces reduced in Europe. But as a sign of good faith, hundreds of tanks and 5,000 Soviet troops were withdrawn from Hungary.

7.58 The Hungarian were dumbfounded, and so was the East German leadership. Any border is only as strong as its weakest point. And by removing the barrier between Hungary and Austria, this was a major breach in the Iron Curtain. And in fact, none of the other Warsaw Pact countries had been consulted about this decision. The East Germans called the Hungarian leadership and were told that East Germans would not be permitted to use Hungary as a pit stop to flee to the West. Several days later, massive demonstrations took place in Budapest, and one leader stood in front of Parliament and proclaimed publicly that "history has pronounced its death sentence on the system called socialism." Instead of incarceration, the only reaction was massive applause.

7.59 Several weeks later, the final details of Poland's roundtable talks were agreed to. Solidarity would be legalized and given official recognition. One-third of the seats in the Lower House of Congress and all 100 seats in the Upper House, the Senate, would be democratically contested. This Polish government saw this not as a loss of power, but as a way of integrating the opposition into the state and validating its authority. It regarded it as a 10- to 15-year process toward a stable power-sharing arrangement.

7.60 But these trends were not the same throughout the Warsaw Pact. Romania, especially, went the other way. Communism often meant the elevation of the mediocre to the highest levels of power, and there are a few better examples of this than Romanian leader Nicolae Ceausescu. In a free country, Ceausescu would have been a mail room clerk baffled if a written address was mismatched between 757 Legion Street and 757 Legion Avenue. As Ceausescu grew older, his biggest skill was knowing how to work the

system, which made him the right man at the right time to replace the Romanian leader when he died of cancer in 1965. No one particularly liked him, but no one particularly hated him. The totally mediocre gray man was the perfectly acceptable compromise candidate.

- 7.61** When he took over Romania, he did so as an unorthodox leader. In '68, for example, he denounced the Soviet Union's invasion in Czechoslovakia, and he often didn't follow Moscow's lead in other matters. But, and this is a big but, in 1967, Ceausescu implemented Decree 770 in Romania, which aimed at increasing Romania's population by 50%. Proclaiming that the fetus is the property of the entire society, both abortion and contraception were made illegal for women under the age of 40 or with fewer than four children. Not having a child was taxed, the marriage age was lowered to 15, and Romanian women of childbearing age were given mandatory gynecological exams every month by the menstrual police, where the traumatized woman would be forced to prove that she had, in fact, lost her child organically.
- 7.62** In 1971, Ceausescu visited both China and North Korea and was heavily inspired by the Stalinist personality cults by Chairman Mao and the great leader Kim Il-sung. And soon, Romanians were being constantly told about Ceausescu's unparalleled brilliance and leadership skills. Part of the propaganda was expanded to include his wife Elena, whose completely nonexistent beauty was praised in terms just as highly as her utterly nonexistent intelligence was. As one historian put it, "As conditions inside Romania worsened, Romanians not only had to endure new privations, but also had to praise those responsible for inflicting them in increasingly fulsome terms."
- 7.63** After dropping out of school at age 14, Elena had been expelled from adult education institute night school courses for cheating on a test. Nevertheless, as first lady in 1967, she received a fake PhD in chemistry. Ghost-written scientific papers were presented as having been written by this barely-educated woman, and the Romanian government lobbied international publications and organizations to publish her work and grant her honorary degrees. Then the media could reasonably speak of Elena being a world-renowned scientist, internationally published. Despite all this, she treated her subordinates with pure contempt, as the Romanian health minister described her as "very vain and almost illiterate, as well as unadulterated evil."
- 7.64** As the 1970s proceeded, Ceausescu was smart and triangulated Romania between the USSR and the West in order to receive favors from both, and his efforts met with a great amount of success. Despite turning Romania into the the most authoritarian of the Soviet Bloc nations, his posturing against the USSR allowed him entrance into Western circles that were eager to exploit differences within the second world of communism. Nicolae and Elena waved from the White House balcony as guests of President Nixon and President Carter, and they danced with President Ford in the streets of Bucharest. Queen Elizabeth gave him a knight grand cross of the Order of the Bath, which is the highest award for a foreign leader.

- 7.65 As the 1980s rolled around, those international loans to Romania came due, and Ceausescu focused on exports at the expense of his own population. The price of goods and services increased dramatically, while cuts were made in government spending on housing, health care, and education. Food was strictly rationed. Television was limited three hours a day, with many neighborhoods not even having enough electricity for that. As one historian pointed out, "The sudden power cuts forced coal miners to climb up ladders in the dark at the end of their shifts or compelled surgeons to abort surgical procedures at the last moment." This was in addition to infants whose life support systems were suddenly disconnected and patients whose iron lungs suddenly stopped.
- 7.66 Mortality rates among pregnant women and infants set European records in Romania. An entire generation was raised by government orphanages dedicated to children whose parents simply couldn't afford to feed them and who were encouraged to abandon them to the superior care of state experts. Now, the government couldn't afford to raise them well either, which result in years of room upon room of infants chained to their cribs in puddles of their own waste to little or no caretaker response. Malnutrition, which resulted in stunted growth and mental disabilities, was the norm, and both physical and sexual assault against the children, not uncommon. AIDS spread among the orphan population due to tainted and often medically unnecessary blood transfusions.
- 7.67 One British journalist was an eyewitness to the rooms in which these children were being raised. In addition to the pervasive smell of urine, he pointed out it was the silence that he found most disturbing. Usually when you enter a room packed with cots filled with children, the expectation is of a noise, chatter, or crying, sometimes even a wimper. There was none, even though the children were awake. "They lay in their cots, sometimes two to a cot, sometimes three, their eyes staring. Silently. It was eerie, almost sinister. They were inhuman. Stalls where children, babies, were treated like farm animals. No, I'm wrong. At least the animals felt brave enough to make a noise."
- 7.68 Ceausescu's holier-than-thou attitude increased over time as he began to believe all the propaganda fed to the Romanian people about his greatness. He was referred to as "the new morningstar," "the living fire," "the treasure of wisdom and charisma." As Gorbachev put it, "I've encountered many ambitious people in my life. Indeed, it is hard to imagine a major politician without his share of vanity and self-confidence. In this sense, though, Ceausescu was in a class of his own." An absolute ruler for decades, he always wore an arrogant smirk, treating others with apparent contempt, everyone from retainers to equal partners.
- 7.69 In 1984, Ceausescu laid the groundstone for the People's House, which is a huge edifice, which was going to be five times the size of Versailles. It was going to be the heaviest building on Earth, and that was supposedly built for the Romanian people. It would serve the Ceausescus as the largest palace that had ever been constructed. Both the military and ordinary citizens were drafted to help in its construction, even though

hundreds of citizens literally froze to death every year in the Romanian winter. Others died from asphyxiation due to turning on their stoves to provide heat, having the gas go out, and then having it come back on unlit. Eventually, construction costs for the People's House was roughly the same as Romania's entire welfare budget.

7.70 When Gorbachev visited Bucharest in 1987, he attempted to get Ceausescu to open his country to the outside world. Ceausescu thought this would be disastrous, both for communism and himself. He was not entirely wrong. And their arguments degenerated into shouting. Doors and windows were shut to make sure that no one could hear what was transpiring between the two leaders. In April 1989, about a week after the announcement of Poland's roundtable agreement, Ceausescu had an announcement of his own. On the one hand, Romania's foreign debt had now been paid off and months ahead of schedule. On the other hand, the rationing and lack of electricity would nevertheless continue. But this was a period when the Soviet Union had a much better relationship with the West, so there was no reason for Western countries to court Ceausescu as an antagonistic force against the USSR. The situation for the Romanian people seemed to be completely hopeless.

7.71 This was the backdrop to the Polish elections on June 4th, 1989. The communists had insisted on a swift vote, hoping it would reestablish their authority as Poland's natural leaders. In fact, there was a concern in the Communist Party about what would happen if they won every election due to their popularity of the people because people would say that the election had been fixed. They needn't have worried. There were 35 seats up for election in the Lower House. Solidarity won 33 of them in the first round of voting. There were 100 seats up in the Senate for election. Solidarity won 99. The Prime Minister, the Interior Minister, the Defense Minister who had all threatened to resign, it wasn't a threat anymore. They were all voted out.

7.72 But would the party honor the results of the election? That was the big question on the table. But the crazy thing is, this wasn't even the biggest news in the world that day, because June 4th, 1989, was the day of the Tiananman Square massacre.

Lecture 8: Shattering the Soviet State

At a glance — Shattering the Soviet state and its collapse.

- 8.1** For weeks, protests against the government had been held throughout China, largely fueled by students and other young people, and a huge number of them occupied Tiananmen Square in Beijing, right outside Chairman Mao's mausoleum. They constructed a 33-foot-high statue of the Goddess of Democracy, which spoke to their hopes for a free democratic China. Those hopes were soon squashed. On the night of June 3rd and into the morning of June 4th, the Chinese officials sent in the tanks. They did a very good job of keeping the footage away from international observers. We still don't know how many people were killed. Hundreds, thousands. Internationally, the reaction to the Tiananmen Square massacre was one of horror and sadness.
- 8.2** In Poland, there was great concern that martial law would be reinstated. As one senior Solidarity figure put it, "We knew that we had won the election, but we also knew that they had all the guns." The communications between Moscow and Warsaw demonstrated to the Polish government that there was no appetite from the Soviet government for another Tiananmen Square in Europe. One journalist was eyewitness to the events, and here's how he put it. He said, "Three things happened at once. The communists lost an election. Solidarity won. The communists acknowledged that Solidarity won." And that might sound like a syllogism, yet until almost the day before, anyone who had predicted these events would have been universally considered not a logician, but a lunatic.
- 8.3** The East Germans had a very different take on what China had done. Their news programs repeatedly played their authorities' congratulations to the Chinese government for its prompt action in dealing with disturbances in Beijing that were instigated by Western imperialist agents. East Germans got the message loud and clear. Many East Germans who had been vacationing in Hungary never went back. One after another, they decide to drive their cars to Budapest. The plan was to make their way to Austria and then to West Germany, where they would automatically be granted West German citizenship.
- 8.4** And in the same way that citizens had vanished during Stalin's Great Terror, never to be seen again, now in East Germany, people understood that people were vanishing one after another. The East German authorities called the Hungarian authorities, demanding that these citizens be returned, and the Hungarians explicitly refused. Hungary regarded them as refugees, and at one point, there were 85,000 East Germans on Hungarian soil. Honecker was apoplectic, and even more so when Gorbachev refused to intervene. He was told he had to settle the matter with the Hungarians by himself.

- 8.5 And now Hungary further liberalized. They promised to allow the exhumation, identification, and burial of Imre Nagy's remains, which had long been hidden to keep his grave from becoming a shrine. And the government officially changed their position on what had happened in Hungary in 1956. It was no longer called a counterrevolution, but it was now called a popular uprising. On June 16, 1989, Nagy and his four closest associates finally got an official funeral. There was a sixth coffin alongside theirs to represent the unknown insurgents, all those other Hungarians, many of whom are anonymous, who gave their lives in a failed effort to liberate the country from Soviet rule. Audio of one of his speeches was broadcast over the loudspeakers at Hero Square in Budapest, and 200,000 Hungarians came out to pay their respects, to lay flowers on top of the coffins of those who had given all.
- 8.6 Ten days after Nagy's funeral, the head of Hungary ceded power to a Presidium of himself and three other men. The dam broke swiftly and decisively for what had been the most liberal of the Warsaw Pact nations. Honecker of East Germany, Ceausescu of Romania, were beside themselves. They demanded that Gorbachev intervene in both Poland and Hungary. His answer was unambiguous. He told them, "Those who are afraid had better hold on because perestroika has only just begun." And in fact, he said, "Ceausescu is only worried for his own skin."
- 8.7 Honecker could do nothing, for his own life was in the balance. He was in Romania on June 8th, 1989. And after he gave a speech about the dangers facing communism, he grabbed his side and collapsed in extreme pain. When he returned to Berlin, it turned out that he had gall bladder cancer. Now, the ultra-centralized East German government was paralyzed as Honecker recuperated, and East German officials sat on their hands as matters continued to grow out of their control. No one wanted to be seen as assuming responsibility, which would be seen as undermining Honecker's rule.
- 8.8 Hungary further went full throttle on liberalization. On August 19th, 1989, they announced that the border between Austria and Hungary would be temporarily opened, exactly where the electrified fence between the two nations had been taken down. A ceremonial gate would be constructed. Its doors opened with delegations from both Hungary and Austria crossing the border to demonstrate a show of support for the concept of freedom of movement between nations.
- 8.9 Word got out to the refugees to make their way to the town, Sopron, and both the Austrian Red Cross and the Austrian authorities made preparations to receive an influx of those East Germans who had been in Hungary. Behind the scenes, the Hungarian authorities told their guards to stand down, should any refugee try to make their way to Austria that day. The head of the border guard explicitly told his officers to order the refugees to turn back, but to do absolutely nothing to prevent them from doing so. About 2,000 refugees crossed from Hungary to Austria that day in complete disbelief that this wasn't all some big communist trick.

- 8.10** Those East Germans who remained in Budapest swarmed the West German consulate, trying to get West German passports. Refugee centers were set up throughout Hungary to service the needs of those East Germans making their way west. The East Germans demanded to send planes and trains to repatriate their refugees, but the requests were immediately dismissed by Hungarian officials. At a certain point, the East Germans could no longer ignore the number of missing people, not entirely, and they denounced the refugees as either political illiterates or criminals, but no one listened.
- 8.11** The contrary news reports from the West about what had happened to the refugees were incessant. Word of their fate spread throughout East Germany. By and large, what mattered to the East Germans was how their former countrymen were being treated in what became known as the Exodus. In fact, Eduard Shevardnadze, who was the Soviet foreign minister, told the GDR to allow for emigration. And he told the German foreign minister, "It will not be bad and will ease your economic burdens." On August 24th, 1989, Tadeusz Mazowiecki was inaugurated as the Prime Minister of Poland. Within less than a year, the communists in Poland went from controlling every aspect of Polish society, all the seats in Parliament, all the guns, to nonexistence. The Polish United Workers Party officially dissolved itself in January of 1990, and the communists never again regained a foothold on power in Poland.
- 8.12** As for Hungary, their version of the roundtable talks were held around a triangular table, but the results were even more dramatic. The ruling Hungarian Socialist Workers Party rebranded itself as the Hungarian Socialist Party and eventually became the main center left party in Hungarian politics. In 1998, a young man who had been prominent in those protests by the name of Viktor Orbán was elected Prime Minister at the age of 35. He left office at the end of his first term but returned in 2010 through to this day as Prime Minister of Hungary. To paraphrase Ernest Hemingway, the Poles and the Hungarians were thus liberated in two ways, gradually and then suddenly. But they were not the only ones.
- 8.13** On August 25th, 1989, the day after Mazowiecki became Poland's Prime Minister, the Prime Minister of Hungary secretly flew to West Germany to meet with West German Chancellor Helmut Kohl. He said, "We have decided to allow the GDR citizens to leave freely, mainly on humanitarian grounds," and warned him that "you may have to deal with 100,000 or even 150,000 new citizens arriving very quickly." The West Germans were skeptical. They were happy to keep the matter quiet from the East Germans. But here was the proof that, given the choice, the people of Germany would prefer the liberal West to the Communist East, to the numbers of hundreds of thousands, even at the risk of losing all their belongings and what had been their past lives.
- 8.14** And that left the elephant in the room, the Soviet Union. Did the Russians know? How would they react? Helmut Kohl was not taking any chances. He'd been drafted by the Nazis at the age of 15 at the end of World War II, and he had avoided combat, but he remembered what the Russians had done to Germany. He called Gorbachev to make

sure there would be no escalation of tensions if this plan came to fruition. And all Gorbachev said was, "Hungarians are good people," which was Gorbachev's code to endorse what was going on. And now they had to let the East Germans know.

8.15 The East Germans insisted that if the refugees were returned to East Germany, they would not be punished, but the Hungarians didn't believe them. And more importantly, neither did the refugees. The East Germans were livid. They wrote to Budapest. They wrote to Moscow. They tried to rally all those Warsaw Pact leaders who had invaded Czechoslovakia to do something about Hungary. But the Poles said no, and the Russians couldn't care less. The head of the Stasi insisted that "Hungary is betraying socialism," and he wasn't entirely wrong. On September 10th, 1989, all border controls were lifted in Hungary. Within three days, over 18,000 East Germans made their way west, assisted by buses provided by the West German government.

8.16 It was clear that a crack had formed in the totalitarian power of the East German regime, and the East German population intended to make the most of it. On the month of September, 1989, demonstrations began to coalesce in Leipzig, East Germany's second largest city. They would meet at St. Nicholas's Church, an 800-year-old church. They lit candles every Monday evening, and they began to march. Soon, thousands joined, if only because there's so little else for them to do. The head of the Stasi, Erich Mielke, insisted that East Germany have its own Tiananmen Square. He said that Chinese comrades must be lauded because they were able to spot the protest before the situation got out of hand and said, "The situation here is comparable and must be countered by all means and methods." On September 18, 1989, there were 15,000 marchers in Leipzig. The Stasi arrested 100 of them, running over others as they sped away. But that did little to stop the masses and did much to further alienate the population from the regime.

8.17 Now, in between East Germany and Hungary, both geographically and politically, stood Czechoslovakia. The head of Czechoslovakia, Milos Jakes, had closed his border with East Germany to make it more difficult for the East Germans to use his country as a halfway house between Hungary and then the West. But now he had a problem with all those East Germans who remained in Prague. They overwhelmed the West German embassy, and something had to give.

8.18 From his hospital bed, Honecker had an idea that was so bizarre and out of touch that only a government official could have conceived of it. He cut a deal with the Czechoslovakian authorities and the West Germans to allow those refugees to emigrate. Here was their condition. They had to return to East Germany in order to travel west, and they had to hand in their ID cards and lose their East German citizenship in the process. So the migrants were very confused. It had to be a trap, but if it was a trap, what's the catch? So they'd give up their East German citizenship and they'd get West German citizenship and a passport, and the only cost is that Honecker considers them a traitor? It took the West German some efforts to persuade the

refugees to trust them. And soon, in an almost perfect inversion of World War II, train cars packed full of refugees began to be deported from East Germany. Except in this case, they were making their way West into freedom.

- 8.19** After that, thousands more began to drive to Czechoslovakia, and the timing couldn't have been worse for Honecker. October 7th, 1989, was the date of a massive nationwide event to commemorate the 40th anniversary of the founding of the GDR. Part of the event featured a visit from Gorbachev, and the Soviet leader did not mince words. He insisted that "life punishes those who fall behind," which was clearly a slap at Honecker, who could only sit there and bite his tongue. As the procession passed where the leader sat, Gorbachev, who could not speak German very well, still heard what the people were saying, "Gorby, help us. Help us."
- 8.20** There were still almost 400,000 Soviet troops stationed in East Germany. The evening after Gorbachev left, their commander received a phone call with orders from the Soviet ambassador. "Do not interfere in any way with internal GDR developments. Let them take their course." When they double-checked with Moscow, they got a confirmation of these orders. Regardless of what was to happen in East Germany, the Russians would be on the side of peace. That same day, demonstrations erupted throughout East Germany as the citizens realized that Gorbachev was on their side and not on the side of Honecker's, and that the authority's strength was decreasing.
- 8.21** Over a thousand people were arrested the following day in Berlin alone, many beaten by the Stasi, both publicly and behind closed doors. But what's a thousand people in a nation of over 16 million? The following night, matters reached a peak. On October 9th, 1989, there were 8,000 people at St. Nicholas's Church alone, far too many to fit inside. The Stasi were ready for them, and so were members of the military. Bloodshed was not just a possibility, but a promise. As one Communist Party newspaper put it, "We will fight these enemies of our country, if necessary, with arms."
- 8.22** The army was stationed on the route of the demonstration. The young men were handed pistols and plenty of ammunition. Many of these soldiers burst into tears because they knew that their wives or their parents or their siblings were marching that night, some with their children, and they knew what those guns could do to those people. If they warned their families to what end, if it wasn't their own mother who would be shot, it would be somebody else's. Here's an example of people who were marching. She's holding a sign that says, "Reform for our schools," with smiley faces. They were given orders to shoot her or her dad from under her. Those soldiers had enlisted to protect their country, and now were being asked to murder families for walking down the street.
- 8.23** By five o'clock, there were 70,000 protesters outside the church. Local party officials called Berlin, hoping for a peaceful resolution. Finally, the second secretary of the party district leadership made the call. He said there would be no force used. He got Honecker's second-in-command, Egon Krenz, on the phone, got him to agree. And all

government forces in Leipzig were told to take no active action against persons if there were no anti-state activities and attacks against security forces, objects, or facilities. And so the Leipzigers lit their candles and marched. They held up signs insisting that they wanted peaceful change.

8.24 The Stasi had spent decades infiltrating protest groups, but the East Germans had spent decades learning their Stasi tricks. And when Stasi officers in plain clothes broke their cover and tried to pull people's signs away, they were swiftly surrounded by the crowd, and the chant was steady and the same. "We are the people. No violence." It was the largest protest East Germany had ever seen. Footage of the march was aired on Western television, and swiftly all of East Germany was aware of what was going on and how nothing was being done to stop it. Leipzig earned the nickname of "Heldenstadt", Hero City.

8.25 Now the politicians began to speak up. Leipzig's mayor asked for dialogue, and so did the mayor of Dresden, which sat just by the border with Czechoslovakia. Many in the party leadership knew that change was necessary. Things could have swiftly gotten out of control. And another Tiananmen Square massacre was right around the corner as long as Honecker was in charge. A quiet revolt was organized behind the cancerous man's back. The following Monday, October 16th, over 120,000 people came out to protest. The ones who had been afraid, understandably, had now seen for themselves that no one had been harmed the previous week, neither by the Stasi nor the military. The chants were the same as the week prior. "We are the people, no violence." But now there was a new chant, "Down with the wall."

8.26 Honecker sat there with his men and just muttered the same thing over and over. Now, surely something has to be done. Something has to be done. Surely something has to be done. That's Honecker on the left. Among them in the room was Colonel General Fritz Streletz. Streletz is Russian for shooter, by the way. He was chief of staff of the military, and he was no weakling and no dove, to put it mildly. He had been a member of the Nazi Wehrmacht. He had spent three years as a Soviet prisoner after World War II. He was and remained a committed communist. Streletz looked at Honecker and as tactfully as possible, told the East German ruler to go fuck himself. "We can't do anything," Streletz said. "We will let the whole matter take its course peacefully."

8.27 The next morning, the East German Communist Party leadership had a meeting. The Prime Minister interjected as soon as everyone was called to order, and he said, "I suggest a new first item be placed on the agenda. It is the release of Erich Honecker from his duties as general secretary and the election of Egon Krenz in his place." Honecker did not react. There was no precedent for this. It caught him entirely by surprise. He couldn't simply ignore the request, so he turned to those he regarded as his most loyal allies in the room, but Honecker had no allies left. One by one, as they had secretly planned, all the men took turns using their words to denounce him, stabbing him not in the back, but in the front.

- 8.28** The vote was unanimous because Honecker, being a good communist, accepted the decision of the collective and voted against himself as well. After he left party headquarters, he phoned the Soviet ambassador, let him know the news, and then he called Margot to tell her as well. She herself would be sacked as education minister a few weeks later. If you remember that Russian joke I'd said about "blame everything on my predecessor," the East Germans thought, "OK, if we sacrifice Honecker to the masses, they would have a honeymoon period under Krenz's leadership." In this, they were as out of touch as Honecker had grown. After all, Krenz had been shown repeatedly on East German television, shaking hands with the Chinese leadership after Tiananmen Square.
- 8.29** The week after Honecker's ouster, over one million East Germans took to the streets in continued protests. On November 1st, Egon Krenz flew to Moscow to me with Gorbachev, who just regarded him as the second Honecker. Krenz had two items on his agenda. First, he learned that the GDR's finances were complete disasters. A majority of the machines being used industrially were write-offs, meaning the cost to repair them outweighed any benefit. Worse, East Germany was days away from defaulting on interest payments on foreign loans. When that happened, getting further credit would be close to impossible, and economic collapse virtually certain.
- 8.30** Would the Soviet Union please help bail them out? And Krenz said, after all, "the GDR is in a sense the child of the Soviet Union and one must acknowledge paternity of one's children." Gorbachev refused and instead argued for more reforms, just as he'd been pushing in the USSR. And now, Krenz turned to threats. He pointed out that if what was happening in Leipzig hit Berlin, it would be possible the Berliners might storm the Berlin Wall itself. That would be awful because then the police would have to intervene, and "certain elements of a state of emergency would have to be introduced." He was threatening Gorbachev with unleashing the power of the East German state against his own people. Gorbachev was disgusted and sent Krenz back to Berlin empty-handed. He sent a memo to the heads of the Soviet forces stationed in the GDR, reminding them to do absolutely nothing to intervene if matters took a turn for the worse.
- 8.31** Three days later, Krenz's prediction to Gorbachev came true. Over 700,000 Berliners took to the streets under the slogan of "We are the people." The propaganda chief, Gunter Schabowski, took to the platform in a show of support for the crowds. They booed him off the stage. On November 8th, Helmut Kohl, chancellor of West Germany, met with Lech Walesa in Poland to discuss the ongoing situation throughout Central Europe. Walesa told him, "You know, the wall will come down soon. I don't know when, but I really think very soon, maybe weeks." And Helmut Kohl laughed in his face. He said, "You're young and don't understand some things." There are long historical process is going on, and this will take many years. Both of the men were wrong.
- 8.32** The imagery of thousands of citizens camped out as refugees had been enormously humiliating to East Germany's international prestige. And now the new East German

government tried a new approach to try to control those citizens who were trying to flee. They decided they would be allowed to emigrate if they asked for permission while on East German soil. That way the authorities would at least have some measure of control over the whole mess, and maybe they'd be able to hide the extent of the situation from the outside world.

- 8.33** And on November 9th, Schabowski, who was the propaganda chief, held his daily press conference. After an hour of talking with the press, he said there was time for one more question. Now, word had gotten around there would be new travel regulations, and he was prepared for this. He spoke about Krenz right before the press conference, and Krenz had even given him a copy of the decree that was going to be announced to look over. As he explained, "We have decided today to implement a regulation that allows every citizen in the German Democratic Republic to leave the GDR through any of their border crossings." He didn't notice the sentence on the back of the paper, embargoing the information until the following morning. He said, "That comes into effect, according to my information, immediately without delay."
- 8.34** And one journalist asked, "Does this also apply for West Berlin?" He shrugged, looked back at his papers, and reread a key passage. "Permanent exit can take place via all border crossings from the GDR to the FRG and West Berlin, respectively." In other words, the propaganda chief of East Germany announced live on camera that East Berliners were free to leave to West Berlin without any fear of repercussion. Not only did he announce it, but he repeated it for good measure. The Berlin Wall was effectively now just a concrete structure.
- 8.35** The East German broadcast of the press conference began at 7:30, and the East Berliners began to storm the wall immediately thereafter. The guards had heard the rumors and were left unsure of what to do. "Open the gate," people chanted. "The wall must go." For the first time in their lives, the East German citizens felt comfortable arguing with the soldiers and the Stasi officials, and they were safe to do so. Later that night, all six East Berlin border checkpoints were mobbed with 20,000 people at the Bornholmer-Strasse checkpoint alone. The border guard commander stationed there made a professional assessment of the situation. All he was thinking about was how to avoid bloodshed. If a panic started, people would have been crushed. Yes, we all had pistols. What if one of my men lost his nerve in the mess? He ordered his men to open the gate.
- 8.36** One hour later, unaware of what had happened at the other crossing point, the border guard commander at Checkpoint Charlie came to the same decision. The citizens of East Germany were greeted in West Berlin with flowers and champagne by their fellow Germans. By midnight, all six checkpoints on the Berlin Wall were wide open. All 12,000 border guards were sent back to their barracks. The entire world watched in shock as residents of a united Berlin were literally dancing on top of the Berlin Wall.

- 8.37** Helmut Kohl cut his trip to Poland short. He said, "I'm at the wrong party," and flew back to Germany. No one even thought to phone Moscow until 5 in the morning, and even then, no one bothered to tell Gorbachev. He woke up the following morning to scenes that seemed unimaginable the day prior. He called Krenz to give his consent after the fact. He said, "You made the right decision because how can you shoot Germans who walk across the border to meet other Germans?"
- 8.38** Now, in between Hungary and East Germany was Czechoslovakia, but the Communist Party leader there, Milos Jakes, intended to stay the course. He told his comrades that as long as the economy holds up, we'll be all right. But there was one problem, the 50th anniversary of the murder of Jan Opletal. Opletal was a 24-year-old medical student shot by the Nazis for protesting their occupation of Czechoslovakia, and the communists had made him into a martyr in the decades following World War II. The anniversary march took place as planned on Friday, November 17th, 1989, eight days after the Berlin Wall was opened. The crowd held banners denouncing communism and commemorating the Prague uprising of 1968, but the police did nothing.
- 8.39** When the march ended, the crowd dispersed, except for a group of mostly students who made their way to Prague's historic Wenceslas Square. As they approached the square, they found their way blocked by riot police and anti-terrorist squads who had their batons ready. The protesters gave the police their flowers, and they gave them their candles. They sat down in the street, chanting, "We have no weapons," and they sang songs. Then another group of police came up behind them. They were trapped on the street for 2 hours, singing songs in the freezing cold. When asked if they could go home, the police said nothing. At 9 PM, a riot squad van arrived and began ramming into them. And that's when the police began their beating. Over 500 people were injured, men, women, and children alike, and the 120 who were arrested were thereupon beaten again. Supposedly, there was one casualty, and the lesson of Jan Opletal was that the life of one student can make an enormous difference.
- 8.40** Rumors in communist nations were often more truthful than any official media source, and the story got out that the police had murdered a young student by the name of Martin Schmidt. It was reported as truth by foreign media outlets. In fact, there were two students by the name Martin Schmidt who were studying at Prague's Charles University at the time, and the government swiftly produced them to demonstrate that they were safe and unharmed. After four decades of communist rule, the authorities were actually telling the truth. After four decades of communist rule, no one believed them.
- 8.41** Now that the authorities had chosen violence, everything was on the table. That weekend saw demonstrations that hadn't been seen in Prague since 1968, with the spot where the police had beaten the protesters taking on the form of a shrine. Students were now joined by every type of citizen, and all the government could think to do in response was to arrest the activists who spread the rumor that Schmidt had

been killed. Czechoslovakia's answer to Lech Walesa was Václav Havel. He was a dissident figurehead who fought authorities for decades while getting arrested and released. He was a playwright, but his career was destroyed due to his support of the Prague Spring. His works were banned in Czechoslovakia, and he himself was forbidden from leaving the country.

- 8.42** He suspected that the end of the Berlin Wall meant that things would swiftly change in Czechoslovakia, and he returned to Prague from the countryside to take part in the drama. Havel organized at a theater with the fortuitous name of the Magic Lantern. The protesters called themselves the Civic Forum, and they presented themselves as spokesmen for the people, and they issued four demands—the resignation of the leaders who had crushed the Prague Spring, the resignation of the ministers who had ordered the attacks on the students, an independent inquiry into recent events, and the immediate release of all political prisoners.
- 8.43** The protest grew and continued over the following days. The energy was felt in every segment of the country. Actors went on strike. So did football players. The Monday alone after police violence saw 300,000 protesters. A new symbol of defiance arose. People in the crowds held up their keys and shook them in the air, telling the communists to pack their shit and go home. The Magic Lantern became a beacon to a huge swath of ideologies who had one thing in common, freeing Czechoslovakia from communist rule. It was a revolution, but a soft and peaceful one, and it became known as the Velvet Revolution for just that reason.
- 8.44** The authorities considered sending in the tanks, not the Russian ones, but their own. On Wednesday, November 22nd, they decided to call out the People's Militia. But there was one problem. The People's Militia refused to take up arms against their countrymen, especially the students. That was enough for the defense minister. He went on television that very evening and let the citizens know the army would not fight them. Havel had joked that it was time for another Russian invasion, but expected this time the Russians would be on the sides of the people. He wasn't entirely wrong.
- 8.45** Gorbachev dispatched the head of the party's international department to Prague to see what was going on. He went directly to the Magic Lantern and met with the Civic Forum himself. And the Soviet embassy also received a delegation from the Civic Forum. These were signals that the Russians regarded the organization as a legitimate, respectable political force in Czechoslovakia. The government tried to censor the images from the news, but there was too much foreign coverage to keep the information from the public. How can you sweep such a story under the rug when hundreds of thousands of people are demonstrating in freezing cold weather?
- 8.46** Friday evening, a week after it all started, Alexander Dubcek, who had been leader of the Prague Spring in 1968, appeared alongside Havel on a balcony in Wenceslas Square, in front of an audience of half a million people. It was as if Martin Luther King had reappeared in Washington, DC, and began to sing We Shall Overcome. The spirit of

1968 was alive and well in Prague. One hour later, both men held a press conference at the Magic Lantern, and that's when the news broke across the entire country. The communist party leaders were resigning.

8.47 As one journalist joked to Havel, "In Poland, it took 10 years. In Hungary, 10 months. In East Germany, 10 weeks. In Czechoslovakia, it will take 10 days." Ten days had been a ridiculously optimistic estimate, and it turned out an overly conservative one. Instead of taking 10 days, it had taken seven. As a test, the Civic Forum called the nationwide general strike for Monday the 27th. The strike was to last two hours, but it would clearly demonstrate who was on which side. It was instantly clear, just as it had been in Poland with that vote, that virtually all the workers were on the side of the protesters and against the communists. In fact, the television anchor who delivered news of the strike simultaneously announced that he was joining it.

8.48 The Communist Party officially abandoned power the next day. By the end of 1989, Havel would be sworn in as president of Czechoslovakia, and Dubcek would be chairman of the Parliament. Additionally, all five of the Warsaw Pact Nations who had taken part in the 1968 invasion of Czechoslovakia officially renounced and condemned their past actions. The Velvet Revolution ended in forgiveness and peace. By 1992, the Czech and Slovak peoples would come to realize they preferred to go their own way, and the Velvet Revolution gave way to the Velvet Divorce. After some intense negotiations, the country Czechoslovakia was dissolved at the end of 1992 and birthed the nations of Slovakia and the Czech Republic.

8.49 But as Czechoslovakia chose to separate, the two Germanies chose to reunify. The Berlin Wall had been a political dam, and when it fell, the fortunes of the East German Communist Party fell with it. Egon Krenz only managed to last 46 days in office, as decades of hatred for the East German government spilled out into the open without fear of repercussions. By the end, the head of the Stasi, Erich Mielke, was reduced to being openly booed in parliament, an 81-year-old dinosaur blubbering, "I love you all. I love all human beings."

8.50 The Stasi went from absolute power to absolute impotence. On December 4th, 1989, the protesters took the Stasi building. The guards asked to see their papers as they entered the building, and the protesters complied before seizing and occupying it, sitting nervously in the hallways of the agency that had spied on them all. Desperate to maintain some semblance of power, East German Party members proceeded to do everything possible to blame their predecessors for the oppression. The party's name was changed from the Socialist Unity Party to the Party of Democratic Socialism. Mielke was stripped of his party card, as were Honecker, Schabowski, and Krenz.

8.51 Krenz was eventually arrested and imprisoned for a few years for his crimes. Schabowski only received one year before receiving a pardon due to his consistent public recantation of his past actions. Mielke became Germany's oldest prisoner before being released after several years due to senile dementia. He ended his days in a

nursing home, having imaginary conversations with Stasi officers on a telephone that wasn't even plugged in. Honecker spent his remaining few years in a constant battle against both cancer and prosecution before passing away in 1994. As for Margot, the witch got on her broom and escaped to Chile. There, she survived unapologetic and unrepentant until the age of 89 before returning to hell in 2016.

- 8.52** But of all the Warsaw Pact countries, it was Romania that was most determined to stay on its unique path while the nations surrounding it overthrew their Communist governments, one after another. News of the unrest had breached even Ceausescu's borders, but Nicolae and Elena weren't going anywhere. Ceausescu held a rally in Bucharest on December 21st, 1989. His goons packed the audience with the most reliable Romanians they could find. The speech would reassure the country that Ceausescu remained in control and was as popular as ever. A few minutes after he began to speak, boos from the crowd began. The moment where Ceausescu realized the crowd was against him, the second he paused and looked confused at the impossible becoming real, was broadcast live throughout Romania, and then the screen went blank.
- 8.53** When the stations resumed broadcasting, they showed the crowds and the chaos. Ceausescu huddled with his henchmen and Elena for an entire day as rioting broke out. The army, used to orders from Ceausescu, waited in their barracks as the unrest spread. Twenty-four hours after his rally, the Ceausescus fled to the roof where a helicopter had just landed for them. There were several countries which they could escape to, and they had hundreds of millions of dollars stashed away in Swiss bank accounts.
- 8.54** Ceausescu ordered the pilot to take them to their palace in the town of Snagov and tried to get in touch with the secret police. Once there, Ceausescu worked the phones, trying to figure out which parts of the country remained in his control. The pilot insisted the helicopter couldn't hold that many people, took off without the Prime Minister and Deputy Prime Minister, and they made their way to the town of Pitesti. He told Ceausescu that the helicopter had been spotted by radar and that they could be shot down at any moment. Ceausescu told the pilot to land in the field close by a road, and the pilot abandoned the Ceausescus there with their bodyguards. One of the bodyguards flagged down a car and the three of them squeezed in.
- 8.55** Now the Ceausescus were on the lam. How do you hide when, for decades, your face had been broadcast every day to everyone in the whole country? Eventually, the Ceausescus were caught. When he was brought into custody, Ceausescu still thought he was commander-in-chief. He didn't realize he'd been taken into custody as a prisoner. For two days, he and Elena harangued their captor about everything, including the food, the bathroom accommodations, and the clothes that they were given.

- 8.56** Shortly before midnight on the 24th of December, the militia building where they were being held captive came under fire from troops from the secret police. The prisoners were taken to an armored car where they had to hide on the floor for five hours while gunfire was exchanged, and eventually, the secret police were beaten back. It was clear to the soldiers that time was of the essence. It was decided to put the couple on trial then and there.
- 8.57** A classroom in a nearby school was hastily set up to serve as the court. The defense attorney was given 10 minutes to confer with his clients. Ceausescu insisted that "I do not recognize this court," not entirely unreasonably, and that "I refuse to answer those who have fomented this coup d'état. I'm the president of the republic. I'm your commander-in-chief." The couple was charged with genocide, organizing armed action against the people, destruction of public assets, sabotage, and attempting to flee the country with funds of more than \$1 billion.
- 8.58** At one point, the prosecutor even stopped to ask Elena if she was mentally defective. "Let's get this over with," said Ceausescu. The trial took less than an hour, and after a five-minute recess, the judges returned to the courtroom and delivered a verdict of death. As the Ceausescus had their hands tied with rope, Ceausescu insisted that "Romania will live and learn of your treachery." Under Romanian law, a death sentence could only be carried out 10 days after a verdict had been delivered. For a brief period, the couple still felt somewhat secure.
- 8.59** Now, there's often a question as to whether dictators like the Ceausescus believe their own bullshit. And in Elena's case, that definitely seems to have been the case. She yelled at the soldiers, "I brought you up like a mother." And one of them told her, "Lady, you're in real trouble." Her reply has either been translated as, "You keep away from me, you motherfucker," or "Go fuck your mother," which was a very unfortunate choice of words given what she had said to them moments prior. It was only when the Ceausescus were taken outside to the school courtyard, and not see a helicopter waiting to return them to Bucharest, that the two of them realized what was going to happen.
- 8.60** "Look," Elena said, "they're going to shoot us like dogs." The couple were placed against the wall, and then the soldiers proved the bitch correct. There were over 100 bullets shot in total by the time they stopped firing the AK-47s at the Ceausescus. As usual, it was bitterly cold in Romania that winter day, with the temperature not even reaching 45 degrees in the capital city of Bucharest. And though no snow fell, it didn't seem to make much of a difference. That day, December 25th, 1989, was still the best Christmas that the Romanian people ever had.
- 8.61** Part of Gorbachev's reordering of the Soviet Union's political structure allowed for other alternative voices to emerge. The best example of this was someone named Boris Yeltsin. At the end of 1985, Yeltsin was appointed first secretary of Moscow city committee, which is roughly like being the mayor, despite his reputation for having a

fondness for the bottle. Tensions between Yeltsin and Gorbachev, as well as Yeltsin and the Communist Party, eventually spilled out into public. In late 1987, Yeltsin made a speech calling out Gorbachev, the Communist Party, and perestroika itself for good measure. Not only that, he quit the politburo in the guise of giving all the leaders of the Soviet Union an ultimatum. It was the most head-on assault of the power of the General Secretary since the days of Trotsky.

8.62 But Yeltsin's speech was seen less as an act of integrity than of one of ambition. Things reached a low shortly thereafter in the morning of November 9th, 1987, where Yeltsin was found covered in blood. Gorbachev recounted how Yeltsin later claimed that he'd been mugged and fought off his attackers, and of course, he had tossed them around like kittens, but still he had received a knife wound. "By then, I had already discovered Yeltsin's talent for fiction." In reality, the wound was clearly self-inflicted, possibly a suicide attempt. Gorbachev explained that the doctor said the wound was not critical at all. The scissors by slipping over his ribs, had left a bloody but superficial wound. And in Yeltsin's defense, this could have occurred during in one of his drunken stupors.

8.63 Years later, it was Bill Clinton's turn to deal with Yeltsin's hijinks. As Clinton told an author at the time, he had received notice of a predawn security alarm when secret service agents discovered Yeltsin on Pennsylvania Avenue, dead drunk, clad in his underwear, yelling for a taxi. Yeltsin slurred his words in a loud argument with the baffled agents. He did not want to go back into Blair House where he was staying. He wanted a taxi to go out for pizza. I asked Clinton what became of the standoff? Well, the President said, shrugging, "He got his pizza."

8.64 Gorbachev called Yeltsin in the hospital, demanded he discuss his speech with the Moscow city committee. Yeltsin said he couldn't, that the doctors wouldn't even let him get up. And Gorbachev said, "That's OK, the doctors will help you." They pumped Yeltsin full of sedatives and sent him on to meet his fate. For four hours, Yeltsin was berated by two dozen speakers before admitting his guilt and accepting his dismissal. But while he lost his political position, he nevertheless became a symbol of the Soviet people's distaste with the system, the same system Gorbachev was trying to reform and salvage.

8.65 On September 16th, 1989, Yeltsin was in America visiting the Johnson Space Center in Texas, and then he took an unscheduled visit to a Randalls supermarket in Houston. The supermarket is still there. He was told that the store stocked over 30,000 items, while the typical Soviet store ostensibly carried fewer than 100, but in practice often had bare shelves. It would have seemed like ridiculous pro-American propaganda, but Yeltsin was witnessing it all with his own eyes. Average American citizens could buy things that were out of reach of the wealthiest Soviet citizens. The conquest of bread had been won by the West.

8.66 And as Yeltsin flew on to Miami, he clutched his head in his hands because his brain was rewiring itself of decades of being told things that were not true. He understood

that those saying such things weren't just misinformed, not to this extent. They were knowingly, brazenly, lying for decades, or at least completely indifferent to the truth. They had to fool the people, he realized. It's now clear why they made it so difficult for the average citizen from Soviet Union to go abroad. They were afraid that people's eyes would open.

- 8.67** As Yeltsin ascended in power, the Soviet government itself began to lose power as the sole decision-making body. The Republic of Lithuania held elections in February 1990, and the vote led to a supreme council issuing a declaration that Lithuania was a sovereign state, free of Soviet rule. Gorbachev declared the act null and void. He implemented an economic blockade against the small Baltic nation, but Lithuania was not East Germany or Hungary. It was still part of the USSR and still under his purview. From his perspective, there was a process for secession, and that secession would have to be through a referendum. Inflation in Lithuania hit 100%. Nevertheless, the authorities in Lithuania persisted.
- 8.68** And in May 1990, Yeltsin was elected chairman of Russia's parliament. And in doing so, he represented the republic, the Russian republic, that contained half of the USSR's population, 76% of its land, and 90% of Soviet oil production. The Russians finally did this time send in the tanks. On January 11, 1991, Russian troops fired in a crowd of protesters in Lithuania, killing over a dozen, wounding many more. The Soviets claimed that the protesters shot first, but their story was instantly debunked by foreign reporters who were there. Now, thousands of unarmed Lithuanians took to surrounding their parliament building around the clock to protect their government against further Soviet aggression.
- 8.69** Gorbachev claimed this was all done without his knowledge or his permission, and years later, tried to figure out who gave the order to use force. In either case, he was either complicit or powerless to stop it. Other nations condemned the USSR in no uncertain terms, and within weeks, Iceland officially recognized the Republic of Lithuania. Five days after that, the Lithuanian government did have a referendum, and 90% of the votes were cast in order for Lithuania to remain independent. Now, the idea of secession quickly spread throughout the other Soviet republics.
- 8.70** On March 31st, 1991, Georgia held a referendum on independence. Over 99% of the voters chose to leave the Soviet Union. Then Yeltsin got another promotion in June. He became elected president of Russia with almost 59% of the vote. His closest rival, Gorbachev's choice, only got 16%. There was now a president of Russia, Yeltsin, and a president of the Soviet Union, Gorbachev. Who was in charge of whom was an increasingly difficult question to answer. Those who had most to lose were men like Vladimir Kryuchkov, who was head of the KGB. The USSR was falling apart and those in power weren't going down without a fight. Kryuchkov spent weeks getting his allies prepared. When Gorbachev left Moscow for his Crimean dacha on August 4th, 1991, the plotters began to get their plan in order.

- 8.71** On August 18th, he was informed that a group of comrades was there to see him. Not expecting anyone, Gorbachev told his security team that he was livid, that they let people get this close. Gorbachev gave instructions to have them wait. He picked up a phone to make a call, only to find the line was dead. He picked up a second phone, then a third, then a fourth. All the lines were dead. Finally, Gorbachev picked up the cover for the red phone to be used in the event of a nuclear attack on the USSR, a phone so important that no one was even permitted to touch it, even to dust it. But it, too, was dead. Gorbachev understood that a coup was underway.
- 8.72** He went outside to discuss the matter with his wife, Raisa. She was a highly educated woman, and she understood how dangerous a situation the two of them were in. When he returned to his study, he was greeted by five elite Soviet officials. The men were nervous, and he was livid. He began interrogating them what was going on, and they explained to him they came as representatives of an emergency committee and rattled off a list of members, men who had owed their positions to Gorbachev, men that he had considered trustworthy. They said Yeltsin was on the verge of arrest as well. They gave Gorbachev two options, either to declare a state of emergency or to transfer his power to vice president Yanayev, who had joined his name to the coup.
- 8.73** Gorbachev told them, "To hell with you." "Mikhael Sergeevich," his chief of staff, said, "you don't understand what the situation in the country is." "Shut up, you prick. How dare you give me lectures about the situation in the country." The men flew back to Moscow, rattled by the meeting. The following day, the Russian media issued the plotters' declaration that, due to Gorbachev's state of health, the vice president was now assuming the responsibilities of the president in accordance with the Constitution.
- 8.74** Yeltsin was awakened to news of the coup by his youngest daughter, and like many other Russians, was completely baffled by what this proclamation meant. He tried to call Yanayev, and Yanayev refused to speak with him. And when Yeltsin tried to call Gorbachev, the call couldn't get through. Now, for all of his escapades, Yeltsin was no fool. A few weeks earlier, he had bonded with a high-ranking general named Pavel Grachev over bottles of vodka. He said, "If our lawfully elected government in Russia were ever threatened, terrorist act, coup d'état, efforts to arrest the leaders, could the military be relied on? Could you be relied on?" "Yes," Grachev said. At that moment, Yeltsin called Grachev to remind him of that conversation, and though Yeltsin didn't realize it, Grachev's fingerprints were all over the coup.
- 8.75** He stammered about needing to obey his superiors before decency got the better of him, and he told Yeltsin that he'd send him a security detachment. As recently as 1989, copy machines in the Soviet Union were locked up by law, but this was 1991, and members of the coup were acting as if they could still somehow control the flow of information. Yeltsin issued a statement denouncing the coup in no uncertain words, and his faxed declaration was then disseminated throughout the world. Putting on a bulletproof vest, he got into his limo and began to ride to his office in Moscow's White

House. On his way to the government building, he passed hundreds of armored vehicles. When he got to the White House, he was greeted by a crowd of journalists who were themselves outnumbered by all the citizens there. He announced that at least 50 tanks are on their way to this building.

8.76 When the tanks eventually arrived, Yeltsin went back down to greet them. He approached one tank and posed for pictures while shaking the hands of its commander. He joked, "Apparently, they're not going to shoot the president of Russia just yet." In the Soviet Union, dark humor was like food. Not everybody got it. But in this case, they got it. And so did everyone watching the scenes unfolding on television across the world. And back at Gorbachev's dacha, Raisa, his wife, was a bit more fearful than Yeltsin seemed to be. They had Gorbachev's transistor radio. When Raisa heard the announcement that Gorbachev was supposedly being deposed due to bad health, she understood this might not be a lie as much as a threat. She hid food so the family would have something to eat and refused to serve anything that hadn't come prepackaged. As she later put it, "We all knew our history."

8.77 Desperate to get his message out, Gorbachev recorded a speech discussing what had happened and claiming that he remained in good health. He repeated it four times and cut the tape into four sections. He gave one section to his personal secretary, his doctor, and to an aide, and kept the fourth for himself. This was his insurance that the truth would be heard if the worst came to pass. For his part, Yeltsin did not acknowledge the coup's legal authority and proceeded to govern accordingly. He issued warrants for the arrests the plotters. He declared himself commander-in-chief of Soviet troops on Russian soil and called an emergency session of Russian parliament and suspended the communist party.

8.78 As for the plotters, they sat down to plan for storming of the White House. At 3 AM, on August 21st, Operation Thunder was set to begin. Things were going to get very violent, very quickly. Grachev kept true to his word and told the Russian leaders that the building was going to be attacked. He suggested getting a crowd of citizens around the building, thinking the military would be very unlikely to shoot civilians. And soon the streets around the White House were filled with tens of thousands of locals, just as Tiananmen Square had been a little over two years prior.

8.79 And that night, Yeltsin took to the airwaves asking for the people's support. At 11 PM, thousands remained in the streets defying the curfew decreed by the plotters. The alpha group, tasked with storming the White House, had that name with good reason. They had personally led the Soviet assault on the Lithuanian facilities not that long ago. And the leader of them asked his men what they thought. And one of his team told him, "We will not go to the White House to kill people." And he replied, "And we will not lead you there." Grachev had a quick discussion with the head of the air force, and he had the same conclusion. Let's just sit by our phones and try to avert any stupidities.

- 8.80** Thousands of lives were saved because strongmen with guns defied their orders and chose peace over force. For hours, Kryuchkov was befuddled by Grachev's men weren't clearing the way for the alpha group to storm the White House. At 2 AM, he got the call. The army wasn't going to do anything. He's on his own. Voices were raised, fingers were pointed. By the end, there was little else that the plotters could do. Soviet citizens woke up to hear the news that they were sending a delegation to visit Gorbachev and check on his health. Raisa thought this was it. She began racking her brain, thinking where her husband could hide. In her panic, she suffered a minor stroke, leaving her mute and partially paralyzed for several hours.
- 8.81** When they arrived, a few hours, Gorbachev refused to speak with them, demanding his phones be restored before he would talk. The message came back that this would take a great deal of time. "I'm not in a hurry to go anywhere," he told them. It took almost two hours, and his first priority was to make calls to officials at home and abroad about what had transpired. At 8 PM, a delegation from the Russian government arrived, and Gorbachev met with them immediately. It was a joyous reunion. After tears and some arguing, they agreed on the next steps.
- 8.82** Late that night, the bulk of the plotters were separated from Kryuchkov and flown to Moscow on their own. Kryuchkov was seated in the back of the Russians' plane alongside a general who was an aide to the Russian vice president. After Gorbachev, his family, and the Russian officials got off the flight, he moved to follow them. "Wait a little bit," he was told. When he tried to get up again, he was told again, "Stay seated." "I think I understand what's happening," Kryuchkov said. "You have understood correctly." Vladimir Kryuchkov, the last functional member of the KGB, was thereupon arrested and alongside his accomplices, charged with high treason. His KGB successor didn't even last 100 days before dissolving the organization. And he declared, "The traditions of Chekism must be eradicated."
- 8.83** Gorbachev returned to work the following day. In the past 48 hours, sensing the chaos in the USSR, Latvia and Estonia had both taken the opportunity to affirm their sovereignty as independent nations, just as Lithuania had done. But Gorbachev had a more pressing concern. He was told that documents were being destroyed at an intensive rate at the communist party central committee building as a mob besieged the structure. He immediately signed an order suspending any activity in the building, and the good communists, obedient to authority, stopped what they were doing and peacefully evacuated.
- 8.84** Gorbachev and Yeltsin soon appeared together at the White House and announced a decree suspending the Communist Party. "At the time of its demise," wrote one historian, "it had 15 million members. Not a single one of them put up any resistance." Dobbs, the historian's name is Dobbs. As he put it further, "For seven decades after the 1917 revolution, the Communist Party had deliberately cultivated a sense of mystery as a key to maintaining its own power. Separated from the people, they ruled by a wall of

ritual, party leaders acquired an aura of omniscience and aloofness. Scarcely anything was known about their private lives or personal political views. No ordinary mortal was allowed to know how these bureaucratic supermen acquired their fine clothes, what kinds of books and films they enjoyed, or how they made a seemingly miraculous appearance on top of Lenin's tomb in Red Square on public holidays."

- 8.85** As the mysteries were gradually explained, the party's grip over society was automatically undermined. Now the final curtain was ripped away to reveal a group of frightened and rather unremarkable people more intent on saving themselves than the regime they served. A few days later, Belarus declared its independence, and Azerbaijan did so as well. And one week later, on September 6, 1991, the Soviet Union officially acknowledged Lithuania's independence. Armenia, two weeks after that, declared its independence.
- 8.86** And on December 1st, 1991, Ukraine held a referendum. 92% of Ukrainian voters chose to secede from the Soviet Union. On December 8th, 1991, Yeltsin, working behind the scenes with the leaders of Belarus and Ukraine, issued a decree that "the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics is ceasing its existence as a subject of international law and a geopolitical reality." Both Russia and Ukraine were officially seceding from the USSR.
- 8.87** When Gorbachev took over as the leader of the Soviet Union in 1985, he'd been the youngest leader since Stalin. But by 1991, he was already an old man from another time. On Christmas Day, 1991, Gorbachev resigned his position as president of the Soviet Union. And at 7:35 PM, the hammer and sickle flag of the USSR was permanently lowered from the Kremlin. The following day, the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics, now a government without a country, officially voted itself out of existence.
- 8.88** In 1981, the overwhelming expert consensus had been one of détente. The premise was that a communist USSR and a democratic USA would rule the world for decades to come. The corrupt and decaying USSR wasn't going anywhere. Few of the experts ever admitted that they had been wrong, that they'd been wrong the entire time, that they were the ones who were naive and unrealistic. Within 10 years, the Soviet Union went from being a perpetual world-dominating superpower to literal nonexistence and is now becoming a forgotten chapter of world history. More of a kitschy joke than a cautionary tale.
- 8.89** Millions of people were trapped for decades in countries where human life meant nothing. They lived in constant terror from morning until night, and at night, they were waiting for the doorbell to ring in countries where there was no law or any rights of any kind. Did they all live happily ever after when the Soviet Union dissolved? Of course not. Utopias don't exist, but progress does, and so do victories by good over evil. They happen all the time, both personally and politically.
- 8.90** The foes of liberty are many, and they are powerful, but they are not particularly impressive. They are not all-knowing, they are not all-powerful, they're often not even

particularly bright. They are men and women, far closer to snakes than they are to gods. They can, will, and have been defeated many, many times. So the next time someone tells you that the victory of good over evil, the victory of freedom over tyranny, is ridiculous or utopian or naive, remind them of the story of the rise and fall of the Soviet Union. Thank you.